



Kiribati



Situated in the mid-Pacific, the islands adopted the name Kiribati (pronounced “Keer-ee-bus,” a corruption of their former name “Gilberts”) upon independence from Britain in 1979.



GEOGRAPHY

Kiribati consists of three groups of tiny, very low-lying coral atolls scattered across 1,930,000 sq. miles (5 million sq. km) of ocean. Most of the 33 atolls have central lagoons.



CLIMATE

Central islands have a maritime equatorial climate. Those to north and south are tropical, with constant high temperatures. There is little rainfall.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Officially I-Kiribati, many local people still refer to themselves as Gilbertese. Almost all are Micronesian, apart from the inhabitants of the island of Banaba, who employed anthropologists to establish their racial distinction. Most people are poor subsistence farmers and many travel abroad to work. The islands are effectively ruled by traditional chiefs.



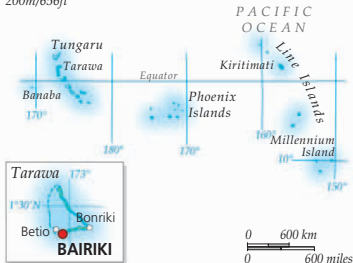
THE ECONOMY

Since exhaustion of Banaba's phosphate deposits in 1980, copra (dried coconut) and fish have become the main exports. Foreign aid and remittances are vital to compensate for Kiribati's isolation and lack of resources.



INSIGHT: In 1981, the UK paid A\$10 million to Banabans for the destruction of their island by mining

All land under
200m/656ft



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Kiribati

DATE OF FORMATION: 1979

CAPITAL: Bairiki (Tarawa Atoll)

POPULATION: 99,000

TOTAL AREA: 277 sq. miles
(717 sq. km)

DENSITY: 361 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Kiribati

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 53%,
Kiribati Protestant Church 39%,
other 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Micronesian 99%,
other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Nonparty system

CURRENCY: Australian dollar = 100 cents

North Korea



Separated from the democratic South by the world's most heavily defended border, the Stalinist North Korean state has been isolated from the outside world since 1948.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly mountainous, with fertile plains in the southwest.



CLIMATE

Continental. Warm summers and cold winters, especially in the north, where snow is common.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Life is heavily regulated. Cult of personality is more powerful than the state-controlled religions, which include Korea's own Chondogyo. Women are expected to work and to run the home. Children are looked after in state-run crèches. The Korean Worker's Party is the sole party. Its elite have a privileged lifestyle. Globally condemned for its nuclear weapons development, its grip on power perpetuates its pariah status.



INSIGHT: Only the political elite are allowed phones and private cars



THE ECONOMY

Minerals are only resource. Vital aid streams lost with global collapse of communism after 1989. Decades of economic mismanagement have led to chronic food shortages. Lack of fuel. Disproportionate defense budget.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Democratic People's Republic of Korea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1948

CAPITAL: Pyongyang

POPULATION: 23.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 46,540 sq. miles
(120,540 sq. km)

DENSITY: 514 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Korean*, Chinese

RELIGIONS: Government-controlled religions include Chondogyo, Buddhism, and Christianity

ETHNIC MIX: Korean 100%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: N. Korean won = 100 chon



South Korea

South Korea occupies the southern half of the Korean peninsula. Under US sponsorship, it was separated from the communist North in 1948 and is now a capitalist economy.



GEOGRAPHY

Over 80% is mountainous and two-thirds is forested. The flattest and most populous parts lie along the west coast and in the extreme south.



CLIMATE

There are four distinct seasons. Winters are dry, and bitterly cold. Summers are hot and humid.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Inhabited for the last 2000 years by a single ethnic group. The nuclear family is replacing traditional extended households. Since the 1953 armistice, the Koreans have remained technically at war. Reunification is the ultimate goal, but in 2009 the South became less conciliatory and the North retaliated by ending its offer of cooperation.



INSIGHT: Half of all Koreans are named Kim, Lee, Park, or Choi



THE ECONOMY

World's biggest shipbuilder. High-tech goods and cars: rising demand from China. Strong regional competition. Aging population.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Korea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1948

CAPITAL: Seoul

POPULATION: 48.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 38,023 sq. miles
(98,480 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1268 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Korean*, Chinese

RELIGIONS: Mahayana Buddhist 47%, Protestant 38%, Roman Catholic 11%, Confucianist 3%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Korean 100%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: South Korean won = 100 chon

Kosovo



Once part of the former Yugoslav state, Kosovo seceded from Serbia in 2008. International recognition, mainly from Western countries, is strongly opposed by Serbia and Russia.



GEOGRAPHY

Landlocked and mountainous, with two plains in the east and west.



CLIMATE

Continental, with warm, sunny summers and cold, snowy winters.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The balance of Albanians to Serbs in Kosovo has changed dramatically over centuries, both groups suffering interethnic violence at various times. Attacks against Albanians in the late 1990s caused a million to flee. After NATO stepped in, many Serbs left: Albanians now form a 92% majority. Most Albanians are Muslim. Serbs dominate three northern provinces, which have threatened to secede.



INSIGHT: *The UN administered Kosovo in 1999–2008 after NATO intervention to stop Serb ethnic cleansing*



THE ECONOMY

One of the two poorest countries in Europe. Aid and remittances cover a large trade deficit. Organized crime: smuggling of fuel, cigarettes, and cement. Uncertain status deters foreign investors. High unemployment. Use of euro has kept inflation low. Lignite deposits. Inefficient agriculture.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Kosovo

DATE OF FORMATION: 2008

CAPITAL: Pristina

POPULATION: 2.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 4212 sq. miles
(10,908 sq. km)

DENSITY: 499 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Albanian*, Serbian*, Bosniak, Gorani, Roma, Turkish

RELIGIONS: Muslim 92%, Roman Catholic 4%, Orthodox Christian 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Albanian 92%, Serb 4%, Bosniak and Gorani 2%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents



Kuwait



Kuwait lies at the northwest tip of the Gulf, dwarfed by its neighbors Iraq, Iran, and Saudi Arabia. It was a British protectorate until 1961, when full independence was granted.



GEOGRAPHY

Terrain is low-lying desert. The lowest land is in the north. Cultivation is only possible along the coast.



CLIMATE

Summers are very hot and dry. Winters are cooler, with some rain and occasional frost at night.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Oil-rich monarchy, ruled by the al-Sabah family. It is a conservative Sunni Muslim society, but women are relatively free. Nonetheless, a 1999 decree giving women the vote was blocked for six years in parliament by Islamic traditionalists. Immigrant workers, from other Arab states, India, and Pakistan, now outnumber native citizens. US-led forces rescued Kuwait after the 1990 Iraqi invasion, and later used it as a launchpad for the 2003 invasion to oust Saddam Hussein.



THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas dominate the economy. Skilled workforce, raw materials, and food are imported. High standard of living. Financial services: stock market lost 40% of value in 2008.



INSIGHT: During the 1991 Gulf War, Iraq deliberately set fire to 800 of Kuwait's 950 oil wells



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: State of Kuwait

DATE OF FORMATION: 1961

CAPITAL: Kuwait City

POPULATION: 2.99 million

TOTAL AREA: 6880 sq. miles
(17,820 sq. km)

DENSITY: 434 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, English

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 45%, Shi'a Muslim 40%, Christian, Hindu, and other 15%

ETHNIC MIX: Kuwaiti 45%, other Arab 35%, South Asian 9%, other 11%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Kuwaiti dinar = 1000 fils

Kyrgyzstan



A small and mountainous landlocked state in central Asia, Kyrgyzstan is one of the least urbanized ex-Soviet republics, and was slow to develop its own sense of cultural identity.



GEOGRAPHY

The mountainous spurs of the Tien Shan range contain glaciers, alpine meadows, forests, and narrow valleys. Semidesert in the west.



CLIMATE

Varies from permanent snow and cold deserts at high altitudes, to hot deserts in low regions.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnic Kyrgyz have only been in the majority since the late 1980s – due to a high birth rate and the emigration of ethnic Russians. Wary of losing skills vital to the economy, the government has attempted to deter Russians from leaving; concessions include making Russian an official language. There are some tensions between Kyrgyz and Uzbeks, and a trend toward greater Islamization, particularly in the poorer south.



THE ECONOMY

Mainly still under state control; corruption issues. Agriculture employs half of the labor force. Cotton, wool, meat, and tobacco exports. Mercury, gold, and antimony are mined. Great potential for hydroelectric power.



INSIGHT: Kyrgyz folklore is based around the 1000-year-old poem, *Manas*, which takes a week to recite



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kyrgyz Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Bishkek

POPULATION: 5.48 million

TOTAL AREA: 76,641 sq. miles
(198,500 sq. km)

DENSITY: 72 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kyrgyz*, Russian*, other

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 70%,
Orthodox Christian 30%

ETHNIC MIX: Kyrgyz 65%, Uzbek 14%,
Russian 13%, other 6%, Dungan 1%,
Ukrainian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Som = 100 tyiyn



Laos

A French colony prior to 1953, Laos lies landlocked in southeast Asia. Heavily bombed during the Vietnam War, it fell in 1975 to communist insurgents, whose regime remains in power.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Largely forested mountains, broadening in the north to a plateau. Lowlands along the Mekong Valley.

**CLIMATE**

Monsoon rains September–May. The rest of the year is hot and dry.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

There are over 60 ethnic groups. Lowland Laotians (Lao Loum) live along the Mekong River and are rice farmers. Upland and highland Laotians (Lao Theung and Lao Soung) traditionally employ environmentally damaging slash-and-burn farming, and grow illegal cash crops (notably opium). Government efforts to reform these practices are resisted.



INSIGHT: *Three small Laotian kingdoms were unified under French control in 1899*

**THE ECONOMY**

One of world's least developed nations. Poor infrastructure. Gold, copper, electricity, timber, garments, and coffee are exported. Levels of foreign investment are rising.

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Lao People's Democratic Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1953

CAPITAL: Vientiane

POPULATION: 6.32 million

TOTAL AREA: 91,428 sq. miles (236,800 sq. km)

DENSITY: 71 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Lao*, Mon-Khmer, other

RELIGIONS: Buddhist 85%, other (including animist) 15%

ETHNIC MIX: Lao Loum 66%, Lao Theung 30%, Lao Soung 2%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: New kip = 100 at

Latvia



Latvia lies on the east coast of the Baltic Sea. Like its Baltic neighbors, it regained independence from Moscow in 1991, and joined the EU and NATO in 2004.



GEOGRAPHY

A flat coastal plain which is deeply indented by the Gulf of Riga. Poor drainage creates many bogs and swamps in the forested interior.



CLIMATE

Temperate, with warm summers and cold winters. There is steady rainfall throughout the year.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Latvians make up just over half of the population and are mostly Lutheran. They have been officially favored by the state since 1991 over the largely Orthodox Christian Russian minority. Latvian was declared the only official language in 2000 and has been used exclusively in schools since 2004. This discrimination has strained relations with neighboring Russia. Women enjoy full equality. The divorce rate is high.



THE ECONOMY

Services sector now accounts for over 70% of GDP. EU's fastest-growing economy in 2004–2006. High inflation has delayed prospect of joining euro. Global credit crunch brought Latvia to verge of bankruptcy in 2008: banks were bailed out and severe recession followed.



INSIGHT: Ethnic Latvians are outnumbered by Russians in Riga



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Latvia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Riga

POPULATION: 2.25 million

TOTAL AREA: 24,938 sq. miles
(64,589 sq. km)

DENSITY: 90 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Latvian*, Russian

RELIGIONS: Lutheran 55%, Catholic 24%, other 12%, Orthodox Christian 9%

ETHNIC MIX: Latvian 59%, Russian 29%, Belarussian 4%, Ukrainian 3%, Polish 3%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Lats = 100 santimi



Lebanon

Once a vibrant cultural hotspot, Lebanon suffered badly from years of civil war and occupation until a 1989 peace deal. Reconstruction was reversed by Israeli bombardment in 2006.



GEOGRAPHY

Behind a narrow Mediterranean coastal plain, two parallel mountain ranges run the length of the country, separated by the fertile Beqaa Valley.



CLIMATE

Winters are mild and summers are hot, with high coastal humidity. Snow falls on high ground in winter.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Politics has long been dominated by divisions between Sunni and Shi'a Muslims and the traditional ruling Maronite Christians. Power-sharing ended 14 years of civil war in 1989. Syria acted as power broker until made to withdraw in 2005. Israel attacked in 2006 in a botched bid to crush Iranian-backed Hezbollah militants. A huge gulf exists between the poor and a small, immensely rich elite. Lebanon hosts 420,000 Palestinian refugees.



THE ECONOMY

Much infrastructure destroyed. Instability undermines Beirut's role as regional financial center. Wine and fruit production. High public debt.



INSIGHT: *The Cedar of Lebanon has been the nation's symbol for more than 2000 years*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Lebanon

DATE OF FORMATION: 1941

CAPITAL: Beirut

POPULATION: 4.22 million

TOTAL AREA: 4015 sq. miles
(10,400 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1069 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, French,
Armenian, Assyrian

RELIGIONS: Muslim 70%,
Christian 30%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 94%, Armenian 4%,
other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Lebanese pound = 100 piastres

Lesotho



The landlocked Kingdom of Lesotho is entirely surrounded by – and economically dependent on – South Africa, which even sent in troops to restore calm after rioting in 1998.



GEOGRAPHY

A high mountainous plateau, cut by valleys and ravines. The Maluti Range runs through the center. The Drakensberg Range lies to the east.



CLIMATE

Temperate. Summers are hot with torrential rain storms. Snow is frequent in the mountains in winter.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The overwhelming majority of people are Sotho, though there are some South Asians, Europeans, and Chinese. A strong sense of national identity has tended to minimize ethnic tensions. Many men work as migrant laborers in South Africa, leaving women to run households.



INSIGHT: Lesotho has one of the highest literacy rates in Africa – but one of the highest rates of HIV/AIDS too



THE ECONOMY

Dependent on South Africa. Water and energy exported from new Highlands Water Scheme. Subsistence farming. Garment exports struggle to compete. HIV/AIDS is depleting workforce.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Lesotho

DATE OF FORMATION: 1966

CAPITAL: Maseru

POPULATION: 2.07 million

TOTAL AREA: 11,720 sq. miles
(30,355 sq. km)

DENSITY: 176 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Sesotho*, isiZulu

RELIGIONS: Christian 90%,
traditional beliefs 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Sotho 97%, European
and Asian 3%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Loti = 100 lisente



Liberia



Liberia, on Africa's Atlantic coast, was founded as a republic of freed slaves. A brutal coup in 1980 and years of civil war have left gang violence and looting widespread.



GEOGRAPHY

A coastline of beaches and mangrove swamps rises to forested plateaus and highlands inland.



CLIMATE

High temperatures. There is only one wet season, from May to October, except in the extreme southeast.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The key social distinction used to be between Americo-Liberians – descendants of freed slaves – and the indigenous tribal peoples. However, political assimilation and intermarriage have eased tensions. Intertribal tension is now a much more serious problem, fueling the civil war which ravaged the country from 1990 to 2003.



INSIGHT: *Liberia is named after the people liberated from slavery who arrived from the US in the 1800s*



THE ECONOMY

War caused economic collapse. Rubber is key export. Bans now lifted on timber and diamond exports. Revenue from merchant shipping licenses. Debt burden. Income well below prewar levels. Vast iron ore reserves.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Liberia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1847

CAPITAL: Monrovia

POPULATION: 3.96 million

TOTAL AREA: 43,000 sq. miles
(111,370 sq. km)

DENSITY: 106 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kpelle, Vai, Bassa, Kru, Grebo, Kissi, Gola, Loma, English*

RELIGIONS: Christian 68%, traditional beliefs 18%, Muslim 14%

ETHNIC MIX: Indigenous tribes (16 main groups) 95%, Americo-Liberians 5%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Liberian dollar = 100 cents

Libya



Situated on north Africa's Mediterranean coast, Libya was declared a revolutionary state in 1969 by Colonel Gaddafi, who promotes Islam, African unity, and a communal lifestyle.



GEOGRAPHY

Apart from the coastal strip and a mountain range in the south, Libya is desert or semidesert. Natural oases provide the agricultural land.



CLIMATE

Hot and arid. The coastal area has a temperate climate, with mild, wet winters and hot, dry summers.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Libyans are of Arab and Berber origin. Once a nation of nomads and livestock herders, it is almost 80% urban. Revolution wiped out private enterprise and the middle classes. Jews and European settlers were banished. Years of political marginalization and sanctions ended after Libya offered compensation for terrorist bombings. The voluntary ending of its Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMD) program was also welcomed by the West.

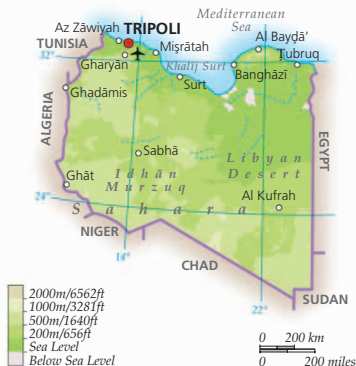


THE ECONOMY

Oil is key export. Dates, olives, and fruit grow in oases, but most food is imported. Corruption and mismanagement. High inflation.



INSIGHT: 90% of Libya is still desert, despite grand irrigation projects



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Great Socialist People's Libyan Arab Jamahariyah

DATE OF FORMATION: 1951

CAPITAL: Tripoli

POPULATION: 6.42 million

TOTAL AREA: 679,358 sq. miles
(1,759,540 sq. km)

DENSITY: 9 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, Tuareg

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 97%,
other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab and Berber 95%,
other 5%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: Libyan dinar = 1000 dirhams



Liechtenstein

Perched in the Alps between Switzerland and Austria, the state of Liechtenstein became an independent principality of the Holy Roman Empire in 1719. It has close links with Switzerland.



GEOGRAPHY

The upper Rhine Valley covers the western third of the country. The mountains and narrow valleys of the eastern Alps make up the remainder.



CLIMATE

Warm, dry summers. Winters are cold, with heavy snow in the mountains from December to March.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Principality's role as a financial center accounts for its many foreign residents (a third of the population). Half of the workforce are cross-border commuters. Living standards are high, with few social tensions. Linked by a customs union since 1924, Switzerland handles Liechtenstein's foreign affairs and defense issues.

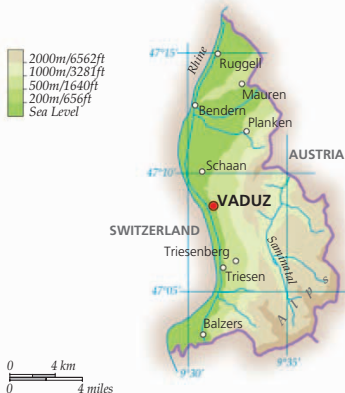


INSIGHT: Women in Liechtenstein obtained the vote only in 1984



THE ECONOMY

Banking secrecy (now modified) and low taxes help attract foreign investment. Anti-money-laundering rules are recent. Diversified exports include precision instruments, dental products, and chemicals.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Principality of Liechtenstein

DATE OF FORMATION: 1719

CAPITAL: Vaduz

POPULATION: 35,000

TOTAL AREA: 62 sq. miles
(160 sq. km)

DENSITY: 565 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: German*, Italian, Alemannish dialect

RELIGIONS: Catholic 81%, other 19%

ETHNIC MIX: Liechtensteiner 66%, other 18%, Swiss 10%, Austrian 6%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Swiss franc = 100 centimes

Lithuania



Lying on the eastern coast of the Baltic Sea, Lithuania is the largest of the Baltic states. The first Soviet republic to declare independence from Moscow in 1991, it joined the EU in 2004.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly flat with moors, bogs, and an intensively farmed central lowland. Numerous lakes and forested sandy ridges in the east.



CLIMATE

Coastal location moderates continental extremes. Cold winters, cool summers, and steady rainfall.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Homogeneous population, with Lithuanians forming a large majority. Only 4000 Jews, known as Litvaks, remain in Lithuania. Strong Roman Catholic tradition and historic links with Poland. There are better relations among ethnic groups than in other Baltic states and interethnic marriages are fairly common. However, ethnic Russians and Poles see a threat from "Lithuanianization." A large income gap has grown since independence.



THE ECONOMY

High-tech and heavy industries: engineering, shipbuilding, and food processing. Litas pegged to euro. High inflation has delayed euro's adoption. Recession in 2009 after strong growth.



INSIGHT: *The "amber coast" of Lithuania produces most of the world's amber – fossilized resin*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Lithuania

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Vilnius

POPULATION: 3.29 million

TOTAL AREA: 25,174 sq. miles
(65,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 131 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Lithuanian*, Russian

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 83%,
other 12%, Protestant 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Lithuanian 85%,
Polish 6%, Russian 5%, other 3%,
Belarussian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Litas = 100 centu



Luxembourg

Part of the plateau of the Ardennes in western Europe, Luxembourg is one of Europe's richest states. A tax haven and banking center, it is also home to key EU institutions.



GEOGRAPHY

Dense Ardennes forests in the north, with a low, open plateau to the south. Undulating terrain throughout.



CLIMATE

The climate is moist, with warm summers and mild winters. Snow is common only in the Ardennes.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnic tensions are rare, despite a large proportion of foreigners (over a third of residents). Integration has been straightforward; most are fellow western Europeans and Catholics, mainly from Italy and Portugal. Low unemployment and high salaries promote stability. Divorce rates are rising and marriage is becoming less common.



INSIGHT: *Luxembourg's capital is home to around 2000 investment funds and over 150 banks*



THE ECONOMY

Traditional industries such as steelmaking have given way to the banking and service sectors. Low taxes and banking secrecy laws attract foreign investors.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Grand Duchy of Luxembourg

DATE OF FORMATION: 1867

CAPITAL: Luxembourg-Ville

POPULATION: 486,200

TOTAL AREA: 998 sq. miles (2586 sq. km)

DENSITY: 487 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Luxembourgish*, German*, French*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 97%, Jewish, Greek Orthodox, and Protestant 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Luxembourger 62%, foreign residents 38%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents

Macedonia



Landlocked Macedonia was hit hard by the sanctions placed on its northern trading partners in the mid-1990s, and by violent conflict with ethnic Albanians in 2001.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly mountainous or hilly, with deep river basins in the center. Plains in the northeast and southwest.



CLIMATE

Continental climate with wet springs and dry autumns. Heavy snowfalls in northern mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Slav Macedonians are mostly Orthodox Christians, with some Muslims. Officially, Muslim Albanians account for 25% of the population, but they claim to number a third. In 2001 Albanian militants fought a bitter war against the government. A peace deal promised greater equality. A major stumbling block to EU and NATO accession is Greece's objection to the name Macedonia, in order to prevent any possibility of claims to historic "Macedonian" lands in north Greece.



THE ECONOMY

Steel, minerals, clothing, shoes, and tobacco exported. Slow transition to market economy. Organized crime and large gray economy. Investment boosted by EU candidate status.



INSIGHT: *Ohrid is the deepest lake in Europe at 964 ft (294 m)*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Macedonia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Skopje

POPULATION: 2.04 million

TOTAL AREA: 9781 sq. miles
(25,333 sq. km)

DENSITY: 206 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Macedonian*, Albanian*

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 59%,
Muslim 26%, other 11%, Catholic 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Macedonian 64%, Albanian 25%,
other 5%, Turkish 4%, Serb 2%

GOVERNMENT: Mixed
presidential-parliamentary system

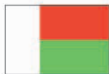
CURRENCY: Macedonian denar = 100 deni



Madagascar

Lying off east Africa in the Indian Ocean, the former French colony of Madagascar is the world's fourth-largest island.

Power struggles erupted onto the streets in 2002 and 2009.



GEOGRAPHY

More than two-thirds of the country forms a savanna-covered plateau, which drops in the east through rainforests to the coast.



CLIMATE

Tropical and often hit by cyclones. Monsoons affect the east coast. The southwest is much drier.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

People are Malay-Indonesian in origin, intermixed with later migrants from the African mainland. The main ethnic division is between the Merina of the central plateau and the poorer *côtier* (coastal) peoples. The Merina were the country's historic rulers, and remain the social elite.



INSIGHT: 80% of Madagascar's plants and many of its animal species are found nowhere else



THE ECONOMY

Most people are farmers. Cash crops are vanilla, coffee, and cloves. Garments and shrimp also exported. Political crises deter investors.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Madagascar

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Antananarivo

POPULATION: 219.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 226,656 sq. miles
(587,040 sq. km)

DENSITY: 87 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Malagasy*, French*

RELIGIONS: Traditional beliefs 52%,
Christian 41%, Muslim 7%

ETHNIC MIX: Other Malay 46%,
Merina 26%, Betsimisaraka 15%, Betsileo 12%,
other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Ariary = 5 iraimbilanja

Malawi



A former colony of the UK, Malawi lies landlocked in southeast Africa, following the Great Rift Valley. Its name means "the land where the sun is reflected in the water like fire."



GEOGRAPHY

Lake Nyasa takes up one-fifth of the landscape. Highlands lie west of the lake. Much of the land is covered by forests and savanna.



CLIMATE

Mainly subtropical. The south is hot and humid. Highlands are cooler.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Malawians share a common Bantu origin. Ethnicity has not been exploited for political ends as has happened in neighboring states. Four out of five people live in poverty. The election in 1994 of a member of the Muslim minority as president signaled the failure of previous attempts to enforce Protestant dominance.



INSIGHT: Lake Nyasa is 353 miles (568 km) in length and contains at least 500 species of fish



THE ECONOMY

Mainly subsistence farming. Tobacco accounts for 60% of export earnings. Tea and sugar are grown. Drought and corruption are problems.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Malawi

DATE OF FORMATION: 1964

CAPITAL: Lilongwe

POPULATION: 15.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 45,745 sq. miles
(118,480 sq. km)

DENSITY: 420 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Chewa, Lomwe, Yao, Ngoni, English*

RELIGIONS: Protestant 55%, Muslim 20%, Catholic 20%, traditional beliefs 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Bantu 99%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Malawi kwacha

= 100 tambala



Malaysia



Malaysia stretches 1240 miles (2000 km) across southeast Asia from the Malay peninsula to Sabah in eastern Borneo. Federated in 1963, it included Singapore for two years.



GEOGRAPHY

The Malay Peninsula has central mountains, an eastern coastal belt, and fertile western plains. Swampy coastal plains rise to mountains on Borneo.



CLIMATE

Warm equatorial. Rainfall always heavy, but with distinct rainy seasons.



INSIGHT: Malaysia is southeast Asia's major tourist destination, with over 20 million visitors a year



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The key distinction is between Malays (Bumiputras, literally “sons of the soil”) and the Chinese, who traditionally controlled most economic activity. Since the 1970s, Malays have been favored for education and jobs, in order to address this imbalance.



THE ECONOMY

Successful industrial base include manufacturing and heavy industry. Tourism is a major earner. Leading producer of palm oil, tin, and tropical hardwoods.

FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Federation of Malaysia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1963

CAPITAL: Kuala Lumpur and Putrajaya

POPULATION: 27.5 million

TOTAL AREA: 127,316 sq. miles
(329,750 sq. km)

DENSITY: 217 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bahasa Malaysia*, Malay, Chinese, Tamil, English

RELIGIONS: Muslim 53%, Buddhist 19%, Chinese faiths 12%, other 9%, Christian 7%

ETHNIC MIX: Malay 50%, Chinese 25%, indigenous tribes 11%, other 14%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Ringgit = 100 sen

Maldives



Set in the Indian Ocean, southwest of Sri Lanka, the Maldives is an archipelago of 1191 small coral islands, or atolls. 200 are inhabited. The word atoll comes from the Dhivehi word “atolu.”



GEOGRAPHY

Consists of low-lying islands and coral atolls. The larger ones are covered in lush, tropical vegetation.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Rain falls throughout the year, but is heaviest June–November, during the monsoon. Violent storms occasionally hit the northern islands.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Maldivians, who are all Sunni Muslim, are descended from Sinhalese, Dravidian, Arab, and black ancestors. About 25% of the population live on Male'. Tourism has grown on separate resort islands away from residents. Politics has been controlled by a small group of influential families. However, a young elite pushed for reform: parties were legalized in 2005, and the presidential election in 2008 brought in a new regime.



THE ECONOMY

The fluctuating tourist industry is the economic mainstay. Fish, especially tuna, are the main export. Construction boom to repair 2004 tsunami damage.



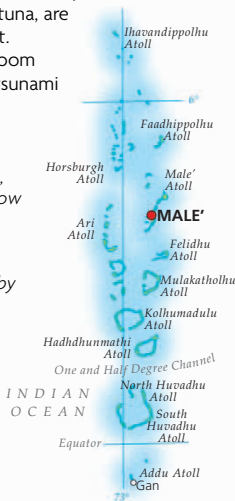
INSIGHT:

The islands, which all lie below 4 ft (1.2 m), are threatened by rising sea levels, brought about by global warming and climatic changes



Sea Level

0 100 km
0 100 miles



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Maldives

DATE OF FORMATION: 1965

CAPITAL: Male'

POPULATION: 309,400

TOTAL AREA: 116 sq. miles
(300 sq. km)

DENSITY: 2667 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Dhivehi* (Maldivian), Sinhala, Tamil, Arabic

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 100%

ETHNIC MIX: All Maldivians are of Arab–Sinhalese–Malay descent

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Rufiyaa
= 100 laari



A former French colony, Mali is landlocked in the heart of west Africa. The 1991 coup ended the 23-year dictatorship of Moussa Traoré and ushered in multiparty elections from 1992.



GEOGRAPHY

The northern half of the country lies in the Sahara. The inland delta of the Niger River flows through a grassy savanna region in the south.



CLIMATE

In the south, intensely hot, dry weather precedes the westerly rains. The north is almost rainless.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people live in the southern savanna region. The Bambara tribe are culturally and politically dominant. A few nomadic Fulani and Tuareg herders travel the northern plains. There is tension between the peoples of the south and Tuareg in the north. Malian women have little status.



INSIGHT: *Tombouctou (Timbuktu) was the center of the 14th-century Malinké trading empire*



THE ECONOMY

Widespread poverty. Most people are farmers, herders, or river fishermen. Less than 2% of land can be cultivated. High-quality cotton, gold, and livestock account for 80% of exports. Vulnerable to drought.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Mali

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Bamako

POPULATION: 13 million

TOTAL AREA: 478,764 sq. miles
(1,240,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 28 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bambara, Fulani, Senufo, Soninke, French*

RELIGIONS: Muslim 80%, traditional beliefs 18%, Christian 1%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Bambara 32%, other 33%, Fulani 14%, Senufo 12%, Soninka 9%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes

Malta



The densely populated Maltese archipelago lies between Africa and Europe. Controlled throughout its history by successive colonial powers, it gained independence from the UK in 1964.



GEOGRAPHY

The main island of Malta has low hills and a ragged coastline with numerous harbors, bays, sandy beaches, and rocky coves. The island of Gozo is more densely vegetated.



CLIMATE

Mediterranean climate. There are many hours of sunshine all year round, with very little rainfall.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Over the centuries, the Maltese have been subject to Arab, Sicilian, Spanish, French, and British influences. Today, the population is socially conservative and devoutly Roman Catholic – on a percentage basis, risen more so than virtually any other nation. Unemployment is high, particularly for women. Divorce is banned. Illegal migration from Africa has increased since Malta joined the EU in 2004.

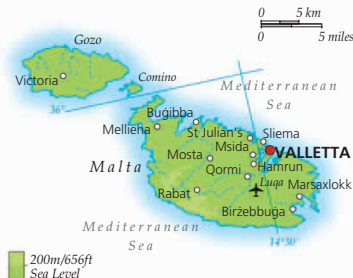


THE ECONOMY

Tourism provides 30% of GDP. Joined eurozone in 2008. Developing offshore banking, high-tech industry. Semiconductors exported. Most goods have to be imported.



INSIGHT: *The Maltese language has Phoenician origins but features Arabic etymology and intonation*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Malta

DATE OF FORMATION: 1964

CAPITAL: Valletta

POPULATION: 408,700

TOTAL AREA: 122 sq. miles
(316 sq. km)

DENSITY: 3296 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Maltese*, English*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 98%, other and nonreligious 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Maltese 96%, other 4%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents



Marshall Islands

Under US rule as part of the UN Trust Territory of the Pacific Islands until independence in 1986, the Marshall Islands comprises a group of 34 widely scattered atolls.



GEOGRAPHY

Narrow coral rings with sandy beaches enclosing lagoons. Those in the south have thicker vegetation. Kwajalein is the world's largest atoll.



CLIMATE

Tropical oceanic, cooled year round by northeast trade winds.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Majuro, the capital city and commercial center, is home to almost half the population. Tensions are high due to poor living conditions. Life on the outlying islands is still traditional, based around subsistence agriculture and fishing. Society is matrilineal, with land and titles handed down through the mother's clan.



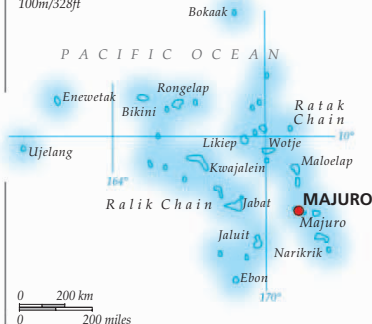
INSIGHT: In 1954, Bikini Atoll was the site for the testing of the largest US H-bomb – the 18–22 megaton Bravo



THE ECONOMY

Almost totally dependent on US aid and the rent paid by the US for its missile base on Kwajalein Atoll. High unemployment. Revenue from licenses to fish in Marshallese waters for tuna. Copra and coconut oil are the only significant agricultural exports.

All land under
100m/328ft



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of the Marshall Islands

DATE OF FORMATION: 1986

CAPITAL: Majuro

POPULATION: 54,100

TOTAL AREA: 70 sq. miles (181 sq. km)

DENSITY: 733 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Marshallese*, English*, Japanese, German

RELIGIONS: Protestant 90%, Roman Catholic 8%, other 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Micronesian 97%, other 3%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: US dollar = 100 cents

Mauritania



Two-thirds of Mauritania's territory is desert – the only productive land is that drained by the Senegal River. The country has taken a strongly Arab direction since 1964.



GEOGRAPHY

The Sahara, barren except for some scattered oases, covers the north. Savanna lands lie to the south.



CLIMATE

The climate is generally hot and dry, aggravated by the dusty *harmattan* wind. Summer rain in the south, virtually none in the north.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The majority Maures control political and economic life. Family solidarity among nomadic peoples is particularly strong. Ethnic tension centers on the oppression of the sizable black minority by Maures. Tens of thousands of blacks are estimated to be in illegal slavery.

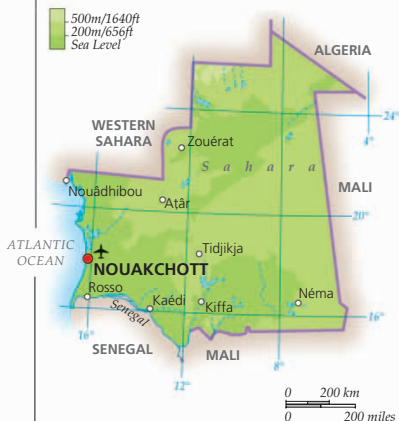


INSIGHT: Slavery officially became illegal in Mauritania in 1980, but *de facto* slavery still persists



THE ECONOMY

Agriculture and herding. Iron, copper, and gold mining. World's largest gypsum deposits. Offshore oil from 2006. Rich fishing grounds.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Islamic Republic of Mauritania

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Nouakchott

POPULATION: 3.29 million

TOTAL AREA: 397,953 sq. miles
(1,030,700 sq. km)

DENSITY: 8 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Hassaniyah Arabic*, Wolof, French

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 100%

ETHNIC MIX: Maure 81%, Wolof 7%,
Tukolor 5%, other 4%, Soninka 3%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Ouguiya = 5 khoums



Mauritius

The islands that make up Mauritius lie in the Indian Ocean east of Madagascar. They have enjoyed considerable economic success following recent industrial diversification and expansion.



GEOGRAPHY

The volcanic main island of Mauritius is ringed by coral reefs, and rises from the coast to a fertile central plateau. The outer islands – Rodriguez, the Agalega Islands, and the Cargados Carajos Shoals – lie some 300 miles (500 km) to the north.



CLIMATE

Warm and humid. Tropical storms are frequent December–March, the hottest and wettest months.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people are descendants of laborers brought over from India in the 19th century. A small minority of French descent form the wealthiest group. Creoles (descendants of African slaves) complain of discrimination. Literacy is high. Health care is free. Criminal offenses are usually traffic-related; little crime on outer islands.



THE ECONOMY

Clothing manufacture, tourism, and sugar. Loss of preferential trade terms for sugar and textiles. Offshore financial center. New outsourcing and ICT industries. Most food is imported.



INSIGHT: *The islands form part of the Mascarene Archipelago – once a land bridge between Asia and Africa*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Mauritius

DATE OF FORMATION: 1968

CAPITAL: Port Louis

POPULATION: 1.29 million

TOTAL AREA: 718 sq. miles (1860 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1794 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: French Creole, Hindi, Urdu,

Tamil, Chinese, English*, French

RELIGIONS: Hindu 52%, Catholic 26%, Muslim 17%, other 3%, Protestant 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Indo-Mauritian 68%, Creole 27%, other 5%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Mauritian rupee = 100 cents

Mexico



Mexico stretches from the US border southward into the ancient Aztec and Mayan heartlands. Independence from Spain came in 1836. One in five Mexicans lives in the sprawling capital.



GEOGRAPHY

Coastal plains along the Pacific and Atlantic seabords rise to a high arid central plateau. To the east and west are the Sierra Madre mountain ranges. Limestone lowlands form the projecting Yucatan peninsula.



CLIMATE

The plateau and high mountains are warm for much of the year. Pacific coast is tropical: storms occur mostly March–December. Northwest is dry.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Mexicans are *mestizos* of Spanish–Amerindian descent. Rural Amerindians are largely segregated from Hispanic society and most live in poverty, though the state promotes their culture. The Zapatista movement backs indigenous rights. Few women in male-dominated politics and business. Narcotics-related violent crime is rising.



THE ECONOMY

One of the world's largest oil producers. Corn, fruit, vegetables, sugar are cash crops. NAFTA has boosted exports, but exposes farmers to subsidized US competition. Huge wealth disparity. Swine flu crippled economy in 2009.



INSIGHT: *More people cross the US–Mexican border each year – illegally or legally – than any other border in the world*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: United Mexican States

DATE OF FORMATION: 1836

CAPITAL: Mexico City

POPULATION: 110 million

TOTAL AREA: 761,602 sq. miles
(1,972,550 sq. km)

DENSITY: 149 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Nahuatl, Mayan, Zapotec, Mixtec, Otomi, Totonac, other

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 88%, other 7%, Protestant 5%

ETHNIC MIX: *Mestizo* 60%, Amerindian 30%, European 9%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Mexican peso = 100 centavos



Micronesia



The Federated States of Micronesia (FSM), situated in the western Pacific, comprise 607 islands and atolls grouped into four main island states: Pohnpei, Kosrae, Chuuk, and Yap.



GEOGRAPHY

Mixture of high volcanic islands with forested interiors, and low-lying coral atolls. Some of the islands have coastal mangrove swamps.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with high humidity. There is very heavy rainfall outside the January–March dry season.



INSIGHT: Chuuk's lagoon contains the sunken wrecks of over 100 Japanese ships and 270 planes from World War II



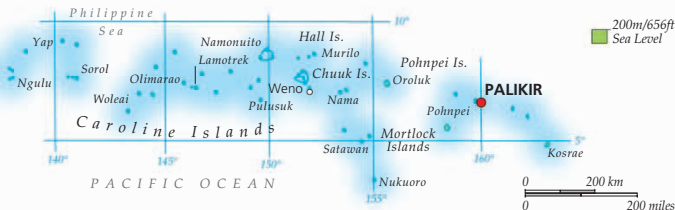
PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Micronesians are physically, culturally, and linguistically diverse. Melanesians live on Yap, Polynesians in Pohnpei. The supply of electricity and running water is limited. Society is based on matrilineal clans.



THE ECONOMY

Dependent on US aid. Fishing licenses are a key source of foreign revenue. Tourism, fishing, betel nuts, copra are economic mainstays. Trust fund created to reduce aid reliance.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Federated States of Micronesia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1986

CAPITAL: Palikir (Pohnpei Island)

POPULATION: 110,700

TOTAL AREA: 271 sq. miles (702 sq. km)

DENSITY: 408 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Trukese, Pohnpeian, Kosraean, Yapese, English*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 50%, Protestant 48%, other 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Chuukese 49%, Pohnpeian 24%, other 19%, Kosraean 6%, Asian 2%

GOVERNMENT: Nonparty system

CURRENCY: US dollar = 100 cents

Moldova



The most densely populated of the former Soviet republics, Moldova has strong ethnic, linguistic, and cultural links with Romania, but relations with Russia remain paramount.



GEOGRAPHY

Steppes and hilly plains are drained by the Dniester and Prut rivers.



CLIMATE

Warm summers and relatively mild winters. Moderate rainfall is evenly spread throughout the year.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

A shared heritage with Romania defines national identity, though in 1994 Moldovans voted against possible reunification with Romania. Most of the population is engaged in intensive agriculture. Transnistria is a breakaway state along the east bank of the Dniester, home to a largely ethnic Slav population. The Gagauz, in the south, have accepted autonomy.



INSIGHT: *Vast underground wine vaults contain entire "streets" of bottles built into rock quarries*



THE ECONOMY

One of the two poorest countries in Europe. Mainly agricultural: produces wine, tobacco, fruit. Food processing and textiles. Depends on Russia for raw materials, fuel, exports. Instability.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Moldova

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Chisinau

POPULATION: 3.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 13,067 sq. miles
(33,843 sq. km)

DENSITY: 277 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Moldovan*, Ukrainian, Russian

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 98%, Jewish 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Moldovan 64%, Ukrainian 14%, Russian 13%, Gagauz 4%, other 5%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Moldovan leu = 100 bani



Monaco



Monaco is a tiny principality on the Côte d'Azur. Its destiny changed radically when the casino was opened in 1863. Today, it promotes its image as an upmarket, glamorous destination.



GEOGRAPHY

A rocky promontory overlooking a narrow coastal strip that has been enlarged through land reclamation.



CLIMATE

Mediterranean. Summers are hot and dry; days with 12 hours of sunshine are not uncommon. Winters are mild and sunny.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Less than 20% of residents are Monégasques. Around a third are French, the rest Italian, American, British, Belgian, and many others. Nationals enjoy considerable privileges, including housing subsidies to protect them from Monaco's high property prices, and the right of first refusal before a job can be offered to a foreigner. Women have equal status, but only acquired the vote in 1962.

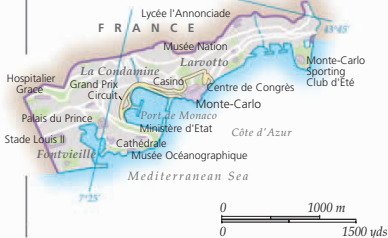


THE ECONOMY

Tourism, gambling, financial services. Banking secrecy laws and tax-haven conditions attract foreign investment. Close links and customs union with France (but not in EU). No resources: depends on imports.



INSIGHT: High-profile social and sporting events attract large crowds each spring, including the Rose Ball, Tennis Open, and Grand Prix



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Principality of Monaco

DATE OF FORMATION: 1861

CAPITAL: Monaco-Ville

POPULATION: 32,000

TOTAL AREA: 0.75 sq. miles
(1.95 sq. km)

DENSITY: 42,667 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: French*, Italian, Monégasque

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 89%,
Protestant 6%, other 5%

ETHNIC MIX: French 32%, other 29%,
Italian 20%, Monégasque 19%

GOVERNMENT: Mixed monarchical–
parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents

Mongolia



Landlocked between Russia and China, Mongolia is a huge, isolated, and sparsely populated nation. Over two-thirds of the country is part of the Gobi Desert.



GEOGRAPHY

A mountainous steppe plateau in the north, with lakes in the north and west. The desert region of the Gobi dominates the south.



CLIMATE

Continental. Mild summers and long, dry, very cold winters, with heavy snowfall. Temperatures can drop as low as -22°F (-30°C).



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Mongolia was unified by Genghis Khan in 1206 and was later absorbed into Manchu China. A majority of ethnic Mongolians live within China in Inner Mongolia. Tibetan Buddhism dominates. The traditional, nomadic way of life has been eroded as urban migration continues, spurred by ferocious winters, known as *zud*, which can devastate the rural economy.

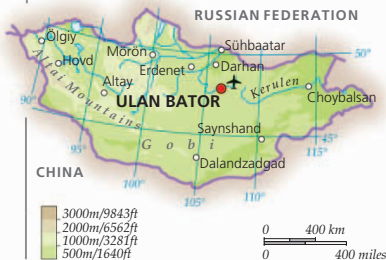


THE ECONOMY

Rich deposits of oil, coal, copper, uranium, and other minerals remain largely untapped. Cashmere exports. Democracy, from 1990, brought a shift toward a market economy, but also rising poverty. State involvement in mining is an issue. Agriculture uses 40% of workforce, mainly as herders.



INSIGHT: *Horseracing, wrestling, and archery are the national sports*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Mongolia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1924

CAPITAL: Ulan Bator

POPULATION: 2.67 million

TOTAL AREA: 604,247 sq. miles
(1,565,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 4 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Khalkha Mongolian*, other

RELIGIONS: Tibetan Buddhist 96%,
Muslim 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Khalkh 82%, other 9%,
Kazakh 4%, Dorvod 3%, Bayad 2%

GOVERNMENT: Mixed presidential–
parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Tugrik (tögrög) = 100 mōngö



Montenegro



Perched on the Adriatic coast, this tiny republic became a separate state in 2006, after 88 years of federation with its neighbors in various forms of the state of Yugoslavia.



GEOGRAPHY

A narrow coastal strip on the Adriatic. Fertile lowland plains around Lake Scutari. Mountainous interior with deep canyons.



CLIMATE

The lowlands have hot, dry summers and mild winters. Heavy snow in winter in the mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Montenegrins are Orthodox Christians. They speak a language closely related to Serbian, using the same Cyrillic script. Muslim Albanians, who make up 80% of the population of the southern Ulcinj region, supported independence and are now asking for autonomy.



INSIGHT: Dark forests once cloaked Montenegro's mountains; its name means "Black Mountain"



THE ECONOMY

Tourism (along Adriatic) drives growth. Bauxite reserves, aluminum industry. Economy dominated by black market; cigarette smuggling is rife. Return of foreign aid and investment. The 2007 accord with the EU is the first step toward eventual accession.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Montenegro

DATE OF FORMATION: 2006

CAPITAL: Podgorica

POPULATION: 624,200

TOTAL AREA: 5332 sq. miles
(13,812 sq. km)

DENSITY: 117 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Montenegrin*, Serbian, Albanian

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 74%, Muslim 18%, Catholic 4%, other 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Montenegrin 43%, Serb 32%, other 12%, Bosniak 8%, Albanian 5%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents

Morocco



Morocco is a former French colony in northwest Africa. Since 1975, it has occupied the territory of Western Sahara, the future of which is yet to be determined by UN-supervised referendum.



GEOGRAPHY

Fertile coastal plain is interrupted in the east by the Rif Mountains. Atlas Mountain ranges to the south. Beyond lies the outer fringe of the Sahara.



CLIMATE

Ranges from temperate and warm in the north, to semiarid in the south. Cooler in the mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Around 30% of the population are descendants of original Berber inhabitants of north Africa, and live mainly in mountain villages. The Arab majority inhabits the lowlands. Morocco is unusual among Arab states in granting Jews religious freedom and civil rights. The king is spiritual leader and head of state. Islamists have gained influence in politics. Islamist militancy and the emergence of terrorist cells are of concern.



THE ECONOMY

Major exporter of phosphates. Investment in tourism and agriculture. Fishing. Relations with EU strained over illegal immigrants and cannabis trade.



INSIGHT: *Karueein University in Fès, founded in 859 CE, is the world's oldest existing educational institution*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Morocco

DATE OF FORMATION: 1956

CAPITAL: Rabat

POPULATION: 32 million

TOTAL AREA: 172,316 sq. miles
(446,300 sq. km)

DENSITY: 186 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, Tamazight, French

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 99%,
other (mostly Christian) 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 70%, Berber 29%,
European 1%

GOVERNMENT: Mixed monarchical–
parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Mor. dirham = 100 centimes



Mozambique

Mozambique lies on the southeast African coast. It was torn apart by a savage and devastating civil war between the Marxist government and a rebel faction between 1977 and 1992.



GEOGRAPHY

Largely a savanna-covered plateau. The coast is fringed by coral reefs and lagoons. The Zambezi River bisects the country.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Temperatures are hottest on the coast. Extremes of rainfall: drought and flood.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Tensions exist between north and south, rather than between ethnic groups. Life is centered on the extended family. Polygamy is fairly common. The country is struggling with the legacy of a war that killed around a million people, and the effects of frequent floods and droughts. Half the population lives in abject poverty.



INSIGHT: Maputo's busy port serves Zimbabwe and South Africa



THE ECONOMY

Extremely dependent on aid. Mineral potential. Cashew nuts, shrimp, cotton exported. Debt relief.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Rep. of Mozambique

DATE OF FORMATION: 1975

CAPITAL: Maputo

POPULATION: 22.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 309,494 sq. miles
(801,590 sq. km)

DENSITY: 76 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Makua, Xitsonga, Sena, Lomwe, Portuguese*

RELIGIONS: Traditional beliefs 56%,
Christian 30%, Muslim 14%

ETHNIC MIX: Makua Lomwe 47%, Tsonga 23%,
Malawi 12%, Shona 11% other 7%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: New metical = 100 centavos

Myanmar (Burma)



Forming the eastern shores of the Bay of Bengal and the Andaman Sea in southeast Asia, Myanmar suffers from isolation, political repression, and ethnic conflict.



GEOGRAPHY

The fertile Irrawaddy basin lies at the center. Mountains to the west, Shan plateau to the east. Tropical rainforest covers much of the land.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Hot summers, with high humidity, and warm winters.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The military, in power since 1962, rules Myanmar with little regard to human rights. Opposition is not tolerated. The National League for Democracy won elections in 1990, but was kept from power. Its leader, Aung San Suu Kyi, is frequently detained. Minority groups maintain low-level guerrilla activity against the state.

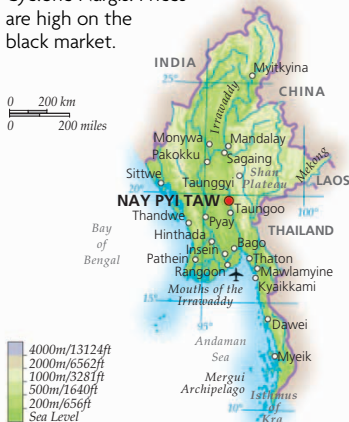


INSIGHT: Myanmar is one of the world's biggest teak exporters, though reserves are diminishing rapidly



THE ECONOMY

Corrupt, mismanaged, subject to sanctions – but gas, teak, and gems are exported. Illicit opium production has fallen. Rice shortages in 2008 after Cyclone Nargis. Prices are high on the black market.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Union of Myanmar

DATE OF FORMATION: 1948

CAPITAL: Nay Pyi Taw

POPULATION: 50 million

TOTAL AREA: 261,969 sq. miles
(678,500 sq. km)

DENSITY: 197 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Burmese*, Shan, Karen, Rakhine, Chin, Yangbye, Kachin, Mon

RELIGIONS: Buddhist 87%, Christian 6%, Muslim 4%, other 2%, Hindu 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Burman 68%, other 13%, Shan 9%, Karen 6%, Rakhine 4%

GOVERNMENT: Military-based regime

CURRENCY: Kyat = 100 pyas



Namibia

Located in southwestern Africa, Namibia gained independence from South Africa in 1990, after 24 years of armed struggle. It regained the territory of Walvis Bay in 1994.



GEOGRAPHY

The Namib Desert stretches along the coastal strip. Inland, a ridge of mountains rises to 8000 ft (2500 m). The Kalahari Desert lies in the east.



CLIMATE

Almost rainless. The coast is usually shrouded in thick fog, unless the hot, dry *berg* wind is blowing.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Ovambo, the main ethnic group, live mainly in the more populous north. Some 100,000 whites, many of German descent, are centered around Windhoek and still control the economy. The minority San and Khoi bushmen are among the oldest human communities in the world. The ban on homosexuality is contentious.



INSIGHT: *The Namib is the Earth's oldest, and one of its driest, deserts*



THE ECONOMY

Varied mineral resources, notably uranium and diamonds. Rich offshore fishing grounds. High unemployment. HIV/AIDS epidemic. One of Africa's most skewed distributions of wealth.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Namibia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1990

CAPITAL: Windhoek

POPULATION: 2.17 million

TOTAL AREA: 318,694 sq. miles
(825,418 sq. km)

DENSITY: 7 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Ovambo, Kavango, English*, Bergdama, German, Afrikaans

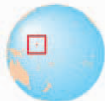
RELIGIONS: Christian 90%, traditional beliefs 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Ovambo 50%, other 25%, Kavango 9%, Damara 8%, Herero 8%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Namibian dollar = 100 cents

Nauru



Nauru lies in the Pacific, northeast of Australia. Phosphate deposits gave its inhabitants huge temporary wealth, but economic mismanagement has left them facing ruin.



GEOGRAPHY

A single low-lying coral atoll, with a fertile coastal belt. Coral cliffs encircle an elevated interior plateau.



CLIMATE

Equatorial, moderated by sea breezes. Occasional long droughts.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Native Nauruans are of mixed Micronesian and Polynesian origin. Most live in simple, traditional houses and spend their money on luxury cars and consumer goods. Welfare and education are free. A diet of imported processed foods has caused widespread obesity and diabetes. Mining was left to imported laborers, mainly from Kiribati, who lived in enclaves of male-only barracks and had few rights. Many young Nauruans leave to seek a better life in Australia or New Zealand.



THE ECONOMY

Phosphate revenues all but dried up. Sale of fishing rights sole resource. State trust fund invested badly overseas. Offshore banking facilities closed after international pressure.



INSIGHT: *Phosphate mining has left 80% of the island uninhabitable*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Nauru

DATE OF FORMATION: 1968

CAPITAL: None

POPULATION: 9800

TOTAL AREA: 8.1 sq. miles
(21 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1210 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Nauruan*, Kiribati, Chinese, Tuvaluan, English

RELIGIONS: Nauruan Congregational Church 60%, Catholic 35%, other 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Nauruan 62%, other Pacific islanders 27%, Asian 8%, European 3%

GOVERNMENT: Nonparty system

CURRENCY: Australian dollar = 100 cents



Nepal



Nepal, lying between India and China on the southern shoulder of the Himalayas, is one of the world's poorest countries. Its agricultural economy is heavily dependent on the monsoon.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly mountainous. The area includes some of the highest mountains in the world, including Mount Everest. Flat, fertile river plains form the south.



CLIMATE

Warm monsoon season from July to October. The rest of the year is dry, sunny, and mild. Winter temperatures in the Himalayas average 14°F (−10°C).



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Tensions are few between the diverse ethnic groups. Buddhist women, including Sherpas, face fewer social restrictions than Hindus. Trafficking of women and child labor are problems. Human rights violations rose during the 1999–2006 Maoist insurgency. The peace deal led to the abolition of the monarchy and Maoist victory in elections, but fractious coalitions mean instability continues.



THE ECONOMY

Agriculture employs 70% of people. Crops include rice and wheat. Tourism and investment affected by instability and Maoist insurgency. Reliant on aid. Hydropower potential.



INSIGHT: Southern Nepal was the birthplace of Buddha (Prince Siddhartha Gautama) in 563 BCE



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Federal Democratic Republic of Nepal

DATE OF FORMATION: 1769

CAPITAL: Kathmandu

POPULATION: 29.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 54,363 sq. miles (140,800 sq. km)

DENSITY: 555 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Nepali*, Maithili, Bhojpuri

RELIGIONS: Hindu 90%, Buddhist 5%, Muslim 3%, other (incl. Christian) 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Other 57%, Chhetri 16%, Hill Brahman 13%, Tharu 7%, Magar 7%

GOVERNMENT: Transitional regime

CURRENCY: Nepalese rupee = 100 paisa

Netherlands



Astride the delta of five major rivers in northwest Europe, the Netherlands built its historic wealth on maritime trade. Rotterdam is Europe's largest port.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly flat, with 27% of the land below sea level and protected by dunes, dikes, and canals. There are a few low hills in the south and east.



CLIMATE

Mild, rainy winters and cool summers. Gales from the North Sea are common in fall and winter.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Dutch have a long history of welcoming immigrants from former colonies and refugees seeking asylum. However, lack of integration is now raising fears about the failing asylum system, immigrant crime, and militant Islam. Population is mostly urban and the density is high. The state does not try to impose a particular morality on its citizens. Laws concerning sexuality, narcotics-taking, and euthanasia are among the world's most liberal.



THE ECONOMY

Major trading hub. High-profile multinationals. Diverse industrial base: chemicals, machinery, electronics, and metals. Costly social welfare system.



INSIGHT: In 2002, the Netherlands became the first country in the world to legalize euthanasia



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of the Netherlands

DATE OF FORMATION: 1648

CAPITAL: Amsterdam and The Hague

POPULATION: 16.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 16,033 sq. miles
(41,526 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1267 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Dutch*, Frisian

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 36%, other 34%, Protestant 27%, Muslim 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Dutch 82%, other 12%, Surinamese, Turkish, and Moroccan 6%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents



New Zealand

Lying in the South Pacific, 990 miles (1600 km) southeast of Australia, New Zealand comprises North and South Islands, separated by the Cook Strait, and many smaller islands.



GEOGRAPHY

North Island, noted for hot springs and geysers, has the bulk of the population. South Island is mostly mountainous, with eastern lowlands.



CLIMATE

Generally temperate and damp. The far north is almost subtropical, whereas southern winters are cold.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Maoris were the first settlers, 1200 years ago. Today's majority European population is descended mainly from British migrants who settled after 1840. Maoris' living and education standards are generally lower than average. The government is continuing to negotiate the settlement of Maori land claims.



INSIGHT: *New Zealand women were the first to get the vote (1893)*



THE ECONOMY

Tourism is the biggest foreign-exchange earner. Modern agricultural sector; world's top exporter of dairy products. Hi-tech manufacturing. Open economy. Strong trade links.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: New Zealand

DATE OF FORMATION: 1947

CAPITAL: Wellington

POPULATION: 4.27 million

TOTAL AREA: 103,737 sq. miles
(268,680 sq. km)

DENSITY: 41 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Maori*

RELIGIONS: Anglican 24%, other 22%, Presbyterian 18%, nonreligious 16%, Roman Catholic 15%, Methodist 5%

ETHNIC MIX: European 75%, Maori 15%, other 7%, Samoan 3%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: New Zealand dollar = 100 cents

Nicaragua



Nicaragua lies at the heart of Central America. The Sandinista revolution of 1978 led to 11 years of civil war between the left-wing Sandinistas and the right-wing US-backed Contras.



GEOGRAPHY

Extensive forested plains in the east. Central mountain region with many active volcanoes. The Pacific coastlands are dominated by lakes.



CLIMATE

Tropical. The lowlands are hot all year round. The mountains are cooler. Prone to occasional hurricanes.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most of the population is mixed race, and there is a large white elite. The Caribbean regions are home to communities of Miskito Amerindians and blacks, who gained autonomy in 1987. The revolution improved the status of women, but these gains have been undone by rampant poverty.



INSIGHT: Lake Nicaragua is the only freshwater lake in the world to contain marine animals



THE ECONOMY

Textiles, coffee, meat, tobacco are main exports: affected by world price fluctuations. Remittances from abroad. Substantial debt relief has cut debt to 60% of GDP. Corruption.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Nicaragua

DATE OF FORMATION: 1838

CAPITAL: Managua

POPULATION: 5.74 million

TOTAL AREA: 49,998 sq. miles
(129,494 sq. km)

DENSITY: 125 people per sq. mile)

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, English Creole, Miskito

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 80%, Protestant Evangelical 17%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 69%, White 14%, Black 8%, Amerindian 5%, Zambo 4%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Córdoba oro = 100 centavos



Niger



Niger lies in west Africa, upstream from Nigeria on the Niger River. One of the world's poorest states, it was ruled by one-party or military regimes until multipartyism was allowed in 1992.



GEOGRAPHY

The north and northeast regions are part of the Sahara. The Air Mountains in the center rise high above the desert. Savanna lies to the south.



CLIMATE

High temperatures persist for most of the year at around 95°F (35°C). The north is virtually rainless.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Tuareg nomads in the north feel excluded from politics and the benefits of development of their area's uranium resources. An early 1990s rebellion was reignited in 2007. In the south, egalitarianism and a sense of community help to combat economic difficulties. Almost the entire urban population lives in slum conditions. Two-thirds of the population is under 25. Women have limited rights and restricted access to education.



THE ECONOMY

Vast uranium deposits. Frequent droughts and food shortages. Banditry. Expansion of Sahara. Oil potential.



INSIGHT: The name Niger comes from the Tuareg word *n'eghirren*, which means "flowing water"



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Niger

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Niamey

POPULATION: 15.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 489,188 sq. miles
(1,267,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 31 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Hausa, French*, other

RELIGIONS: Muslim 85%, traditional beliefs 14%, other (incl. Christian) 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Hausa 55%, Djermas and Songhai 21%, Peul 9%, Tuareg 9%, other 6%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes

Nigeria



West Africa's biggest nation, Nigeria is a federation of 36 states and the capital, Abuja. Dominated by military governments since 1966, democracy returned in 1999.



GEOGRAPHY

Coastal area of beaches, swamps, and lagoons gives way to rainforest, and then to savanna on the high plateaus. Semidesert to the north.



CLIMATE

The south is hot, rainy and humid for most of the year. The arid north has one very humid wet season. The Jos Plateau and highlands are cooler.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Some 250 ethnic groups: tensions threaten national unity, with sporadic intercommunal violence. The northern states have introduced *sharia* (Islamic law) for their majority Muslim populations. Women have more economic independence in the south. In the Niger Delta, where 70% of people live on less than a dollar a day, militants are fighting for a share of the benefits of the region's oil wealth.



THE ECONOMY

Overdependent on oil, principal export since 1970s. Mismanagement and corruption. Foreign debt reduced.



INSIGHT: Nigeria is Africa's most populous state – one in every seven Africans is Nigerian



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Federal Republic of Nigeria

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Abuja

POPULATION: 155 million

TOTAL AREA: 356,667 sq. miles
(923,768 sq. km)

DENSITY: 440 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Hausa, English*, Yoruba, Ibo

RELIGIONS: Muslim 50%, Christian 40%, traditional beliefs 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Hausa 21%, Yoruba 21%, Ibo 18%, Fulani 11%, other 29%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Naira = 100 kobo



Norway



The Kingdom of Norway traces the rugged western coast of Scandinavia. Settlements are largely restricted to southern and coastal areas. Vast oil and natural gas revenues bring prosperity.



GEOGRAPHY

The western coast is indented with numerous fjords and features tens of thousands of islands. Mountains and plateaus cover most of the country.



CLIMATE

Mild coastal climate. Inland, the weather is more extreme, with warmer summers and cold, snowy winters.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Fairly homogeneous; influx of refugees from 1990s Bosnian conflict. Strong family tradition despite high divorce rate. Fair-minded consensus promotes female equality, boosted by the generous childcare provision. Wealth is more evenly distributed than in most developed countries. Voted not to join EU in 1994.



INSIGHT: Near Narvik, mainland Norway is only 4 miles (7 km) wide



THE ECONOMY

Western Europe's top oil and natural gas producer: trust fund saves for post-oil future. Metal, chemical, and engineering industries. Generous aid donor. High cost of living.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Norway

DATE OF FORMATION: 1905

CAPITAL: Oslo

POPULATION: 4.81 million

TOTAL AREA: 125,181 sq. miles
(324,220 sq. km)

DENSITY: 41 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Norwegian* (Bokmål and Nynorsk), Sámi

RELIGIONS: Evangelical Lutheran 89%, other 10%, Roman Catholic 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Norwegian 93%, other 6%, Sámi 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Norwegian krone = 100 øre

Oman



Oman occupies a strategic position on the Arabian Peninsula, at the entrance to the Persian Gulf. It is the least developed Gulf state, despite modest oil exports.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly gravelly desert, with mountains in the north and south. Some narrow fertile coastal strips.



CLIMATE

Blistering heat in the west. Summer temperatures often climb above 113°F (45°C). Southern uplands receive rains June–September.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Urban drift has seen most Omanis move to northern towns. The majority are Ibadi Muslims who follow an appointed leader, the imam. Ibadism is not opposed to freedom for women, and a few women hold positions of authority. Baluchi from Pakistan are the largest group of foreign workers.



INSIGHT: *Until the late 1980s, Oman was closed to all but business or official visitors*



THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas account for almost all export revenue. Commercially extractable reserves are limited. Other exports include fish, animals, and dates. Foreigners work in all sectors.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Sultanate of Oman

DATE OF FORMATION: 1951

CAPITAL: Muscat

POPULATION: 2.85 million

TOTAL AREA: 82,031 sq. miles
(212,460 sq. km)

DENSITY: 35 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, Baluchi, other

RELIGIONS: Ibadi Muslim 75%, other Muslim and Hindu 25%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 88%, Baluchi 4%, Persian 3%, Indian and Pakistani 3%, African 2%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Omani rial = 1000 baisa



Pakistan



Once a part of British India, Pakistan was created in 1947 in response to demands for an independent Muslim state. In 1971, Bangladesh (former East Pakistan) became a separate state.



GEOGRAPHY

Indus floodplain across east and south. Hindu Kush mountains in north. Semidesert plateau, mountains in west.



CLIMATE

Temperatures can soar to 122°F (50°C) in south and west, and fall to -4°F (-20°C) in the Hindu Kush.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Punjabis dominate government and the army. Tensions with minority groups, exacerbated by the vast gap between rich and poor. Strong family ties permeate politics and business. Relations with India are tense over Kashmir. Islamist taliban insurgency in tribal areas on Afghan border: in 2009, fighting displaced two million.

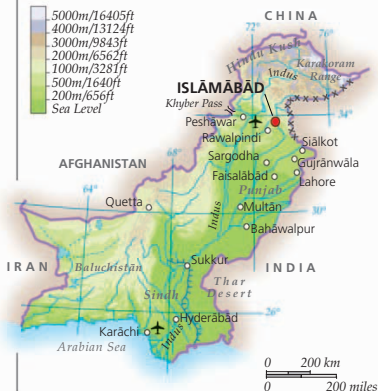


INSIGHT: In 1988, Pakistan elected Benazir Bhutto as the first female prime minister in the Muslim world



THE ECONOMY

Major cotton and rice producer, but unpredictable weather conditions often affect crop. Textiles. Instability. Corruption. Aid to fight terrorism and for earthquake reconstruction.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Islamic Rep. of Pakistan

DATE OF FORMATION: 1947

CAPITAL: Islamabad

POPULATION: 181 million

TOTAL AREA: 310,401 sq. miles
(803,940 sq. km)

DENSITY: 607 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Punjabi, Sindhi, Pashtu, Urdu*, Baluchi, Brahui

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 77%, Shi'a Muslim 20%, Hindu 2%, Christian 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Punjabi 56%, Pathan 15%, Sindhi 14%, other 8%, Mohajir 7%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Pakistani rupee = 100 paisa

Palau



The 300-island Palau archipelago (known locally as Belau) lies in the western Pacific Ocean. It achieved independence in 1994, and is gradually reducing its aid dependence.



GEOGRAPHY

Terrain varies from thickly forested mountains to limestone and coral reefs. Babeldaob, the largest island, is volcanic, with many rivers and waterfalls.



CLIMATE

Hot and wet. Little variation in daily and seasonal temperatures. February–April is the dry season.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Native Palauans are a mix of the original Southeast Asian migrants and Pacific settlers. A modern influx from Asia has led to tension. 70% of the population lives on the island-city of Koror, prompting the construction of a new capital on Babeldaob. Native culture is preserved on outer islands despite strong influence from the US and Japan. Modekngei is a blend of Christianity and local beliefs.

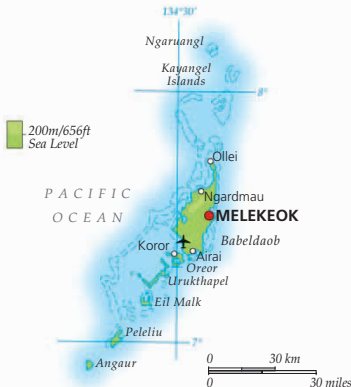


THE ECONOMY

Tourism and fishing licenses are main earners. Coconuts, taro, and bananas. 15-year US aid plan to 2009.



INSIGHT: Palau's reefs contain 1500 species of fish and 700 types of coral



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Palau

DATE OF FORMATION: 1994

CAPITAL: Melekeok

POPULATION: 20,400

TOTAL AREA: 177 sq. miles
(458 sq. km)

DENSITY: 104 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Palauan*, English*, Japanese, Angaur, Tobi, Sonsorolese

RELIGIONS: Christian 66%, Modekngei 34%

ETHNIC MIX: Palauan 74%, Filipino 16%, other 6%, Chinese and other Asian 4%

GOVERNMENT: Nonparty system

CURRENCY: US dollar = 100 cents



Panama

Panama is the southernmost country in Central America. The colossal Panama Canal (which was under US control until 2000) links the Pacific and Atlantic oceans.



GEOGRAPHY

Lowlands along both coasts, with savanna-covered plains and rolling hills. Mountainous interior. Swamps and rainforests in the east.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid, with heavy rainfall in the May–December wet season. Cooler at high altitudes.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

A multiethnic society, dominated by people of Spanish origin. Amerindians live in remote areas. The Panama Canal and former US military bases (the last of which closed in 1999) have given society a cosmopolitan outlook, but Catholicism and the extended family remain strong. Crime is high; money-laundering, narcotics trafficking, and corruption are rife.



THE ECONOMY

Colón Free Trade Zone: world's second-largest. Income from the canal (expansion project underway) and merchant ships sailing under flag of Panama. Banana and shrimp exports.



INSIGHT: The Panama Canal shortens the sea route between the east coast of the US and Japan by 3000 miles (4800 km)



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Panama

DATE OF FORMATION: 1903

CAPITAL: Panama City

POPULATION: 3.45 million

TOTAL AREA: 30,193 sq. miles
(78,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 118 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English Creole, Spanish*, Amerindian and Chibchan languages

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 86%, other 8%, Protestant 6%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 60%, White 14%, Black 12%, Amerindian 8%, other 6%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Balboa = 100 centésimos

Papua New Guinea



A former Australian colony, Papua New Guinea (PNG) occupies the eastern section of the island of New Guinea and several other island groups. Much of the country is isolated.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountainous and forested mainland, with broad, swampy river valleys. 40 active volcanoes in the north. Around 600 outer islands.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid in lowlands, cooling toward highlands, where snow can fall on highest peaks.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Around 800 language groups and even more tribes. The main social distinction is between lowlanders, who have frequent contact with the outside world, and the very isolated, but increasingly threatened, highlanders. Great tensions exist between highland tribes, and vendettas can often last several generations. The island of Bougainville has been granted autonomy and promised an eventual referendum on independence.



THE ECONOMY

Minerals: significant quantities of gold, copper, oil, and natural gas. High government spending almost led to national bankruptcy in 2002.



INSIGHT: PNG is home to the only known poisonous birds; contact with the feathers of some species of pitohui produces skin blisters



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Independent State of Papua New Guinea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1975

CAPITAL: Port Moresby

POPULATION: 6.73 million

TOTAL AREA: 178,703 sq. miles
(462,840 sq. km)

DENSITY: 39 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Pidgin English, Papuan, English*, Motu, c.800 native languages

RELIGIONS: Protestant 60%, Roman Catholic 37%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Melanesian and mixed 100%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Kina = 100 toea



Paraguay



Landlocked in central South America, and once a Spanish colony, Paraguay's postindependence history has included periods of military rule. Free elections were held in 1993.



GEOGRAPHY

The Paraguay River divides the hilly and forested east from a flat alluvial plain, with marsh and semidesert scrub land in the west.



CLIMATE

Subtropical. The Gran Chaco is generally hotter and drier. All areas experience floods and droughts.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Population mainly of mixed Spanish and native Guaraní origin. Most people are bilingual, though in rural areas Guaraní is more widely used. Cattle ranchers populate the Chaco, along with communities of the German-origin Mennonite Church. The army is politically active.



INSIGHT: *The War of the Triple Alliance (1864–1870) killed almost 90% of Paraguay's male population*



THE ECONOMY

Agriculture: soybeans are the main export. Electricity exported from massive hydroelectric dams, including Itaipú (world's second-largest, jointly run with Brazil). Large informal economy. Corruption and smuggling.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Paraguay

DATE OF FORMATION: 1811

CAPITAL: Asunción

POPULATION: 6.35 million

TOTAL AREA: 157,046 sq. miles
(406,750 sq. km)

DENSITY: 41 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Guaraní*, Spanish*, German

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 96%, Protestant (including Mennonite) 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 91%, other 7%, Amerindian 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Guaraní = 100 céntimos

Peru



Once the heart of the Inca Empire, before the Spanish conquest in the 16th century, Peru lies on the Pacific coast of South America, just south of the equator.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Coastal plain rises to Andes Mountains. Uplands, dissected by fertile valleys, lie east of the Andes. Tropical forest in extreme east.

**CLIMATE**

Coast is mainly arid. Middle slopes of the Andes are temperate; higher peaks are snow-covered. East is hot, humid, and very wet.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

Though most people are Amerindians or mixed-race *mestizos*, society is dominated by a small group of Spanish descendants. Amerindians, and the small black community, suffer discrimination in towns, but access to information and political power are growing; the first Amerindian president was elected in 2001–2006. Clashes with left-wing militants killed almost 70,000 people between 1980 and 2000.

**THE ECONOMY**

Abundant mineral resources: notably copper and gold. Rich Pacific fish stocks. Illegal cocaine producer.



INSIGHT: *Lake Titicaca is the world's highest navigable lake*

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Peru

DATE OF FORMATION: 1824

CAPITAL: Lima

POPULATION: 29.2 million

TOTAL AREA: 496,223 sq. miles
(1,285,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 59 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Quechua*, Aymara

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 95%, other 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Amerindian 50%, *Mestizo* 40%, White 7%, other 3%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: New sol = 100 céntimos



Philippines



Lying in the western Pacific Ocean, the Philippines is the world's second-largest archipelago, with 7107 islands, of which 4600 are named but only around 1000 inhabited.



GEOGRAPHY

Larger islands are forested and mountainous. Over 20 active volcanoes. Frequent earthquakes.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Warm and humid all year round. Typhoons occur in the rainy season: June–October.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Over 100 ethnic groups, most of which are of Malay origin. The Catholic Church is a dominant cultural force; it opposes family-planning, despite high population growth. The Chinese minority has been established for 400 years. Women play a prominent part in society. High literacy levels. Islamist separatists and communist insurgents undermine stability.



INSIGHT: Mass "People Power"

demonstrations have brought down two presidents, in 1986 and 2001



THE ECONOMY

Coconuts, bananas, pineapples exported. Growing outsourcing center. Remittances from abroad. Corruption and poor infrastructure limit growth.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Rep. of the Philippines

DATE OF FORMATION: 1946

CAPITAL: Manila

POPULATION: 92 million

TOTAL AREA: 115,830 sq. km
(300,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 799 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Filipino*, Tagalog, Cebuano, Hiligaynon, other, including English*

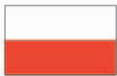
RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 83%, Protestant 9%, Muslim 5%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Tagalog 28%, Cebuano 13%, Ilocano 9%, Hiligaynon 8%, other 42%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Philippine peso = 100 centavos

Poland



Located in the heart of Europe, Poland has undergone massive social, economic, and political change since the collapse of communism in 1989. It joined the EU in 2004.



GEOGRAPHY

Lowlands, part of the North European Plain, cover most of the country. The Tatra Mountains run along the southern border.



CLIMATE

Rainfall peaks during the hot summers. Cold winters with snow, especially in mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnic homogeneity masks a number of tensions. Secular liberals criticize the semiofficial status of the Roman Catholic Church, and emerging wealth disparities are resented by those not profiting from the free market. The German minority in the west is growing more assertive.



INSIGHT: *Wild wisent (European bison) live in the Bialowieza Forest straddling the Poland–Belarus border*



THE ECONOMY

Foreign investment reflects the country's large potential market. Rapid privatization. Heavy industries dominate, though services growing. Plans to join euro in 2012.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Poland

DATE OF FORMATION: 1918

CAPITAL: Warsaw

POPULATION: 38.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 120,728 sq. miles
(312,685 sq. km)

DENSITY: 324 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Polish

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 93%, other and nonreligious 5%, Orthodox Christian 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Polish 97%, other 2%, Silesian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Zloty = 100 groszy



Portugal

Portugal, with its long Atlantic coast, lies on the western side of the Iberian Peninsula, which it shares with Spain. It is the most westerly country on the European mainland.



GEOGRAPHY

The Tagus River bisects the country roughly east to west, dividing mountainous north from lower and more undulating south.



CLIMATE

North is cool and moist. South is warmer, with dry, mild winters.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

A homogeneous and stable society, which is losing some of its conservative traditions. History of immigration from former colonies, and recently from eastern Europe. Urban areas and the south are more socially liberal. The north is more responsive to traditional Roman Catholic values. Family ties remain important.



INSIGHT: Portugal is the world's leading producer of cork, which comes from the bark of the cork oak



THE ECONOMY

Tourism. Vegetables, fruit, wine, cars, and clothing are exported, but agriculture and manufacturing are in decline. Resilient banking sector.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Portugal

DATE OF FORMATION: 1139

CAPITAL: Lisbon

POPULATION: 10.7 million

TOTAL AREA: 35,672 sq. miles
(92,391 sq. km)

DENSITY: 302 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Portuguese

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 97%,
other 2%, Protestant 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Portuguese 98%, African
and other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary
system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents

Qatar



Projecting from the Arabian Peninsula into the Persian Gulf, Qatar was a founding member of OPEC. One of the region's wealthiest states due to oil and natural gas exports.



GEOGRAPHY

Flat, semiarid desert with dunes and salt pans. Vegetation is limited to small patches of scrub.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid. Temperatures in summer can soar to over 104°F (40°C). Rainfall is rare.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Only one in five residents is native-born; the rest are guest workers from across the Middle East, the Indian subcontinent, Southeast Asia and north Africa. Qataris were once nomadic Bedouins, but since the advent of oil wealth, most now live in Doha and its suburbs, leaving the north dotted with abandoned villages. Women enjoy relative freedom; most wear the veil.



INSIGHT: *There are twice as many men as women in Qatar*



THE ECONOMY

Steady supply of crude oil and huge natural gas reserves, plus related industries. All other raw materials and most foods are imported. Strong GDP growth. Economy is heavily dependent on foreign workforce.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: State of Qatar

DATE OF FORMATION: 1971

CAPITAL: Doha

POPULATION: 1.41 million

TOTAL AREA: 4416 sq. miles

(11,437 sq. km)

DENSITY: 332 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 95%, other 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Qatari 20%, other Arab 20%, Indian 20%, Nepalese 13%, Filipino 10%, Pakistani 7%, other 10%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Qatar riyal = 100 dirhams



Romania



Once dominated by Poles, Hungarians, and Ottomans, Romania has been slowly converting to a market economy since the 1989 overthrow of its communist regime. It joined the EU in 2007.



GEOGRAPHY

Carpathian Mountains encircle the Transylvanian plateau. Wide plains to the south and east. Danube River forms southern border.



CLIMATE

Continental. Summers are hot and humid, winters are cold and snowy. Very heavy spring rains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Romanians are ethnically distinct from their Slav and Hungarian (Magyar) neighbors. Hungarians are the largest minority, living mainly in Transylvania. They are protected by the influence of Hungary, unlike the Roma, who suffer from discrimination. The overall population is shrinking.



INSIGHT: In 2001, Romania became the last country in Europe to lift its ban on homosexuality



THE ECONOMY

Polluting, outdated heavy industries and unmechanized agricultural sector. Exports of textiles and metals have led growth in 2000s. Has plans to join euro currency zone in 2015. Privatization continues.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Romania

DATE OF FORMATION: 1878

CAPITAL: Bucharest

POPULATION: 21.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 91,699 sq. miles
(237,500 sq. km)

DENSITY: 239 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Romanian*, Hungarian

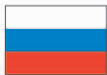
RELIGIONS: Romanian Orthodox 87%, Roman Catholic 5%, Protestant 4%, other 2%, Greek Orthodox 1%, Uniate 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Romanian 89%, Magyar 7%, Roma 2%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Romanian leu

Russian Federation



The Russian Federation was the core of the old Soviet Union, which broke up in 1991. Russia is still the world's largest state. Its diversity is a source of both strength and problems.



GEOGRAPHY

The Ural Mountains divide the European steppes and forests from the tundra and forests of Siberia. South-central deserts and mountains.



CLIMATE

Continental in European Russia. Elsewhere climate ranges from sub-arctic to Mediterranean and hot desert.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Besides the ethnic Russian majority, there are 57 "nationalities" with territorial status, and a further 95 minorities without their own region. Most ethnic republics are in European Russia. The number of Muslims is rising, though the overall population is predicted to fall by 30% in 50 years. Nation-based separatism is brutally suppressed, as in Chechnya. HIV/AIDS is spreading. Healthcare and education are underfunded. Crime is a serious problem.



INSIGHT: *The Trans-Siberian Railroad, which runs 5578 miles (9297 km) from Moscow to Vladivostok, is the longest in the world, passing through eight time zones*

FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Russian Federation

DATE OF FORMATION: 1480

CAPITAL: Moscow

POPULATION: 141 million

TOTAL AREA: 6,592,735 sq. miles
(17,075,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 21 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Russian*, other

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 75%,
Muslim 14%, other 11%

ETHNIC MIX: Russian 80%, other 13%,
Tatar 4%, Ukrainian 2%, Chavash 1%

GOVERNMENT: Mixed presidential–
parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Russian rouble = 100 kopeks



THE ECONOMY

Huge natural resources (oil and natural gas, precious metals, timber) account for 80% of exports. Important military, engineering, and scientific base. Wealth disparities and black-market activities have accompanied reforms. Organized crime syndicates own huge

areas of the economy. Widespread tax evasion, corruption. Lingering inefficiencies in industry and agriculture. High oil prices brought strong GDP growth and budget surpluses in 2000s, allowing Russia to repay its Soviet-era debt. Stock market collapse, devaluation of rouble in 2008, then recession in 2009.

Rwanda



Rwanda lies just south of the equator in east central Africa, far from the nearest sea port. Since independence from France in 1962, ethnic tensions have dominated politics.



GEOGRAPHY

A series of plateaus descend from the ridge of volcanic peaks in the west to the Akagera River on the eastern border. The Great Rift Valley also passes through this region.



CLIMATE

Tropical, though tempered by the altitude. Two wet seasons are separated by a dry season, from June to August. Heaviest rain in the west.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

For over 500 years the cattle-owning Tutsi minority were politically dominant over the land-owning Hutu. In 1959, violent revolt led to a reversal of the roles. Ethnic tensions are fierce; in the most recent violence, in 1994, over 800,000 people, mostly Tutsi, were massacred in an act of state-backed genocide; trials are ongoing. Most people live at subsistence level.



THE ECONOMY

Rwanda is reliant on aid, but (given stability) could become a big coffee and tea producer. Exports tin, coltan, and iron ore. Ecotourism is growing. Possible oil and gas reserves. Landlocked: high transportation costs.



INSIGHT: *Rwanda's parliament in 2008 was the first in the world to have more women members than men*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Rwanda

DATE OF FORMATION: 1962

CAPITAL: Kigali

POPULATION: 10 million

TOTAL AREA: 10,169 sq. miles
(26,338 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1038 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kinyarwanda*, French*, Kiswahili, English*

RELIGIONS: Catholic 56%, traditional beliefs 25%, Muslim 10%, Protestant 9%

ETHNIC MIX: Hutu 90%, Tutsi 9%, other (including Twa) 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Rwanda franc = 100 centimes



St. Kitts & Nevis

A popular Caribbean tourist destination, St. Kitts and Nevis lies in the northern part of the Leeward Island chain. Nevis is the smaller and less developed of the two islands.



GEOGRAPHY

Volcanic in origin, with forested, mountainous interiors. Nevis has hot and cold springs.



CLIMATE

Tropical, tempered by trade winds. Little seasonal variation in temperature. Moderate rainfall.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The majority of the population are descended from former African slaves. There are small numbers of Europeans, and South Asians, and a community of Lebanese. Levels of emigration are high, and overseas remittances are an important source of national income. The government has pledged to retrain sugar workers. Native professionals and civil servants have largely replaced the former expatriate elite. The secessionist movement on Nevis remains an issue.



THE ECONOMY

Successful tourist industry is vulnerable to downturns in US market. Financial services. Once-key sugar industry closed down in 2005.



INSIGHT: *Nevis has been renowned as a spa since the 18th century, and is known as the "Queen of the Caribbean"*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Federation of Saint Christopher and Nevis

DATE OF FORMATION: 1983

CAPITAL: Basseterre

POPULATION: 46,100

TOTAL AREA: 101 sq. miles (261 sq. km)

DENSITY: 332 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, English Creole

RELIGIONS: Anglican 33%, Methodist 29%, other 22%, Moravian 9%, Roman Catholic 7%

ETHNIC MIX: Black 95%, Mixed race 3%, White 1%, other and Amerindian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: East Caribbean \$ = 100 cents

St. Lucia



St. Lucia is one of the most beautiful of the Caribbean Windward Islands. Ruled by France and the UK at different times in its past, the island retains the character of both.



GEOGRAPHY

Volcanic and mountainous, with some broad fertile valleys. The Pitons, ancient lava cones, rise from the sea on the forested west coast.



CLIMATE

Tropical, moderated by trade winds. May–October wet season brings daily warm showers. Rainfall is highest in the mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Population is a tension-free mixture of descendants of Africans, Caribs, and Europeans. Family life and the Roman Catholic Church are important to most St. Lucians. In rural areas, women often head the households and run much of the farming. Plantation and hotel owners are the richest group. There is growing local resistance to overdevelopment of the island for tourism.

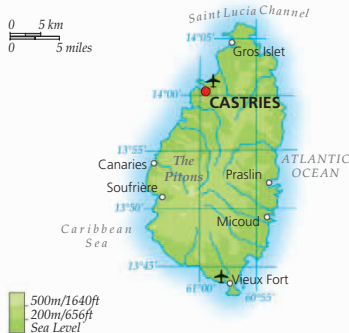


THE ECONOMY

Bananas are still biggest export, but struggling to compete since loss of preferential access to EU market. Successful tourism. Offshore banking.



INSIGHT: *St. Lucia has two Nobel laureates, the most per capita in the world*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Saint Lucia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1979

CAPITAL: Castries

POPULATION: 172,200

TOTAL AREA: 239 sq. miles
(620 sq. km)

DENSITY: 730 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, French Creole

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 90%,
other 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Black 83%, Mixed race 13%,
Asian 3%, White 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: East Caribbean dollar =
100 cents



St. Vincent & the Grenadines

The islands of St. Vincent and the Grenadines form part of the Windward group in the Caribbean. St. Vincent is mostly volcanic, while the Grenadines are flat, mainly bare, coral reefs.



GEOGRAPHY

St. Vincent is mountainous and forested, with one of two active volcanoes in the Caribbean, La Soufrière. The Grenadines are 32 islands and cays, fringed by beaches



CLIMATE

Tropical, with constant trade winds. Hurricanes are likely during July–November wet season.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Population is racially diverse; intermarriage has reduced tensions. Society is informal and relaxed, but family life is strongly influenced by the Christian Church. Locals fear that their traditional lifestyle is being threatened by the expanding tourist industry.



INSIGHT: *The islands' precolonial inhabitants, the Carib, named them "Harioun" – home of the blessed*



THE ECONOMY

Dependent on agriculture and tourism. Bananas are the main cash crop. Tourism, targeted at the jet-set and cruise-ship markets, is concentrated on the Grenadines.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Saint Vincent and the Grenadines

DATE OF FORMATION: 1979

CAPITAL: Kingstown

POPULATION: 109,200

TOTAL AREA: 150 sq. miles (389 sq. km)

DENSITY: 834 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, English Creole

RELIGIONS: Anglican 47%, Methodist 28%, Roman Catholic 13%, other 12%

ETHNIC MIX: Black 77%, Mixed race 16%, other 3%, Carib 3%, Asian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: East Caribbean dollar = 100 cents

Samoa



The Pacific islands of Samoa gained independence from New Zealand in 1962. Four of the nine volcanic islands are inhabited – Apolima, Manono, Savai'i, and Upolu.



GEOGRAPHY

Comprises two large islands and seven smaller ones. The two largest islands have rainforested, mountainous interiors surrounded by coastal lowlands and coral reefs.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with high humidity. Cooler in May–November. Cyclone season is December–March.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnic Samoans are the world's second-largest Polynesian group, after the Maoris. Their way of life is communal and formalized. Extended family groups own 80% of the land. Each family has an elected chief, who looks after its political and social interests. Large-scale migration to the US and New Zealand reflects the country's lack of jobs and the attractions of a Western lifestyle.



THE ECONOMY

Exports fish, coconut products (oil, cream, copra), and nonu fruit. Growth of tourism, offshore banking, and light manufacturing (Japanese car parts). Dependent on aid and expatriate remittances. Rainforests are increasingly exploited for timber.



INSIGHT: *Samoa was named for the sacred (sa) chickens (moa) of Lu, son of Tagaloa, the god of creation*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Independent State of Samoa

DATE OF FORMATION: 1962

CAPITAL: Apia

POPULATION: 178,800

TOTAL AREA: 1104 sq. miles
(2860 sq. km)

DENSITY: 164 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Samoan*, English*

RELIGIONS: Christian 99%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Polynesian 90%,
Eurasian (mixed European and
Polynesian) 9%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Tala = 100 sene



San Marino

Perched on the slopes of Monte Titano in the Italian Apennines, San Marino has maintained its independence since the 4th century CE, but Italy effectively controls most of its affairs.



GEOGRAPHY

Distinctive limestone outcrop of Monte Titano dominates wooded hills and pastures near Italy's Adriatic coast.



CLIMATE

High altitude and sea breezes moderate a Mediterranean climate. Hot summers and cool, wet winters.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Territory is divided into nine "castles," or districts. Tightly knit society, with 16 centuries of tradition. Strict immigration rules require 30-year residence before applying for citizenship. Living standards are similar to those in northern Italy. About 20,000 Sammarinesi live abroad, most in Italy.



INSIGHT: Sales of postage stamps and coins contribute around 10% of the national income



THE ECONOMY

Tourism provides over half of GDP. Banking: transparency has improved. Lower tax rates than Italy. Wine, cheese, olive oil, textiles, and ceramics are exported. Also relies on Italian subsidy and infrastructure.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of San Marino

DATE OF FORMATION: 1631

CAPITAL: San Marino

POPULATION: 31,400

TOTAL AREA: 23.6 sq. miles
(61 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1308 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Italian

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 93%, other and nonreligious 7%

ETHNIC MIX: Sammarinese 88%, Italian 10%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents

São Tomé & Príncipe



A former Portuguese colony, São Tomé and Príncipe comprises two main islands and surrounding islets, off the west coast of Africa. Elections in 1991 ended 15 years of Marxism.



GEOGRAPHY

Islands scattered across the equator. São Tomé and Príncipe are heavily forested and mountainous.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid, but cooled by the Benguela Current. Plentiful rainfall.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Population is mostly black, though Portuguese culture predominates. Blacks run the political parties. Society is well integrated and free of racial prejudice. Príncipe assumed autonomous status in 1995. There is a growing business class. Extended family offers main form of social security. One of Africa's highest aid-to-population ratios.

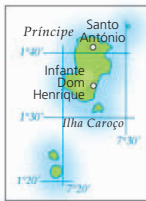
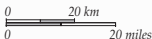


INSIGHT: The population is entirely of immigrant descent: the islands were uninhabited when colonized in 1470



THE ECONOMY

Cocoa provides 95% of export earnings. Coconuts, pepper, coffee also farmed. Tourism potential. Offshore oil may come onstream in 2012.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Democratic Republic of São Tomé and Príncipe

DATE OF FORMATION: 1975

CAPITAL: São Tomé

POPULATION: 162,800

TOTAL AREA: 386 sq. miles (1001 sq. km)

DENSITY: 439 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Portuguese Creole, Portuguese*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 84%, other 16%

ETHNIC MIX: Black 90%, Portuguese and Creole 10%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Dobra = 100 céntimos



Saudi Arabia

Occupying most of the Arabian Peninsula, Saudi Arabia covers an area the size of western Europe. It is the world's largest oil producer and has a major petrochemicals industry.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly desert or semidesert plateau. Mountain ranges in the west run parallel to the Red Sea and drop steeply to a coastal plain.



CLIMATE

In summer, temperatures often soar above 118°F (48°C), but in winter they may fall below freezing. Rainfall is rare.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Saudis are Sunni Muslims who follow the strictly orthodox Wahhabi interpretation of Islam and embrace sharia (Islamic law) in their daily lives. Women are obliged to wear the veil, cannot hold a driver's license, and have no role in public life. The al-Sa'ud family has had absolute rule since 1932. With the support of the religious establishment, it controls all political life.



THE ECONOMY

Vast oil and natural gas reserves. A third of workers are foreign. Attractive jobs for young Saudis are scarce, however.



INSIGHT: Three million Muslims a year make the haj (pilgrimage) to the holy city of Mecca. Only practicing Muslims are allowed inside the city



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Saudi Arabia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1932

CAPITALS: Riyadh

POPULATION: 25.7 million

TOTAL AREA: 756,981 sq. miles
(1,960,582 sq. km)

DENSITY: 32 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic

RELIGIONS: (Native population) Sunni Muslim 85%, Shi'a Muslim 15%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 72%, foreign (mostly S or SE Asian) 20%, Afro-Asian 8%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Saudi riyal = 100 halalat

Senegal



Senegal's capital, Dakar, stands on the westernmost cape of Africa. After independence from France, Senegal became a single-party state, but it has had multiparty elections since 1981.



GEOGRAPHY

Arid semidesert in the north. The south is mainly savanna bushland. Plains in the southeast.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with humid rainy conditions June–October, and a drier season December–May. The coast is cooled by northern trade winds.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Interethnic marriage has reduced ethnic tensions. Groups can be identified regionally. Dakar is a Wolof area, the Senegal River is dominated by the Toucouleur, and the Malinké mostly live in the east. The Diola (Jola) in Casamance have felt politically excluded, prompting a long-running secessionist struggle; a cease-fire has held since 2004. A large diaspora has raised global awareness of Senegalese culture and music.



THE ECONOMY

Good infrastructure, particularly port at Dakar. Fishing (though stocks diminishing). Remittances. Phosphate mining. Groundnuts. Development of tourism. Oil potential off Casamance.



INSIGHT: *Senegal's name derives from the Muslim Zenaga Berbers who invaded in the 1300s*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Senegal

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Dakar

POPULATION: 12.5 million

TOTAL AREA: 75,749 sq. miles
(196,190 sq. km)

DENSITY: 169 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Wolof, Serer, Pulaar, Diola, Mandinka, Malinké, Soninké, French*

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 90%, traditional beliefs 5%, Christian 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Wolof 43%, Serer 15%, other 14%, Peul 14%, Toucouleur 9%, Diola 5%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes



Serbia

The central and eastern region of what was once Yugoslavia, Serbia was a pariah state until Slobodan Milosevic was ousted in 2000. Montenegro broke away in 2006, and Kosovo in 2008.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Landlocked since secession of Montenegro. Fertile Danube plain in the north, rolling uplands in the center and southeast. Mountains in southwest.

**CLIMATE**

Continental in north, with wet springs and warm summers. Colder winters with heavy snow in south.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

Serbs are Orthodox Christian, and their language uses Cyrillic script. The Catholic Magyars (Hungarians) live mainly in Vojvodina, which has been granted some autonomy. Society was severely shaken in the 1990s by interethnic conflict. EU integration is dependent on Serbia's cooperation in apprehending suspected war criminals.



INSIGHT: *The medieval Serbian Empire reached into northern Greece*

**THE ECONOMY**

Recovering from sanctions and 1999 NATO bombing: GDP is only just back to pre-1990 level. Reserves of coal, oil. Strong industrial base. Privatization ongoing. Foreign investment growing. Danube is a key transportation link.

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Serbia

DATE OF FORMATION: 2006

CAPITAL: Belgrade

POPULATION: 7.75 million

TOTAL AREA: 34,116 sq. miles

(88,361 sq. km)

DENSITY: 259 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Serbian*, Hungarian

RELIGIONS: Orthodox Christian 85%, other 6%, Roman Catholic 6%, Muslim 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Serb 83%, other 10%, Magyar 4%, Bosniak 2%, Roma 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Dinar = 100 para

Seychelles



Formerly a UK colony, the Seychelles comprises 115 islands in the Indian Ocean. After 14 years as a one-party state, multiparty elections were introduced in 1993.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly low-lying coral atolls, but 40, including the largest, Mahé, are mountainous and are the only granitic midocean islands in the world.



CLIMATE

Tropical oceanic climate. Hot and humid. Rainy season December–May.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The islands were uninhabited when French settlers arrived in the 18th century. Today, the population is homogeneous – a result of inter-marriage between ethnic groups. Almost 90% of people live on Mahé. Living standards are among Africa's highest. Poverty is rare and the welfare system caters to all.

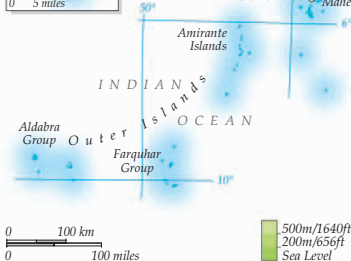


INSIGHT: The Seychelles' unique species include the coco-de-mer palm, which produces the world's largest seeds



THE ECONOMY

Tourism is main sector, based on appeal of beaches and exotic wildlife. Tuna is fished and canned for export. Re-export trade. Virtually no mineral resources. All domestic requirements are imported. High debt-servicing burden. Lack of foreign exchange.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Seychelles

DATE OF FORMATION: 1976

CAPITAL: Victoria

POPULATION: 84,600

TOTAL AREA: 176 sq. miles
(455 sq. km)

DENSITY: 813 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Creole*, English*, French*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 90%, Anglican 8%, other (including Muslim) 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Creole 89%, Indian 5%, other 4%, Chinese 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Seychelles rupee = 100 cents



Sierra Leone

The west African state of Sierra Leone achieved independence from the UK in 1961. Today, trying to recover from ten years of devastating civil war, it is one of the world's poorest nations.



GEOGRAPHY

Flat plain, running the length of the coast, stretches inland for 83 miles (133 km). Beyond, forests rise to highlands near neighboring Guinea in the northeast.



CLIMATE

Hot tropical weather, with very high rainfall and humidity. The dusty, northeastern *harmattan* wind blows November–April.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Mende and Temne are the major ethnic groups. Freetown's citizens are largely descended from slaves freed from Britain and the US, resulting in a strongly Anglicized Creole culture in the capital. The countryside is less developed. A brutal civil war broke out in 1991 and was not properly resolved until a 2001 peace agreement. Two million people were displaced during the conflict.



THE ECONOMY

Aid is vital: reconstruction will take years. Diamond exports, though smuggling is rife. Rutile and bauxite also mined. Coffee and cocoa are cash crops, but most farming is subsistence.



INSIGHT: *The British philanthropist Granville Sharp set up a settlement for freed slaves in Freetown in 1787*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Sierra Leone

DATE OF FORMATION: 1961

CAPITAL: Freetown

POPULATION: 5.7 million

TOTAL AREA: 27,698 sq. miles
(71,740 sq. km)

DENSITY: 206 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Mende, Temne, Krio, English*

RELIGIONS: Muslim 30%, traditional beliefs 30%, other 30%, Christian 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Mende 35%, Temne 32%, other 21%, Limba 8%, Kuranko 4%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Leone = 100 cents

Singapore



Linked to the southernmost tip of the Malay peninsula by a causeway, Singapore was established as a trading settlement in 1819. It is one of Asia's most important commercial centers.



GEOGRAPHY

Little remains of the original vegetation on Singapore Island. The other 54 much smaller islands are little more than swampy jungle.



CLIMATE

Equatorial. Hot and humid, with heavy rainfall all year round.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Dominated by the Chinese, who make up three-quarters of the community. The old English-speaking Straits Chinese and newer Mandarin-speakers are now well integrated. Malays are generally the poorest group. The population is skilled and industrious; there is a significant foreign workforce. Society is highly regulated; official campaigns aim to improve public behavior. Crime is limited and punishment can be severe.



THE ECONOMY

Wealth from success as entrepôt and center of high-tech industries, such as electronics and pharmaceuticals. Leads research in new biotechnologies. All food, energy, and water imported. Worst-ever recession in 2008–2009.



INSIGHT: Chewing gum was banned outright from 1992 to 2004



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Singapore

DATE OF FORMATION: 1965

CAPITAL: Singapore

POPULATION: 4.74 million

TOTAL AREA: 250 sq. miles
(648 sq. km)

DENSITY: 20,072 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Mandarin*, Malay*, Tamil*, English*

RELIGIONS: Buddhist 55%, Taoist 22%, Muslim 16%, Hindu, Christian, Sikh 7%

ETHNIC MIX: Chinese 77%, Malay 14%, Indian 8%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Singapore dollar = 100 cents



Slovakia



Landlocked in central Europe, Slovakia became a separate state in 1993, splitting ex-communist Czechoslovakia in two. It joined the EU in 2004 and the eurozone five years later.

**GEOGRAPHY**

The Tatra Mountains stretch along the northern border with Poland. Southern lowlands include the fertile Danube plain.

**CLIMATE**

Continental. Moderately warm summers and steady rainfall. Cold winters with heavy snowfalls.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

The majority Slovaks are the dominant group. The Magyars (Hungarians) seek protection of their language and culture, backed by Hungary. Magyar parties exist in the political mainstream, and on occasion form part of the ruling coalition. Ethnic Czechs have dual citizenship. Roma are unrepresented and face significant discrimination. Rural eastern regions are least developed.

**THE ECONOMY**

Emphasis on heavy industry, especially cars. Inexpensive workforce. Rising foreign investment. Successful privatizations. Strong growth until 2009 recession. High unemployment.



INSIGHT: From 1526 to 1784 Bratislava, then known as Pozsony, served as the capital of Hungary

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Slovak Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1993

CAPITAL: Bratislava

POPULATION: 5.41 million

TOTAL AREA: 18,859 sq. miles
(48,845 sq. km)

DENSITY: 286 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Slovak*, Hungarian (Magyar), Czech

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 60%, other 22%, Atheist 10%, Protestant 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Slovak 86%, Magyar 10%, Roma 2%, Czech 1%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents

Slovenia



Lying at the junction of central Europe and the Balkans, Slovenia seceded from socialist Yugoslavia in 1991. In 2004, it became the first former Yugoslav state to join the EU.



GEOGRAPHY

Alpine terrain with hills and mountains. Forests cover almost half the country's area. There is a short coastline on the Adriatic Sea.



CLIMATE

Mediterranean climate on the small coastal strip. The alpine interior has continental extremes.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Long historical association with western Europe, accounts for the "Alpine" rather than "Balkan" outlook of Slovenia's people, despite close similarities to other former Yugoslavs. The absence of sizable Serb or Croat minorities made for a relatively peaceful secession from Yugoslavia. There are small communities of Italians and Magyars (Hungarians) in the southwest and east respectively.



THE ECONOMY

First new EU member to join eurozone (in 2007). Export-oriented, so vulnerable to global economic trends. Competitive manufacturing industry. Sizable state-owned sector remains.



INSIGHT: A wheel found in a marsh in 2003 is claimed to be the world's oldest, pre-dating 3000 BCE



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Slovenia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Ljubljana

POPULATION: 2.02 million

TOTAL AREA: 7820 sq. miles

(20,253 sq. km)

DENSITY: 258 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Slovenian*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 96%, other 3%, Muslim 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Slovene 83%, other 12%, Serb 2%, Croat 2%, Bosniak 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents



Solomon Islands

The Solomons archipelago comprises several hundred coral reef islands scattered in the southwestern Pacific. Most of the population live on the six largest islands.



GEOGRAPHY

The six largest islands are volcanic, mountainous, and thickly forested. Flat coastal plains provide the only cultivable land.



CLIMATE

Northern islands are hot and humid all year round; farther south a cool season develops. November–April wet season brings cyclones.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

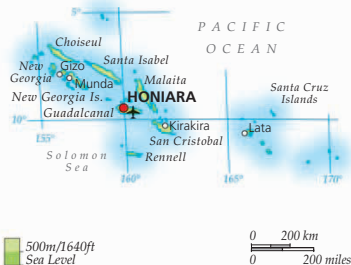
Almost all Solomon Islanders are Melanesian. Tensions are regional; Guadalcanal natives (Isatabu) fought against immigrant Malaitan workers in the 1998–2000 conflict, displacing thousands and ruining the economy. In 2003, Australian-led peacekeepers arrived to try to restore the rule of law. Outlying islands have pressed for autonomy. Animist beliefs exist alongside Christianity.



THE ECONOMY

Subsistence farming and fishing sustain 75% of people. Cash crops are copra and cocoa. Gold deposits. Civil conflict bankrupted the government, closed the main gold mine, and cut trade links. Forests have been depleted.

INSIGHT: *The battle for Japanese-held Guadalcanal was the first major US offensive in the Pacific War during World War II*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Solomon Islands

DATE OF FORMATION: 1978

CAPITAL: Honiara

POPULATION: 523,200

TOTAL AREA: 10,985 sq. miles
(28,450 sq. km)

DENSITY: 48 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Pidgin English, Melanesian Pidgin, c. 120 others

RELIGIONS: Anglican 34%, Catholic 19%, other Protestant 38%, other 9%

ETHNIC MIX: Melanesian 94%, Polynesian 4%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Solomon Is. dollar = 100 cents

Somalia



A semiarid state occupying the Horn of Africa, Somalia was formed from the Italian and British colonies of Somaliland. Conflict has left it without effective government since 1991.



GEOGRAPHY

Highlands in the north, flatter scrub-covered land to the south. Coastal areas are more fertile.



CLIMATE

Very dry, except for the north coast, which is hot and humid. The interior has among the world's highest average annual temperatures.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The clan system forms the basis of all commercial, political, and social life. Most people are ethnic Somali. The minority Bantu are traditionally seen as socially inferior. Since the 1991 coup, Somalia has lacked a strong central authority. Somaliland has declared independence, while Puntland claims autonomy. Islamist militias now control most of the country: some have joined the latest attempt at a transitional government, but fighting continues.

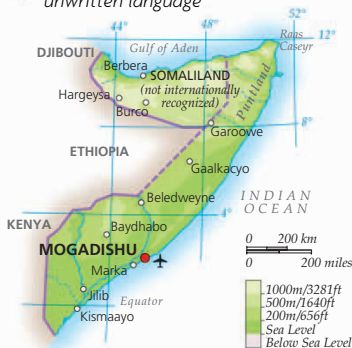


THE ECONOMY

Ongoing war. Every commodity, except arms, is in short supply. Piracy and banditry. Few natural resources. Prone to drought. Somaliland region is more stable, but its trade is hampered by lack of international recognition.



INSIGHT: Until 1973, Somali was an unwritten language



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Somalia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Mogadishu

POPULATION: 9.13 million

TOTAL AREA: 246,199 sq. miles
(637,657 sq. km)

DENSITY: 38 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Somali*, Arabic*, English, Italian

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 98%, Christian 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Somali 85%, other 15%

GOVERNMENT: Transitional regime

CURRENCY: Somali shilin = 100 senti



South Africa



After 80 years of white minority rule, South Africa held its first multiracial, multiparty elections in 1994. Victory for the blacks marked the symbolic overturning of long years of apartheid.



GEOGRAPHY

Much of the interior is grassy veld. Desert in the west and far north. Mountains east, south, and west.



CLIMATE

Warm, temperate, and dry. Cape Town has a Mediterranean climate. Semi-arid in the west.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The majority black population now dominates politically, but the minority white community still controls the economy. A small black middle class is growing, but unemployment among blacks remains high. Over five million people are HIV-positive, but the fight against AIDS is hampered by social attitudes. Violent crime is a problem.

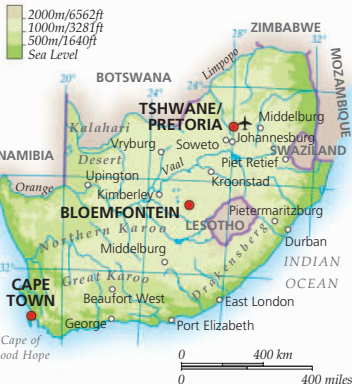


INSIGHT: Over the last century, South Africa has produced over half of the world's gold



THE ECONOMY

Africa's largest, most developed economy. Leading mineral producer, notably metals, diamonds, coal. Tourism is also key. Wealth gap has widened: jobs, housing, and better access to basic services are needed to fight poverty.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of South Africa

DATE OF FORMATION: 1934

CAPITAL: Tshwane / Pretoria; Cape Town; Bloemfontein

POPULATION: 50.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 471,008 sq. miles (1,219,912 sq. km)

DENSITY: 106 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, isiZulu*, isiXhosa*, Afrikaans*, 7 other official languages*

RELIGIONS: Christian 68%, animist and traditional beliefs 29%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Black 79%, White 10%, Mixed race 9%, Asian 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Rand = 100 cents

Spain



Lodged between Europe, Africa, the North Atlantic, and the Mediterranean, Spain has occupied a pivotal global position since unification under Ferdinand and Isabella in 1492.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountain ranges in the north, center, and south, with a huge central plateau. Mediterranean lowlands. Verdant valleys in the northwest.



CLIMATE

Maritime in north. Hotter and drier in south. The central plateau has an extreme climate.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

A vigorous ethnic regionalism, suppressed under Franco's fascist regime, now flourishes. There are 17 autonomous regions. People remain churchgoing, though Roman Catholic teachings on social issues are often flouted. Spanish women are increasingly emancipated, with strong political representation.



INSIGHT: Over 3000 festivals and feasts take place each year in Spain



THE ECONOMY

Decade of sustained growth, until construction boom ended in 2007, followed by global recession: unemployment soared. Large fishing fleet. Few natural resources. Proximity to Africa makes it a target for would-be economic migrants.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Spain

DATE OF FORMATION: 1492

CAPITAL: Madrid

POPULATION: 44.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 194,896 sq. miles
(504,782 sq. km)

DENSITY: 233 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Catalan*, Galician*, Basque*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 96%, other 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Spanish 72%, Catalan 17%, Galician 6%, other 3%, Basque 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents



Sri Lanka



The teardrop-shaped island of Sri Lanka is separated from India by the Palk Strait. Ethnic Tamil rebels – the Tamil Tigers – were defeated in 2009, after a brutal 26-year civil war.



GEOGRAPHY

The main island is dominated by rugged central highlands. Fertile northern plains are dissected by rivers. Much of the land is tropical jungle.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with breezes on the coast and cooler air in highlands. Northeast is driest and hottest.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Sinhalese are mostly Buddhist, while Tamils are mostly Hindu. Moors are the Muslim descendants of Arab traders. Tamils were the minority group favored by the British colonists. Majority-Sinhalese power since independence in 1948 fueled tensions, erupting into civil war in 1983. The eventual government victory in 2009 made this the only rebel insurgency ever defeated in modern times.

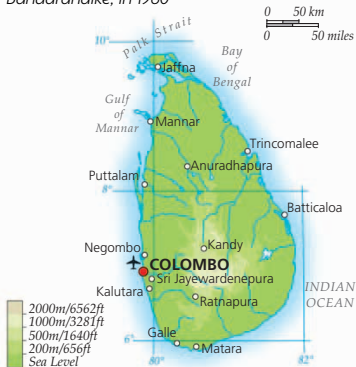


THE ECONOMY

Garment industry. Remittances. Major tea exporter. Civil war drained government funds, deterred investors and tourists. Tsunami damage in 2004.



INSIGHT: Sri Lanka elected the world's first woman prime minister, Sirimavo Bandaranaike, in 1960



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Democratic Socialist Republic of Sri Lanka

DATE OF FORMATION: 1948

CAPITAL: Colombo

POPULATION: 20.2 million

TOTAL AREA: 25,332 sq. miles
(65,610 sq. km)

DENSITY: 810 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Sinhala*, Tamil*, English

RELIGIONS: Buddhist 69%, Hindu 15%, Muslim 8%, Christian 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Sinhalese 82%, Tamil 9%, Moor 8%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Sri Lanka rupee = 100 cents

Sudan



The largest country in Africa, Sudan has undergone two civil wars between its Arab north and black African south. Darfur in the west now endures a terrible humanitarian crisis.



GEOGRAPHY

Lies within the upper Nile basin. Mostly arid plains, with marshes in the south. Highlands border the Red Sea in the northeast.



CLIMATE

North is hot, arid desert with constant dry winds. Rainy season ranging from two months in the center to eight in the south.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Two million people are nomads. Many ethnic groups. Key social divide is between Arabized Muslims in north, and mostly black African, largely Christian or animist peoples in south. Attempts to impose Arab and Islamic values were the root cause of civil war (1955–1972, 1983–2005). Ethnic violence by Arab militias in Darfur since 2003 has killed 300,000 people: huge refugee crisis. Women's rights are restricted.



THE ECONOMY

Oil exports. Cotton, sesame, gum arabic. Violence and drought hamper farming. Millions of people displaced.



INSIGHT: *Sudan's Sudd is the world's largest swamp*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of the Sudan

DATE OF FORMATION: 1956

CAPITAL: Khartoum

POPULATION: 42.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 967,493 sq. miles
(2,505,810 sq. km)

DENSITY: 44 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, African languages

RELIGIONS: Muslim 70%, traditional beliefs 20%, Christian 9%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Black 59% (including Beja and Dinka 7%), Arab 40%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Sudanese pound or dinar
= 100 piastres



Suriname

Suriname is a former Dutch colony on the north coast of South America. Democracy was restored in 1991, after almost 11 years of military rule. The Netherlands is still the main supplier of aid.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly covered by tropical rainforest. Coastal plain rises to central plateaus and the Guiana Highlands.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Hot and humid, but cooled by trade winds. High rainfall, especially in the interior.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Dutch brought laborers from South Asia and Java. Independence saw mass emigration: over 300,000 Surinamese live in the Netherlands. Of those left, over 85% live near the coast, the rest in scattered rainforest communities. Indigenous Amerindians only number a few thousand. *Bosnegers* – descended from runaway African slaves – fought the military government in the late 1980s. Under civilian rule, each group has had a political party representing its interests.



THE ECONOMY

Alumina and gold are the key exports. Rice and bananas are main cash crops. Oil production and tourism are growing. Excessive bureaucracy.



INSIGHT: In a 1667 Anglo-Dutch deal, Holland gained Suriname but lost New Amsterdam (now New York)



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Suriname

DATE OF FORMATION: 1975

CAPITAL: Paramaribo

POPULATION: 519,700

TOTAL AREA: 63,039 sq. miles
(163,270 sq. km)

DENSITY: 8 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Sranan (Creole), Dutch*, Javanese, Sarnami, Hindi, other

RELIGIONS: Christian 48%, Hindu 27%, Muslim 20%, traditional beliefs 5%

ETHNIC MIX: South Asian 27%, other 25%, Creole 18%, Javanese 15%, Black 15%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Surinamese dollar = 100 cents

Swaziland



The tiny southern African kingdom of Swaziland is crippled with HIV/AIDS and economically dependent on South Africa. Vocal demands for multiparty democracy have been ignored.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly high plateaus and mountains. Rolling grasslands and low scrub plains to the east. Pine forests on western border.



CLIMATE

Temperatures rise and rainfall declines as the land descends eastward, from high to low grassy *veld*.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

One of Africa's most conservative states, though there is pressure from urban-based modernizers. Political system promotes Swazi tradition and is dominated by powerful monarchy. Women face discrimination. Swaziland has world's highest prevalence of HIV/AIDS: chastity is urged to combat its spread.



INSIGHT: Polygamy is practiced in Swaziland – when King Sobhuza died in 1982, he left 100 widows



THE ECONOMY

Sugarcane is the main cash crop. Wood pulp and soft drink concentrates are also exported. Loss of workforce to HIV/AIDS, and high cost of health care.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Swaziland

DATE OF FORMATION: 1968

CAPITAL: Mbabane

POPULATION: 1.18 million

TOTAL AREA: 6704 sq. miles
(17,363 sq. km)

DENSITY: 178 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, siSwati*, isiZulu, Xitsonga

RELIGIONS: Christian 60%, traditional beliefs 40%

ETHNIC MIX: Swazi 97%, other 3%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Lilangeni = 100 cents



Sweden



The largest Scandinavian country by both population and area, Sweden has one of the world's most extensive welfare systems and is among the leading proponents of equal rights for women.



GEOGRAPHY

Heavily forested, with many lakes. Northern plateau extends beyond the Arctic Circle. Southern lowlands are widely cultivated.



CLIMATE

Southern coasts warmed by Gulf Stream. Northern areas have more extreme continental climate.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The nuclear family forms the basis of society, but the marriage rate is one of the lowest in the world, and cohabitation is now common. The model welfare system is paid for by a high tax burden. Women are well represented at all levels. A minority of 20,000 Sámi lives in the far north. Most industries and the bulk of population are based in and around the southern cities. An EU member since 1995, Sweden has voted not to join the euro.



THE ECONOMY

Companies of global importance, including Volvo, Saab, SKF, Ericsson. Highly developed infrastructure. Up-to-date technology. Skilled workforce.



INSIGHT: Sweden has maintained a position of armed neutrality since 1815



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Sweden

DATE OF FORMATION: 1523

CAPITAL: Stockholm

POPULATION: 9.25 million

TOTAL AREA: 173,731 sq. miles
(449,964 sq. km)

DENSITY: 58 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Swedish*, Finnish, Sámi

RELIGIONS: Evangelical Lutheran 82%, other 13%, Roman Catholic 2%, Muslim 2%, Orthodox Christian 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Swedish 86%, recent immigrant 12%, Finnish and Sámi 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Swedish krona = 100 öre

Switzerland



One of the world's most prosperous countries, Switzerland sits at the center of Europe. It has retained its neutral status through every major European conflict since 1815.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly mountainous, with river valleys. The Alps cover 60% of its area; the Jura in the west cover 10%. Lowlands lie along the east–west axis.



CLIMATE

Most rain falls in the warm summer months. Winters are snowy, but milder and foggy away from the mountains. Avalanches are a problem.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Switzerland is composed of distinct German-Swiss, French-Swiss, and Italian-Swiss linguistic groups. In the east, a 35,000-strong minority speaks Romansch. The country is divided into 26 autonomous cantons (states), each with control over housing and economics. Public referenda are widely used to decide policy. Society is conservative; marriage is common but divorce is above the EU average rate.



THE ECONOMY

Diversified economy relies on services – the banking sector manages over a quarter of the world's offshore private wealth – and specialized industries (engineering, watches, etc).



INSIGHT: *Famed for its neutrality, Switzerland only joined the UN in 2002, and remains outside the EU*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Swiss Confederation

DATE OF FORMATION: 1291

CAPITAL: Bern

POPULATION: 7.57 million

TOTAL AREA: 15,942 sq. miles
(41,290 sq. km)

DENSITY: 493 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: German*, Swiss-German, French*, Italian*, Romansch*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 42%, Protestant 35%, other 19%, Muslim 4%

ETHNIC MIX: German 64%, French 20%, other 9.5%, Italian 6%, Romansch 0.5%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Franc = 100 rappen/centimes



Syria



Stretching from the eastern Mediterranean to the Tigris River, Syria's borders are regarded as an artificial creation of French colonial rule by many Syrians. Foreign relations are turbulent.



GEOGRAPHY

A short stretch of coastal plain is backed by a low range of hills. The Euphrates River cuts through a vast interior desert plateau.



CLIMATE

Mediterranean coastal climate. Inland areas are arid. In winter, snow is common on the mountains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Syrians live within 60 miles (100 km) of the coast. 90% are Muslim, including the politically dominant Shi'a Alawis. In the north and west are groups of Kurds, Armenians, and Turkic-speaking peoples. Some 460,000 Palestinian refugees live in Syria, and over a million Iraqis have fled here since 2003. There is a growing gulf between rich and poor. Human rights are an issue, but women's rights are among the best in the Arab world.



THE ECONOMY

Oil, though production is falling. Natural gas. High defense spending. Large public sector. Agriculture: fruit, cotton, and grain. Under US sanctions.



INSIGHT: *Syria is an ancient land; there are at least 3500 as yet unexcavated archaeological sites*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Syrian Arab Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1941

CAPITAL: Damascus

POPULATION: 21.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 71,498 sq. miles
(184,180 sq. km)

DENSITY: 308 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, French, Kurdish, Armenian, Circassian, Assyrian, other

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 74%, other Muslim 16%, Christian 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 89%, Kurd 6%, other 3%, Armenian, Turkmen, Circassian 2%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: Syrian pound = 100 piastres

Taiwan



The republic of Taiwan (formerly Formosa) is on an island 80 miles (130 km) off the southeast coast of mainland China, which still considers it to be a renegade province.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountain region covers two-thirds of the island. Highly fertile lowlands and coastal plains.



CLIMATE

Tropical monsoon. Hot and humid. Typhoons July–September. Snow falls in mountains in winter.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Taiwanese are Han Chinese, descendants of the 1644 migration of the Ming dynasty from the mainland. The modern republic was created in 1949, when the nationalist Kuomintang was expelled from the mainland following Communist victory in the civil war. 100,000 emigrés established themselves as a ruling class. Initial resentment has subsided as a new Taiwan-born generation has taken over the reins of power. The aboriginal minority suffers discrimination.

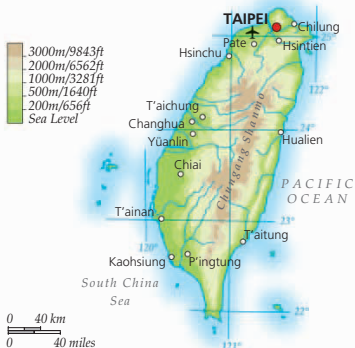


THE ECONOMY

Successful economy of small, adaptable companies. High-tech goods: TVs, computers, and semiconductors. Rising trade, investment with China.



INSIGHT: Taiwan lost its seat at the UN to Beijing in 1971: both claim to represent “China”



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of China (ROC)

DATE OF FORMATION: 1949

CAPITAL: Taipei

POPULATION: 23 million

TOTAL AREA: 13,892 sq. miles
(35,980 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1844 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Amoy Chinese, Mandarin Chinese*, Hakka Chinese

RELIGIONS: Buddhist, Confucianist, and Taoist 93%, Christian 5%, other 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Indigenous Chinese 84%, mainland Chinese 14%, aboriginal 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Taiwan dollar = 100 cents



Tajikistan

Tajikistan lies landlocked on the western slopes of the Pamirs in central Asia. Soon after the breakup of the USSR in 1991, civil war erupted between ruling communists and Islamists.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly mountainous: bare slopes of the Pamir ranges, with fast-flowing rivers, cover most of the country. Small but fertile Fergana Valley in northwest.



CLIMATE

Continental extremes in the valleys. Bitterly cold winters in the mountains. Rainfall is low.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Unlike the other former Soviet republics of central Asia, Tajikistan is dominated by a people of Persian (Iranian) rather than Turkic origin. The main ethnic conflict is with the Turkic Uzbek minority. Russians are discriminated against; most fled in the 1992–1997 civil war, and standards of living fell dramatically. Islamist militants are active. Two million people work abroad, primarily in Russia.



THE ECONOMY

Mass poverty. Declining cotton revenue. Also exports aluminum. Uranium deposits. Transit route for Afghan opium. Corruption. Needs reforms to attract foreign investment.



INSIGHT: *Carpet-making, an ancient tradition learned from Persia, is still a major source of revenue*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Tajikistan

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Dushanbe

POPULATION: 6.95 million

TOTAL AREA: 55,251 sq. miles
(143,100 sq. km)

DENSITY: 126 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Tajik*, Uzbek, Russian

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 80%, other 15%, Shi'a Muslim 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Tajik 80%, Uzbek 15%, other 3%, Kyrgyz 1%, Russian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Somoni = 100 diram

Tanzania



The east African state of Tanzania was formed in 1964 by the union of Tanganyika and the Zanzibar islands. A third of its area is game reserve or national park.



GEOGRAPHY

The mainland is mostly a high plateau lying to the east of the Great Rift Valley. Forested coastal plain. Highlands in the north and south.



CLIMATE

Tropical on the coast and Zanzibar. Semiarid on central plateau, semitemperate in the highlands. March–May rains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

99% of people belong to one of 120 small ethnic Bantu groups. Arabs, Asians, and Europeans make up the remaining population. Use of Kiswahili as the lingua franca has eliminated ethnic rivalries. The majority of Tanzanians are subsistence farmers.



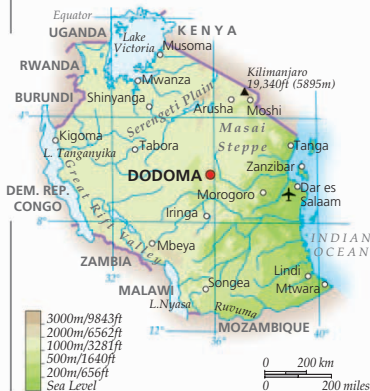
INSIGHT: At 19,340 ft (5895 m),

Kilimanjaro in northeast Tanzania is Africa's highest mountain



THE ECONOMY

Heavily reliant on agriculture, including forestry and cattle. Coffee, cotton, tea, cashew nuts, sisal, and cloves are cash crops. Gold, diamonds, and gems are mined. Safari and beach tourism. Debt relief.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: United Republic of Tanzania

DATE OF FORMATION: 1964

CAPITAL: Dodoma

POPULATION: 43.7 million

TOTAL AREA: 364,898 sq. miles
(945,087 sq. km)

DENSITY: 128 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kiswahili*, English*, other

RELIGIONS: Muslim 33%, Christian 33%, traditional beliefs 30%, other 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Native African (over 120 tribes) 99%, European, Asian, Arab 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Tanzanian shilling = 100 cents



Thailand



Thailand lies at the heart of mainland southeast Asia. Continuing rapid industrialization has resulted in massive congestion in the capital and a serious depletion of natural resources.



GEOGRAPHY

One-third is low plateau, drained by tributaries of the Mekong River. Central plain is the most fertile area.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Hot, humid March–May; monsoon rains May–October; cooler season November–March.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Buddhism is a national binding force. 600,000 hill tribes-people, with their own languages, live in the north and northeast. The Chinese minority is the most assimilated in the region. Malay Islamists in the undeveloped far south are fighting for secession. Politics has been unstable since the 2006 fall of pro-poor Prime Minister Thaksin.

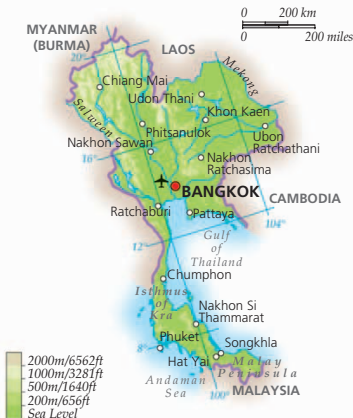


INSIGHT: *Thailand, meaning “land of the free,” is the only SE Asian nation never to have been colonized*



THE ECONOMY

Successful manufacturing. Natural gas reserves. Leading exporter of rice and rubber. Tourism, though sex industry harms image. 2004 tsunami damage.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Thailand

DATE OF FORMATION: 1238

CAPITAL: Bangkok

POPULATION: 67.8 million

TOTAL AREA: 198,455 sq. miles
(514,000 sq. km)

DENSITY: 344 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Thai*, Chinese, Malay, Khmer, Mon, Karen, Miao

RELIGIONS: Buddhist 95%, Muslim 4%, other (including Christian) 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Thai 83%, Chinese 12%, Malay 3%, Khmer and other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Baht = 100 satang

Togo



Togo lies sandwiched between Ghana and Benin in west Africa. General Eyadema ruled from 1967–2005; his son succeeded him. Lomé port is an important entrepôt for regional trade.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Central forested region bounded by savanna lands to the north and south. Mountain range stretches southwest to northeast.

**CLIMATE**

Coast hot and humid; drier inland. Rainy season March–July, with heaviest falls in the west.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

Harsh resentment between Ewe in the south and Kabye in the north. Kabye control the military, but the north is less developed than the south. Extended family is important. Tribalism and nepotism are key factors in everyday life. Some ethnic groups, such as the Mina, have matriarchal societies.



INSIGHT: The “Nana Benz,” the entrepreneurial market-women of Lomé, control Togo’s retail trade

**THE ECONOMY**

Most people are farmers. Self-sufficient in staple foods. Togo’s main cash crops are coffee and cocoa: cotton has declined. Its phosphate deposits are the most mineral-rich in the world, but easily extractable reserves are depleted and the sector needs investment.

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Togo

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Lomé

POPULATION: 6.62 million

TOTAL AREA: 21,924 sq. miles
(56,785 sq. km)

DENSITY: 315 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Ewe, Kabye, Gurma, French*

RELIGIONS: Traditional beliefs 50%, Christian 35%, Muslim 15%

ETHNIC MIX: Ewe 46%, other African 41%, Kabye 12%, European 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes



Tonga



Tonga is an archipelago of 170 islands in the South Pacific. Only 45 of these islands are inhabited. The king's powers have been challenged: democratic reforms are promised for 2010.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Easterly islands are generally low and fertile. Those in the west are higher and volcanic in origin.

**CLIMATE**

Tropical oceanic. Temperatures range between 68°F (20°C) and 86°F (30°C) all year round. Heavy rainfall, especially February–March.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

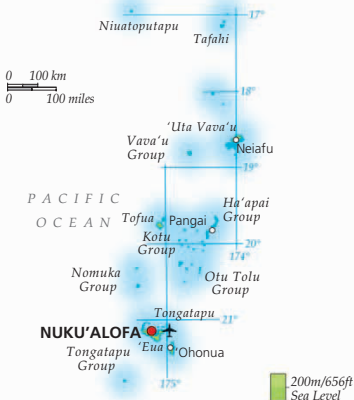
Tonga is the last remaining Polynesian monarchy. All land belongs to the crown, but is administered by nobles who allot it to the common people. Respect for traditional values is high, though younger, Westernized Tongans are starting to question some attitudes. The first elected commoner became prime minister in 2006.



INSIGHT: *Unique in the Pacific, Tonga was never brought under foreign rule*

**THE ECONOMY**

Squashes and vanilla exported. Remittances. Potential for tourism and fisheries. Capital's business district destroyed in 2006 prodemocracy riots.

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Tonga

DATE OF FORMATION: 1970

CAPITAL: Nuku'alofa

POPULATION: 104,000

TOTAL AREA: 289 sq. miles

(748 sq. km)

DENSITY: 374 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Tongan*

RELIGIONS: Free Wesleyan 41%, other 29%, Roman Catholic 16%, Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints 14%

ETHNIC MIX: Tongan 98%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Pa'anga (Tongan dollar)

= 100 seniti

Trinidad & Tobago



The two islands of the former UK colony of Trinidad and Tobago are the most southerly of the Caribbean Windward Islands, lying just 9 miles (15 km) off the coast of Venezuela.



GEOGRAPHY

Both islands are hilly and wooded. Trinidad has a rugged mountain range in the north, and swamps on its east and west coasts.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with July–December wet season. Escapes the region's hurricanes, which pass to the north.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Trinidad's East Indian community is the Caribbean's largest and holds onto its Muslim and Hindu heritage. There are tensions with the mainly Christian blacks; political parties are divided along race lines. Blacks form the majority on Tobago. High rates of kidnapping and murder are an issue.



INSIGHT: *Trinidad and Tobago is the birthplace of steel bands and Calypso music*



THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas: it provides 75% of US imports of liquefied natural gas, but only 12 years of reserves left. Associated industries: second-largest producer of methanol. Tourism on wildlife-rich Tobago.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Trinidad and Tobago

DATE OF FORMATION: 1962

CAPITAL: Port-of-Spain

POPULATION: 1.34 million

TOTAL AREA: 1980 sq. miles (5128 sq. km)

DENSITY: 676 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English Creole, English*, Hindi, French, Spanish

RELIGIONS: Catholic 32%, Hindu 24%, Protestant 28%, other 9%, Muslim 7%

ETHNIC MIX: East Indian 40%, Black 40%, Mixed race 18%, White, Chinese 1%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Trin. & Tob. dollar = 100 cents



Tunisia



Tunisia has traditionally been one of the more liberal Arab states, moving toward a multiparty democracy, but its government is now facing a challenge from Islamic fundamentalists.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountains in the north are surrounded by plains. Vast, low-lying salt pans in the center. To the south lies the Sahara Desert.



CLIMATE

Summer temperatures are high. The north is often wet and windy in winter. Far south is arid.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The population is almost entirely of Arab-Berber descent, with Jewish and Christian minorities. Many still live in extended family groups, in which three or four generations are represented. Women have better rights than in most other Arab countries and make up over 30% of the workforce. Parliamentary and municipal quotas aim to increase their representation in politics. A low birth rate is a result of a long-standing family planning policy.

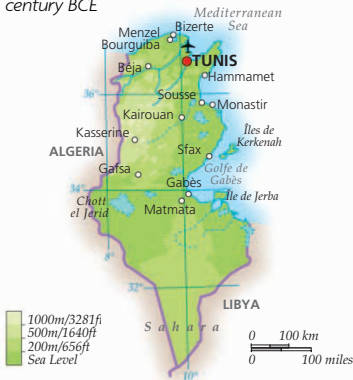


THE ECONOMY

Competitive and diversified. Expanding manufacturing. Exports olives, dates, citrus fruit, phosphates. Tourism. Free trade area with EU.



INSIGHT: *Tunisia was the center of trading empires from the 9th century BCE*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Tunisia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1956

CAPITAL: Tunis

POPULATION: 10.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 63,169 sq. miles
(163,610 sq. km)

DENSITY: 171 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, French

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 98%,
Christian 1%, Jewish 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab and Berber 98%, Jewish 1%,
European 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Tunisian dinar =
1000 millimes

Turkey



Lying partly in the region of eastern Thrace in Europe, but mostly in Asia, Turkey's position gives it significant influence in the Mediterranean, the Black Sea, and the Middle East.



GEOGRAPHY

Asian Turkey (Anatolia) is dominated by two mountain ranges, separated by a high, semidesert plateau. Coastal regions are fertile.



CLIMATE

Coast has a Mediterranean climate. Interior has cold, snowy winters and hot, dry summers.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Despite racial diversity, Turkey has a strong sense of national identity, and close links with other Turkic states. Kurds, the largest minority, based in the southeast, have waged a violent campaign for greater autonomy intermittently since 1984. Islamist parties are challenging Turkey's cherished identity as a secular state. It has applied to join the EU, though progress will be slow.



THE ECONOMY

Liberalized economy, boosted by self-sufficient agriculture, and textiles, tourism, and manufacturing sectors. Route of Asian oil pipelines to Europe.



INSIGHT: Turkey had two of the seven wonders of the ancient world: the tomb of King Mausolus at Halicarnassus (now Bodrum), and the temple of Artemis at Ephesus



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Turkey

DATE OF FORMATION: 1923

CAPITAL: Ankara

POPULATION: 74.8 million

TOTAL AREA: 301,382 sq. miles
(780,580 sq. km)

DENSITY: 252 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Turkish*, Kurdish, Arabic, Circassian, Armenian, Greek, other

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 99%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Turkish 70%, Kurdish 20%, other 8%, Arab 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: New Turkish lira = 100 kuruş



Turkmenistan

Stretching from the Caspian Sea into the central Asian desert, Turkmenistan has had less upheaval than most ex-Soviet states, but President Niyazov was a dictator.



GEOGRAPHY

Low Garagum Desert covers 80% of the country. Mountains on southern border with Iran. Fertile Amu Darya Valley in north.



CLIMATE

Arid desert climate with extreme summer heat, but sub-freezing winter temperatures.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Before Russia annexed the area in 1884, the Turkmen were a largely nomadic tribal people. Today, the tribal unit remains strong, with population clustered around desert oases. Relations with Uzbek and Russian minorities have become tense in recent years due to the "Turkmenization" of government, education, and religion. Political reform since Niyazov's sudden death in 2006 is slowly dismantling the old regime.



THE ECONOMY

State-controlled, though there is some private investment. Natural gas and oil are main resources. Overintensive farming of cotton. Black market.



INSIGHT: President Niyazov created an elaborate personality cult, styling himself as *Turkmenbashi* – "head" of all Turkmen



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Turkmenistan

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Ashgabat

POPULATION: 5.11 million

TOTAL AREA: 188,455 sq. miles
(488,100 sq. km)

DENSITY: 27 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Turkmen*, Uzbek, Russian, Kazakh, Tatar, other

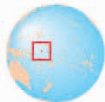
RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 87%, Orthodox Christian 11%, other 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Turkmen 77%, Uzbek 9%, Russian 7%, other 5%, Kazakh 2%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: Manat = 100 tenge

Tuvalu



One of the world's smallest, most isolated states, Tuvalu lies in the central Pacific. The nine islands were linked to the Gilbert Islands (Kiribati) as a UK colony until independence.



GEOGRAPHY

A series of coral atolls, none more than 15 ft (4.6 m) above sea level. Poor soils restrict vegetation to bush, coconut palms, and breadfruit trees.



CLIMATE

Hot all year round. Heavy annual rainfall. Hurricane season brings many violent storms.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

People are mostly Polynesian. Around half the population lives on Funafuti, where government jobs are based. Life is communal and traditional. Most people live by subsistence farming, digging pits out of the coral to grow crops. Fresh water is precious, due to frequent droughts.

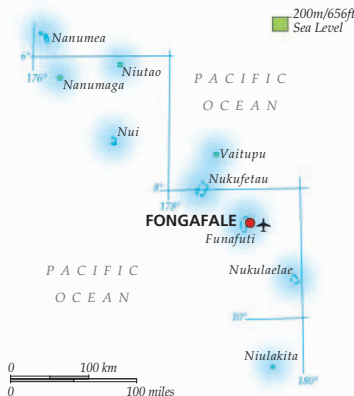


INSIGHT: Low-lying Tuvalu, like the Maldives, is set to disappear with rising sea levels



THE ECONOMY

World's smallest economy. Remittances from Tuvaluan seafarers. Sale of fishing licenses. Copra, stamps, and coins exported. Income from trust fund and the lease of .tv Internet suffix.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Tuvalu

DATE OF FORMATION: 1978

CAPITAL: Fongafale, on Funafuti Atoll

POPULATION: 11,100

TOTAL AREA: 10 sq. miles

(26 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1110 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Tuvaluan, Kiribati, English*

RELIGIONS: Church of Tuvalu 97%, Baha'i 1%, Seventh-day Adventist 1%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Polynesian 92%, other 6%, Kiribati 2%

GOVERNMENT: Nonparty system

CURRENCY: Australian dollar and

Tuvaluan dollar = 100 cents each



Uganda



Landlocked in east Africa, Uganda has a history of ethnic strife. Under President Museveni, steps have been taken to restore peace and to rebuild the economy and democracy.



GEOGRAPHY

Predominantly a large plateau with the Ruwenzori mountain range and the Great Rift Valley in the west. Lake Victoria lies to the southeast. Vegetation is of savanna type.



CLIMATE

Altitude and the influence of the lakes modify the equatorial climate. Rain falls throughout the year; spring is the wettest period.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The mostly rural population comprises some 13 main ethnic groups. President Museveni has worked hard to break down ethnic animosities, but a noticeable north-south divide persists, with most development in the south. After two decades of brutal conflict with northern rebels, a final peace deal has been mediated but not yet signed; many refugees have returned home.



THE ECONOMY

Resource-rich, but undeveloped and poor. Exports coffee, fish, tea, and flowers. Oil exploration. Hydroelectric power is reducing oil imports. Great potential from mining. Debt relief.



INSIGHT: *Lake Victoria is the world's third-largest lake*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Uganda

DATE OF FORMATION: 1962

CAPITAL: Kampala

POPULATION: 32.7 million

TOTAL AREA: 91,135 sq. miles
(236,040 sq. km)

DENSITY: 425 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Luganda, Nkole, Chiga, Lango, Acholi, Teso, Lugbara, English*

RELIGIONS: Catholic 38%, Protestant 33%, trad. beliefs 13%, Muslim 8%, other 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Baganda 17%, Banyakole 10%, Basoga 9%, Iteso 7%, other 57%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: New Ug. shilling = 100 cents

Ukraine



The former “breadbasket of the Soviet Union,” Ukraine lies on the north coast of the Black Sea. Politics is divided between pro-Russian sentiments and pro-European nationalism.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly fertile steppes and forests. Carpathian Mountains in west, Crimean chain in south. Pripet Marshes in northwest.



CLIMATE

Mainly continental climate, with distinct seasons. Southern Crimea has Mediterranean climate.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Over 90% of people in the west are Ukrainian, but in cities in the east and south, and in Crimea, Russians form a majority. The government is wary of Crimean separatism. Tatars have been returning there since the Soviet Union's collapse and now comprise around 12% of the local population. Over five million people in Ukraine, Belarus, and Russia live in areas “contaminated” by the 1986 Chernobyl nuclear disaster.



THE ECONOMY

Minerals: 5% of global reserves. Slow reform of land laws, holding back agriculture. Oil/natural gas transit from Russia and the Caspian to Europe: natural gas price disputes with Russia. Political crisis.



INSIGHT: *Ukraine means “on the border,” referring to its position on the edge of the old Russian Empire*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Ukraine

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Kiev

POPULATION: 45.7 million

TOTAL AREA: 223,089 sq. miles
(603,700 sq. km)

DENSITY: 196 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Ukrainian*, Russian, Tatar

RELIGIONS: Christian (mainly Orthodox) 95%, other 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Ukrainian 78%, Russian 17%, other 5%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Hryvna = 100 kopykas



United Arab Emirates

Bordering the Gulf on the northern coast of the Arabian Peninsula, the seven states of the UAE are Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman, Umm al Qaywayn, Ras al Khaymah, and Fujayrah.



GEOGRAPHY

Mostly flat, semiarid desert with dunes, salt pans, and occasional oases. Cities are watered by extensive irrigation systems.



CLIMATE

Summers are humid, despite minimal rainfall. Sand-laden *shamal* winds blow in winter and spring.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Emirians, who make up just a quarter of the population, are mostly Sunni Muslims of Bedouin descent, and largely city dwellers. In theory, women enjoy equal rights with men. Poverty is rare and there is no income tax. The 1970s oil boom encouraged the immigration of workers, mostly from Asia. Western expatriates are permitted a virtually unrestricted lifestyle. Islamism, however, is a growing force among the young.



THE ECONOMY

Major oil and natural gas exporter; plentiful reserves. Dynamic Dubai: free trade zone, financial center (but 2008 global downturn caught overextended banks). Water is scarce. Imports most food. Some emirates are less developed.



INSIGHT: *Mina Jabal Ali, in Dubai, is the largest man-made port in the world*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: United Arab Emirates

DATE OF FORMATION: 1971

CAPITAL: Abu Dhabi

POPULATION: 4.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 32,000 sq. km
(82,880 sq. km)

DENSITY: 142 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, Farsi, Indian and Pakistani languages, English

RELIGIONS: Muslim (mainly Sunni) 96%, Christian, Hindu, and other 4%

ETHNIC MIX: Asian 60%, Emirian 25%, other Arab 12%, European 3%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: UAE dirham = 100 fils

United Kingdom



Separated from continental Europe by the English Channel, the UK consists of Great Britain (England, Wales, and Scotland), several smaller islands, and Northern Ireland.



GEOGRAPHY

Rugged uplands dominate the landscape of Scotland, Wales, and northern England. All of the peaks in the United Kingdom over 4000 ft (1219 m) are in highland Scotland. The Pennine mountains, known as the “backbone of England,” run the length of northern England. Lowland England rises into several ranges of rolling hills, and there is an interconnected system of rivers and canals. Over 600 islands, many uninhabited, lie west and north of the Scottish mainland.



CLIMATE

Generally mild, temperate, and highly changeable. Rain is fairly well distributed throughout the year. The west is generally wetter than the east, and the south warmer than the north. Winter snow is common in upland areas.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Scottish and Welsh nations remain recognizably distinct, and the creation of the Scottish Parliament and Welsh Assembly has given each country greater political autonomy. The future of devolved government in Northern Ireland remains problematic. People from other ethnic minorities account for 5% of the population; more than half of them were born in the UK. Asians and West Indians in most cities face deprivation and social stress; Asian women can be particularly isolated. In key areas such as policing, multiethnic recruitment has made little progress. Marriage is in decline. Over 40% of all births occur outside marriage, but most of them to cohabiting couples. Single-parent households account for just over a quarter of all families. Income inequality is greater now than in 1884, when records began.

FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland

DATE OF FORMATION: 1707

CAPITAL: London

POPULATION: 61.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 94,525 sq. miles (244,820 sq. km)

DENSITY: 660 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Welsh*, other

RELIGIONS: Anglican 45%, other 39%, Catholic 9%, Presbyterian 4%, Muslim 3%

ETHNIC MIX: English 80%, Scottish 9%, other 5%, Welsh 3%, Northern Irish 3%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Pound sterling = 100 pence

THE ECONOMY

World leader in financial services, pharmaceuticals, and defense industries. Strong multinationals. Precision engineering and high-tech industries, including biotechnology and telecommunications. Energy sector based on declining North Sea oil and natural gas reserves. Innovative in computer software development. Flexible working practices. Long-term decline of manufacturing sector, particularly heavy industries and car manufacture, matched by rise in financial and other services. Nonparticipation

in euro threatens former status as EU's largest recipient of inward investment, and has prompted some major investors to close UK factories. High levels of government, corporate, and consumer debt: institutional vulnerability to 2007–2008 global downturn. Bank bailouts and stimulus packages pushed the government's finances further into the red.

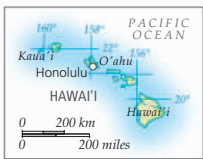
 **INSIGHT:** *The UK has no formal written constitution, but a stable government system based on Parliament, which originated as a check on royal power in the 13th century*



United States of America



Stretching across the most temperate part of North America, and with many natural resources, the US is the world's leading economic power and third-largest country.



GEOGRAPHY

The US has a varied topography. Forested mountains stretch from New England in the far northeast, giving way to lowlands and swamps in the extreme south. The central plains are dominated by the Mississippi–Missouri River system and the Great Lakes on the Canadian border. The Rocky Mountains in the west contain active volcanoes and drop to the coast across the earthquake-prone San Andreas Fault. The southwest is arid desert. Mountainous Alaska is mostly Arctic tundra.



CLIMATE

There are four main climatic zones. The north and east are continental and temperate, with heavy rainfall, warm summers, and cold winters. Florida and the Deep South are tropical and prone to hurricanes. The southwest is arid desert, with searing summer heat and low rainfall. Southern California is Mediterranean, with hot summers and mild winters.

INSIGHT: *The United States of America has the world's oldest constitution. Drafted in 1787, it has operated continuously ever since, albeit with numerous amendments*



United States of America



INSIGHT: By law, the actual records collected in a United States census must remain confidential for 72 years



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Although the demographic, economic, and cultural dominance of White Americans is firmly entrenched after over 400 years of settlement, the ethnic balance of the country is shifting. Barack Obama, whose father was African, became the first non-White US president in 2009. The African-American community, originally uprooted by the slave trade, has a strong consciousness. Less well organized socially but more numerous, and faster-growing, the Hispanic community is predicted to number over 25% of the population by 2050. Native Americans, dispossessed in the 19th century, are now among the poorest people. Constitutionally, state and religion are clearly separated. Conservative Christianity, however, is increasingly dominant politically. Living standards are high, but bad diet and insufficient exercise have left over a third of Americans obese.



THE ECONOMY

World's largest economy: well-established engineering and high-tech industries, huge resource base, global spread of US culture. Manufacturing is in decline as jobs are lost to low-wage economies. The combination of tax cuts, to boost consumer spending after the 2001 slowdown, and the rising defense budget for the "war on terror" drove the budget into a record deficit. Oil production was hit badly in 2005 by Hurricane Katrina, causing global price hikes. The "subprime" mortgage lending crisis of 2007 sent global stock markets plummeting. In 2008, Lehman Brothers bank crashed spectacularly, while other giants in the financial sector received huge bailouts. Further tax cuts and billion-dollar spending packages in 2009 attempted to lift the economy back out of recession, but the gaping budget deficit also needs to be brought under control.

FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: United States of America

DATE OF FORMATION: 1776

CAPITAL: Washington, D.C.

POPULATION: 315 million

TOTAL AREA: 3,717,792 sq. miles
(9,626,091 sq. km)

DENSITY: 89 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English, Spanish, other

RELIGIONS: Protestant 52%, Catholic 25%, other 19%, Muslim 2%, Jewish 2%

ETHNIC MIX: White 62%, Hispanic 13%, African American 13%, other 7%, Asian 4%, Native American 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: US dollar = 100 cents



Uruguay



Situated in southeastern South America, Uruguay returned to civilian government in 1985, after 12 years of military rule. Most land is used for farming; Uruguay is a major wool exporter.



GEOGRAPHY

Low, rolling grasslands cover 80% of the country. Narrow coastal plain. Alluvial floodplain in southwest. Five rivers flow westward and drain into the Uruguay River.



CLIMATE

Temperate throughout the country. Warm summers, mild winters, and moderate rainfall.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Uruguayans are largely second- or third-generation Italians or Spaniards. Wealth derived from cattle ranching enabled the country to establish the first welfare state in South America. Despite economic decline since the 1950s, a large, if less prosperous, middle class remains. Though a Roman Catholic country, Uruguay is liberal in its attitude to religion and all forms are tolerated.



THE ECONOMY

Exports wool, meat, hides, rice, wood, soy. Rebounded from 1999–2002 economic crisis. Mineral potential.



INSIGHT: *Uruguay's rich pastures are ideal for raising livestock; animal products bring in over 40% of export earnings*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Eastern Republic of Uruguay

DATE OF FORMATION: 1828

CAPITAL: Montevideo

POPULATION: 3.36 million

TOTAL AREA: 68,039 sq. miles (176,220 sq. km)

DENSITY: 50 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 66%, other 30%, Jewish 2%, Protestant 2%

ETHNIC MIX: White 90%, Mestizo 6%, Black 4%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Urug. peso = 100 centésimos

Uzbekistan



Sharing what is left of the Aral Sea with its neighbor, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan lies on the ancient Silk Road between Asia and Europe. It is the most populous central Asian republic.



GEOGRAPHY

Arid and semiarid plains in much of the west. Fertile, irrigated farmland in the east lies below the peaks of the western Pamirs.



CLIMATE

Harsh continental climate. Summers can be extremely hot and dry; winters are cold.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Complex ethnic makeup. Ex-Communists are in firm control, but traditional social patterns based on clan, religion, and region have reemerged. Constitutional measures aim to control the influence of Islam: activities against Islamists have drawn international condemnation. Most people live in the fertile east. Birth rates are high, and the status of women continues to be low.



THE ECONOMY

Highly regulated. Reserves of natural gas, oil, coal, gold (has one of the world's largest gold mines), and other minerals. Cash crop is cotton: requires much irrigation. Grain imports necessary.



INSIGHT: *The Aral Sea has shrunk to just a tenth of its former size, due to diversion of rivers for irrigation*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Uzbekistan

DATE OF FORMATION: 1991

CAPITAL: Tashkent

POPULATION: 27.5 million

TOTAL AREA: 172,741 sq. miles
(447,400 sq. km)

DENSITY: 159 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Uzbek*, Russian, Tajik, Kazakh

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 88%, Orthodox Christian 9%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Uzbek 80%, other 6%, Russian 6%, Tajik 5%, Kazakh 3%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Som = 100 tiyin



Vanuatu

An archipelago of 82 islands and islets in the South Pacific, Vanuatu was ruled jointly by the UK and France from 1906 until independence in 1980. Politics is democratic but volatile.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountainous and volcanic, with coral beaches and dense rainforest. Cultivated land along the coasts.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Temperatures and rainfall decline from north to south.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Indigenous Melanesians form a majority. Ni-Vanuatu culture is traditional; local social and religious customs are strong, despite centuries of missionary influence. Subsistence farming and fishing are the main activities. 80% of the population lives on the 12 main islands. Women have lower social status than men and payment of bride-price is common.

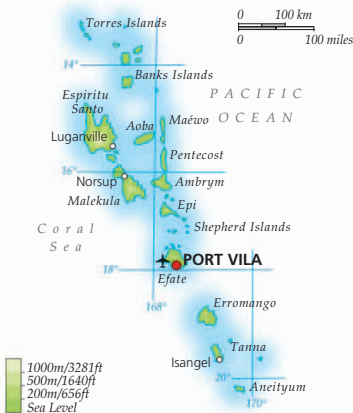


INSIGHT: With 105 indigenous tongues, Vanuatu has the world's highest per capita density of languages



THE ECONOMY

Reliant on aid. Main export is copra; diversifying into beef, timber, kava. Tourism. Offshore banking: rules tightened after international pressure.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Vanuatu

DATE OF FORMATION: 1980

CAPITAL: Port Vila

POPULATION: 239,800

TOTAL AREA: 4710 sq. miles
(12,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 51 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bislama*, English*, French*

RELIGIONS: Presbyterian 37%, other 25%, Anglican 15%, Roman Catholic 15%, traditional beliefs 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Melanesian 98%, European 1%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Vatu = 100 centimes

Vatican City



The Vatican City, or Holy See, the seat of the Roman Catholic Church, is a walled enclave in the Italian city of Rome. It is the world's smallest fully independent state.



GEOGRAPHY

The Vatican's territory includes 10 other buildings in Rome, plus the papal residence. The Vatican Gardens cover half the City's area.



CLIMATE

Mild winters with regular rainfall. Hot, dry summers with occasional thunderstorms.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Vatican has about 800 permanent inhabitants, including over 100 lay persons. Thousands of lay staff are also employed. Citizenship can be acquired through long-term residence and holding a position within the City. The reigning pope has supreme legislative and judicial powers, and holds office for life. Though the Vatican City is officially neutral, papal opinion has a great influence on the world's 1.1 billion Roman Catholics.



THE ECONOMY

Investments and voluntary contributions made by Catholics worldwide (known as Peter's Pence) are backed up by tourist revenue and the issue of Vatican stamps and coins.



INSIGHT: *The Vatican City is the spiritual center for one in six of the world's population*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: State of the Vatican City

DATE OF FORMATION: 1929

CAPITAL: Vatican City

POPULATION: 800

TOTAL AREA: 0.17 sq. miles
(0.44 sq. km)

DENSITY: 4706 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Italian*, Latin*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 100%

ETHNIC MIX: Cardinals are from many nationalities, but Italians form the largest group. The current pope is from Germany.

GOVERNMENT: Papal state

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents



Venezuela



Lying on the southern shores of the Caribbean, Venezuela was the first of Spain's colonies to seek independence. Despite large oil reserves, many Venezuelans still live in poverty.



GEOGRAPHY

Andes Mountains and the Maracaibo lowlands in the northwest. Central grassy plains are drained by the Orinoco River system. Forested Guiana Highlands in the southeast.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Hot and humid. Uplands are cooler. Orinoco plains are alternately parched or flooded.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Venezuela is historically a "melting pot," with immigrants from Europe and all over Latin America. The few indigenous Amerindians live in remote areas. Venezuela has one of the most urbanized societies in the region, with most of its population living in the northern cities. President Chávez's left-wing rhetoric raises opposition within Venezuela from urban society, and from the US.



THE ECONOMY

Oil accounts for 95% of exports. Reserves of coal, gold, other minerals. Nationalization program is enlarging the inefficient, corruption-prone state sector and deterring foreign investors.



INSIGHT: Venezuela's Angel Falls is the world's tallest waterfall, with a total drop of 3210 ft (979 m)



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela

DATE OF FORMATION: 1830

CAPITAL: Caracas

POPULATION: 28.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 352,143 sq. miles
(912,050 sq. km)

DENSITY: 84 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, native languages

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 89%,
Protestant and other 11%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestizo 69%, White 20%,
Black 9%, Amerindian 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Bolívar fuerte = 100 céntimos

Vietnam



French rule of Vietnam ended in 1954. Divided at 17°N, the US-backed South fought the Communist North. Reunified after the North's 1975 victory, it is run as a single-party state.



GEOGRAPHY

A heavily forested mountain range separates the northern Red River delta lowlands from the Mekong Delta in the south.



CLIMATE

Cool winters in north; south is tropical, with even temperatures.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Ethnic Vietnamese dominate; the Chinese minority was viewed as a corrupt bourgeoisie by the victorious Communists after the war. Mountain-based minorities (*montagnards*) were also sidelined; tensions persist over the settling of highlands by lowlanders. Women play an active role in society. There is no political or press freedom.



INSIGHT: Intense US bombing and defoliant spraying in the 1962–1975 Vietnam War has scarred the landscape



THE ECONOMY

Liberal economic policy (*doi moi*) from 1986: now one of fastest-growing economies. Major rice exporter. Cheap labor. Strong manufacturing: textiles, electrical goods. Diverse resource base.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Socialist Republic of Vietnam

DATE OF FORMATION: 1976

CAPITAL: Hanoi

POPULATION: 88.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 127,243 sq. miles
(329,560 sq. km)

DENSITY: 701 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Vietnamese*, Chinese, other

RELIGIONS: Nonreligious 81%, Buddhist 9%, Christian 7%, other 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Vietnamese 86%, other 10%, Tay 2%, Thai 2%

GOVERNMENT: One-party state

CURRENCY: Đồng = 10 hao = 100 xu



Yemen

Located in southern Arabia, Yemen was formerly two countries: the People's Democratic Republic of Yemen (south and east) and the Yemen Arab Republic (northwest) were united in 1990.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountainous west with a fertile strip along the Red Sea. Arid desert and mountains elsewhere.



CLIMATE

Desert climate, modified by altitude, which affects temperatures by as much as 54°F (30°C).



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Almost entirely of Arab and Bedouin descent, most Yemenis are Sunni Muslims, of the Shafi sect. In rural and northern areas, tribalism and Islamic orthodoxy are strong and most women wear the veil. Tension continues between the south, led by cosmopolitan Aden, and the more conservative north, though political opposition is now primarily from Islamists. Foreigners are subject to sporadic attacks and kidnappings.



THE ECONOMY

Instability deters investment. Considerable oil and natural gas reserves. Agriculture is the largest employer: qat (mild narcotic), coffee, and cotton.



INSIGHT: Mokha, on the Red Sea, gave its name to the first coffee beans exported to Europe in the 1600s



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Yemen

DATE OF FORMATION: 1990

CAPITAL: Sana

POPULATION: 23.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 203,849 sq. miles
(527,970 sq. km)

DENSITY: 108 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 55%,
Shi'a Muslim 42%, Christian, Hindu,
and Jewish 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 99%, Afro-Arab, Indian,
Somali, and European 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Yemeni rial = 100 fils

Zambia



Bordered to the south by the Zambezi River, Zambia lies at the heart of southern Africa. In 1991, it made a peaceful transition from single-party rule to multiparty democracy.



GEOGRAPHY

A high savanna plateau, broken by mountains in northeast. Vegetation mainly trees and scrub.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with three seasons: cool and dry, hot and dry, and wet. Southwest is prone to drought.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

There are more than 70 different ethnic groups, but there are fewer tensions than in many African states. Major groups are the Bemba (in the northeast), Tonga (south), Nyanja (east), and Lozi (west). There are also thousands of refugees, mostly from the DRC and Angola. A National Gender Policy was issued in 2000 to redress inequalities between the sexes. The standard of living has fallen in real terms since independence. One in seven adults is infected with HIV/AIDS.



THE ECONOMY

Copper: output has risen since 2000, when decades of falling global prices ended. New agricultural exports, notably flowers. Debt relief.



INSIGHT: *Spray from Musi-o-Tunya (Victoria Falls) can be seen up to 20 miles (35 km) away*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Zambia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1964

CAPITAL: Lusaka

POPULATION: 12.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 290,584 sq. miles
(752,614 sq. km)

DENSITY: 45 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bemba, Tonga, Nyanja, Lozi, Lala-bisa, Nsenga, English*

RELIGIONS: Christian 63%, traditional beliefs 36%, Muslim and Hindu 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Bemba 34%, other 27%, Tonga 16%, Nyanja 14%, Lozi 9%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Zamb. kwacha = 100 ngwee



Zimbabwe

Situated in southern Africa, Zimbabwe achieved independence from the UK in 1980. President Robert Mugabe, in power since then, has become increasingly authoritarian.



GEOGRAPHY

High plateaus in center bordered by Zambezi River in the north and Limpopo in the south. Rivers crisscross central area.



CLIMATE

Tropical, though moderated by the high altitude. Wet season November–March. Drought is common in the eastern highlands.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Two main ethnic groups: Shona in the north and east, and Ndebele in the south. Shona outnumber Ndebele by four to one. Whites are generally far more affluent than Blacks. Official efforts to redress this imbalance (such as land redistribution) have become increasingly aggressive. The political opposition to Mugabe joined him in a fractious unity government from 2009 in an attempt to rebuild the country.

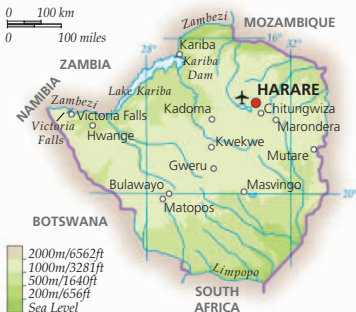


THE ECONOMY

Undermined by mismanagement, corruption, and international isolation. High unemployment. Hyperinflation. Stabilization could cost US\$45 billion.



INSIGHT: *The ruins of the 1000-year-old city of Great Zimbabwe, after which the country is named, are near modern-day Masvingo*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Zimbabwe

DATE OF FORMATION: 1980

CAPITAL: Harare

POPULATION: 12.5 million

TOTAL AREA: 150,803 sq. miles (390,580 sq. km)

DENSITY: 84 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Shona, isiNdebele, English*

RELIGIONS: Syncretic 50%, Christian 25%, traditional beliefs 24%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Shona 71%, Ndebele 16%, other African 11%, White 1%, Asian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Zimbabwe dollar suspended in 2009; US dollar and South African rand legal tender

Overseas territories

Despite the rapid process of global decolonization since World War II, around eight million people in more than 50 territories around the world continue to live under the protection of France, Australia, Denmark, the Netherlands, Norway, New Zealand, the UK, or the USA. These remnants of former colonial empires may have persisted for economic, strategic, or political reasons and are administered by the protecting country in a variety of ways.

AUSTRALIA

Australia's overseas territories have not been an issue since Papua New Guinea became independent in 1975. Consequently there is no overriding policy toward them. Norfolk Island is inhabited by descendants of the HMS *Bounty* mutineers and more recent Australian migrants. Phosphate is mined on Christmas Island.

Ashmore & Cartier Is. *Ref: 124 A3*



STATUS: External territory
CLAIMED: 1931

CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 2 sq miles (5.2 sq km)

Christmas Island *Ref: 123 E5*

STATUS: External territory
CLAIMED: 1958
CAPITAL: The Settlement
POPULATION: 1400
AREA: 52 sq miles (135 sq km)

Cocos Islands *Ref: 123 D5*

STATUS: External territory
CLAIMED: 1955
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: 574
AREA: 5.5 sq miles (14 sq km)

Coral Sea Islands *Ref: 126 B4*

STATUS: External territory
CLAIMED: 1969
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: 8 (Meteorologists)
AREA: 1.2 sq miles (3 sq km)

Heard & McDonald Is. *Ref: 123 C7*

STATUS: External territory
CLAIMED: 1947
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 161 sq miles (417 sq km)

Norfolk Island *Ref: 124 D4*



STATUS: External territory
CLAIMED: 1774
CAPITAL: Kingston

POPULATION: 2100
AREA: 13 sq miles (34 sq km)

DENMARK

The Faeroe Islands have been under Danish administration since Queen Margreth I of Denmark inherited Norway in 1380. The Home Rule Act of 1948 gave the Faeroese control over all their internal affairs. Greenland first came under Danish rule in 1380. Denmark remains responsible for the island's foreign affairs.

Overseas territories

Faeroe Islands *Ref: 65 F5*



STATUS: External territory

CLAIMED: 1380

CAPITAL: Tórshavn

POPULATION: 49,000

AREA: 540 sq miles (1399 sq km)

Greenland *Ref: 64 D3*



STATUS: External territory

CLAIMED: 1380

CAPITAL: Nuuk

POPULATION: 57,500

AREA: 836,109 sq miles (2,166,086 sq km)

FRANCE

France has developed economic ties with its *Territoires d'Outre-Mer*, thereby stressing interdependence over independence. Overseas *départements*, officially part of France, have their own governments. Territorial *collectivités* and overseas *territoires* have varying degrees of autonomy.

Clipperton Island *Ref: 135 F3*

STATUS: Dependency of French Polynesia

CLAIMED: 1935

CAPITAL: Not applicable

POPULATION: None

AREA: 3.4 sq miles (9 sq km)

French Guiana *Ref: 41 H3*

STATUS: Overseas department

CLAIMED: 1817

CAPITAL: Cayenne

POPULATION: 221,500

AREA: 35,135 sq miles (91,000 sq km)

French Polynesia *Ref: 127 H4*

STATUS: Overseas country

CLAIMED: 1843

CAPITAL: Papeete

POPULATION: 264,000

AREA: 1608 sq miles (4165 sq km)

Guadeloupe *Ref: 37 G4*

STATUS: Overseas department

CLAIMED: 1635

CAPITAL: Basse-Terre

POPULATION: 441,000

AREA: 687 sq miles (1780 sq km)

Martinique *Ref: 37 G4*

STATUS: Overseas department

CLAIMED: 1635

CAPITAL: Fort-de-France

POPULATION: 402,000

AREA: 425 sq miles (1100 sq km)

Mayotte *Ref: 61 G2*

STATUS: Territorial collectivity

CLAIMED: 1843

CAPITAL: Mamoudzou

POPULATION: 194,000

AREA: 144 sq miles (374 sq km)

New Caledonia *Ref: 126 D5*

STATUS: Overseas territory

CLAIMED: 1853

CAPITAL: Nouméa

POPULATION: 249,000

AREA: 7347 sq miles (19,100 sq km)

Réunion *Ref: 61 H4*

STATUS: Overseas department

CLAIMED: 1638

CAPITAL: Saint-Denis

POPULATION: 827,000

AREA: 970 sq miles (2500 sq km)

Overseas territories

St Pierre & Miquelon *Ref: 21 G4*

STATUS: Territorial collectivity

CLAIMED: 1604

CAPITAL: Saint-Pierre

POPULATION: 6125

AREA: 93 sq miles (242 sq km)

Wallis & Futuna *Ref: 127 E4*

STATUS: Overseas territory

CLAIMED: 1842

CAPITAL: Mata'Utu

POPULATION: 13,484

AREA: 106 sq miles (274 sq km)

NETHERLANDS

The country's two remaining territories were formerly part of the Dutch West Indies. Both are now self-governing, but the Netherlands remains responsible for their defense.

Aruba *Ref: 37 E5*



STATUS: Autonomous part of the Netherlands

CLAIMED: 1634

CAPITAL: Oranjestad

POPULATION: 103,000

AREA: 75 sq miles (194 sq km)

Netherlands Antilles *Ref: 37 E5*



STATUS: Autonomous part of the Netherlands

CLAIMED: 1816

CAPITAL: Willemstad

POPULATION: 184,000

AREA: 371 sq miles (960 sq km)

NEW ZEALAND

New Zealand's government has no desire to retain any overseas territories. However, the economic weakness of Tokelau, Niue, and the Cook Islands has forced it to remain responsible for their foreign policy and defense.

Cook Islands *Ref: 127 G4*



STATUS: Associated territory

CLAIMED: 1901

CAPITAL: Avarua

POPULATION: 19,500

AREA: 91 sq miles (235 sq km)



Niue *Ref: 127 F5*

STATUS: Associated territory

CLAIMED: 1901

CAPITAL: Alofi

POPULATION: 1400

AREA: 102 sq miles (264 sq km)

Tokelau *Ref: 127 F3*

STATUS: Dependent territory

CLAIMED: 1926

CAPITAL: Not applicable

POPULATION: 1400

AREA: 4 sq miles (10 sq km)

NORWAY

In 1920, 41 nations signed the Spitsbergen treaty recognizing Norwegian sovereignty over Svalbard. There is a NATO base on Jan Mayen. Bouvet Island is a nature reserve.

Overseas territories

Bouvet Island *Ref: 49 D7*

STATUS: Dependency
CLAIMED: 1928
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 22 sq miles (58 sq km)

Jan Mayen *Ref: 65 F3*

STATUS: Dependency
CLAIMED: 1929
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: 18 (Meteorologists)
AREA: 147 sq miles (381 sq km)

Peter I. Island *Ref: 136 A3*

STATUS: Dependency
CLAIMED: 1931
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 69 sq miles (180 sq km)

Svalbard *Ref: 65 F2*

STATUS: Dependency
CLAIMED: 1920
CAPITAL: Longyearbyen
POPULATION: 2100
AREA: 24,289 sq miles (62,906 sq km)

UNITED KINGDOM

The UK has the largest number of overseas territories. These are locally governed by a mixture of elected representatives and appointed officials.

Anguilla *Ref: 37 G3*



STATUS: Dependent territory
CLAIMED: 1650
CAPITAL: The Valley
POPULATION: 13,477
AREA: 37 sq miles (96 sq km)

Ascension Island *Ref: 49 C5*

STATUS: Dependency of St Helena
CLAIMED: 1673
CAPITAL: Georgetown
POPULATION: 940
AREA: 34 sq miles (88 sq km)

Bermuda *Ref: 17 E6*



STATUS: Crown colony
CLAIMED: 1612
CAPITAL: Hamilton
POPULATION: 67,800
AREA: 20 sq miles (53 sq km)

British Indian Ocean Territory

Ref: 122 C4



STATUS: Dependent territory
CLAIMED: 1814
CAPITAL: Diego Garcia
POPULATION: 4000
AREA: 23 sq miles (60 sq km)

British Virgin Is. *Ref: 37 F3*



STATUS: Dependent territory
CLAIMED: 1672
CAPITAL: Road Town
POPULATION: 22,000
AREA: 59 sq miles (153 sq km)

Cayman Islands *Ref: 36 B3*



STATUS: Dependent territory
CLAIMED: 1670
CAPITAL: George Town
POPULATION: 52,000
AREA: 100 sq miles (259 sq km)

Falkland Islands *Ref: 47 D7*



STATUS: Dependent territory
CLAIMED: 1832
CAPITAL: Stanley
POPULATION: 3100
AREA: 4699 sq miles (12,173 sq km)

Overseas territories

Gibraltar *Ref: 74 D5*



STATUS: Crown colony

CLAIMED: 1713

CAPITAL: Gibraltar

POPULATION: 28,800

AREA: 2.5 sq miles (6.5 sq km)

Guernsey *Ref: 71 D8*



STATUS: Crown dependency

CLAIMED: 1066

CAPITAL: St. Peter Port

POPULATION: 65,500

AREA: 25 sq miles (65 sq km)

Isle of Man *Ref: 71 C5*



STATUS: Crown dependency

CLAIMED: 1765

CAPITAL: Douglas

POPULATION: 76,500

AREA: 221 sq miles (572 sq km)

Jersey *Ref: 71 D8*



STATUS: Crown dependency

CLAIMED: 1066

CAPITAL: St. Helier

POPULATION: 91,600

AREA: 45 sq miles (116 sq km)

Montserrat *Ref: 37 G4*



STATUS: Dependent territory

CLAIMED: 1632

CAPITAL: Plymouth (uninhabitable)

POPULATION: 4500

AREA: 40 sq miles (102 sq km)

Pitcairn Islands *Ref: 125 G4*



STATUS: Dependent territory

CLAIMED: 1887

CAPITAL: Adamstown

POPULATION: 45

AREA: 18 sq miles (47 sq km)

Saint Helena *Ref: 49 D5*



STATUS: Dependent territory

CLAIMED: 1673

CAPITAL: Jamestown

POPULATION: 4299

AREA: 47 sq miles (122 sq km)

South Georgia & The Sandwich Islands *Ref: 49 C7*

STATUS: Dependent territory

CLAIMED: 1775

CAPITAL: Not applicable

POPULATION: None

AREA: 1387 sq miles (3592 sq km)

Tristan da Cunha *Ref: 49 D6*

STATUS: Dependency of St. Helena

CLAIMED: 1612

CAPITAL: Edinburgh

POPULATION: 270

AREA: 38 sq miles (98 sq km)

Turks & Caicos Islands *Ref: 37 E2*



STATUS: Dependent territory

CLAIMED: 1766

CAPITAL: Cockburn Town

POPULATION: 36,600

AREA: 166 sq miles (430 sq km)

UNITED STATES

US Commonwealth territories are self-governing incorporated territories that are an integral part of the US. Unincorporated territories have varying degrees of autonomy.

American Samoa *Ref: 127 F4*



STATUS: Unincorporated territory

CLAIMED: 1900

CAPITAL: Pago Pago

POPULATION: 65,600

AREA: 75 sq miles (195 sq km)

Overseas territories

Baker & Howland Islands *Ref: 127 E2*

STATUS: Unincorporated territory
CAPITAL: Not applicable
CLAIMED: 1856
POPULATION: None
AREA: 0.5 sq miles (1.4 sq km)

Guam *Ref: 126 B1*



STATUS: Unincorporated territory
CLAIMED: 1898

CAPITAL: Hagåtña
POPULATION: 178,000
AREA: 212 sq miles (549 sq km)

Jarvis Island *Ref: 127 G2*

STATUS: Unincorporated territory
CLAIMED: 1856
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 1.7 sq miles (4.5 sq km)

Johnston Atoll *Ref: 125 E1*

STATUS: Unincorporated territory
CLAIMED: 1858
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 1 sq mile (2.8 sq km)

Kingman Reef *Ref: 127 F2*

STATUS: Administered territory
CLAIMED: 1856
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 0.4 sq miles (1 sq km)

Midway Islands *Ref: 134 D2*

STATUS: Administered territory
CLAIMED: 1867
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 2 sq miles (5.2 sq km)

Navassa Island *Ref: 36 D3*

STATUS: Unincorporated territory
CLAIMED: 1856
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 2 sq miles (5.2 sq km)

Northern Mariana Islands *Ref: 124 C1*



STATUS: Commonwealth territory
CLAIMED: 1947

CAPITAL: Saipan
POPULATION: 86,600
AREA: 177 sq miles (457 sq km)

Palmyra Atoll *Ref: 127 G2*

STATUS: Unincorporated territory
CLAIMED: 1898
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: None
AREA: 5 sq miles (12 sq km)

Puerto Rico *Ref: 37 F3*



STATUS: Commonwealth territory
CLAIMED: 1898

CAPITAL: San Juan
POPULATION: 4 million
AREA: 3515 sq miles (9104 sq km)

Virgin Islands *Ref: 37 F3*



STATUS: Unincorporated territory
CLAIMED: 1917

CAPITAL: Charlotte Amalie
POPULATION: 108,500
AREA: 137 sq miles (355 sq km)

Wake Island *Ref: 124 D1*

STATUS: Unincorporated territory
CLAIMED: 1898
CAPITAL: Not applicable
POPULATION: 200
AREA: 2.5 sq miles (6.5 sq km)

International organizations

This listing provides acronym definitions for the main international organizations concerned with worldwide economics, trade, and defense, plus an indication of membership.

ASEAN

Association of Southeast Asian Nations

ESTABLISHED: 1967

MEMBERS: Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, Vietnam

CIS

Commonwealth of Independent States

ESTABLISHED: 1991

MEMBERS: Arm., Az., Belarus, Kaz., Kyrgy., Mold., Russia, Tajik., Turkmen.*, Ukraine*, Uzbek. *Unofficial members

COMM *The Commonwealth of Nations*

ESTABLISHED: 1931; evolved out of the British Empire. Formerly known as the British Commonwealth of Nations.

MEMBERS: 53

EU *European Union*

ESTABLISHED: 1965; formerly known as EEC (European Economic Community) and EC (Economic Community)

MEMBERS: Austria, Belg., Bulg., Cyprus, Czech Rep., Denmark, Est., Fin., Fr., Ger., Greece, Hung., Ireland, Italy, Lat., Lith., Lux., Malta, Neth., Pol., Port., Rom., Slvka., Slvna., Spain, Swed., UK

G8 *Group of 8*

ESTABLISHED: 1994

MEMBERS: Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, Russia, UK, US

IMF *International Monetary Fund* (UN agency)

ESTABLISHED: 1945

MEMBERS: 186

NAFTA

North American Free Trade Agreement

ESTABLISHED: 1994

MEMBERS: Canada, Mexico, US

NATO

North Atlantic Treaty Organization

ESTABLISHED: 1949

MEMBERS: Albania, Belg., Bulg., Canada, Croatia, Czech Rep., Denmark, Est., France, Ger., Greece, Hung., Iceland, Italy, Lat., Lith., Lux., Neth., Norway, Poland, Port., Rom., Slovakia, Slovenia, Spain, Turkey, UK, US

OPEC *Organization of Petroleum* *Exporting Countries*

ESTABLISHED: 1960

MEMBERS: Algeria, Angola, Ecuador, Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, Libya, Nigeria, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, United Arab Emirates, Venezuela

UN *United Nations*

ESTABLISHED: 1945

MEMBERS: 192; all nations are represented, except Taiwan. The Vatican City has "observer status" only.

WTO *World Trade Organization*

ESTABLISHED: 1995

MEMBERS: 153

Abbreviations

This glossary provides a comprehensive guide to the abbreviations used in this atlas.

abbrev. abbreviation

Afgh. Afghanistan

Amh. Amharic

anc. ancient

Ar. Arabic

Arm. Armenia/Armenian

Aus. Austria

Aust. Australia

Az. Azerbaijan

Bas. Basque

Bel. Belorussian

Belg. Belgium/Belgian

Bos. & Herz. Bosnia & Herzegovina

Bul. Bulgarian

Bulg. Bulgaria

Bur. Burmese

C Central

C. Cape

Cam. Cambodian

Cast. Castilian

Chin. Chinese

Cord. Cordillera (Sp. mts.)

Cz. Czech

Czech Rep. Czech Republic

D.C. District of Columbia

Dan. Danish

Dominican Rep. Dominican Republic

E East

Emb. Embalse

Eng. English

Eq. Guinea Equatorial Guinea

Est. Estonia/Estonian

Faer. Faeroese

Fin. Finland/Finnish

Flem. Flemish

Fr. France/French

Geo. Georgia

Geor. Georgian

Ger. Germany/German

Gk. Greek

Heb. Hebrew

Hung. Hungary/Hungarian

I. Island

Ind. Indonesia, Indonesian

Is. Islands

It. Italian

Kaz. Kazakhstan/Kazakh

Kep. Kepulauan (Ind. island group)

Kir. Kirghiz

Kor. Korean

Kos. Kosovo

Kurd. Kurdish

Kyrgy. Kyrgyzstan

L. Lake, Lago

Lat. Latvia

Latv. Latvian

Leb. Lebanon

Liech. Liechtenstein

Lith. Lithuania/Lithuanian

Lux. Luxembourg

Mac. Macedonia

Med. Sea Mediterranean Sea

Mon. Montenegro

Mold. Moldova

Mt. Mount/Mountain

Mts. Mountains

N North

N. Korea North Korea

Neth. Netherlands

NW Northwest

NZ New Zealand

P. Pulau (Ind. island)

Peg. Pegunungan (Ind. mountain range)

Per. Persian

Pol. Poland/Polish

Port. Portugal, Portuguese

prev. previously

R. River, Río, Rio

Res. Reservoir

Rom. Romania/Romanian

Rus. Russian

Russ. Fed. Russian Federation

S South

S. Korea South Korea

SA South Africa

SCr. Serbian and Croatian

Serb. Serbia

Slvka. Slovakia

Slvna. Slovenia

Som. Somali

Sp. Spanish

St, St. Saint

Str. Strait

Swed. Swedish

Switz. Switzerland

Tajik. Tajikistan

Th. Thai

Turk. Turkish

Turkm. Turkmen

Turkmen. Turkmenistan

U.A.E. United Arab Emirates

UK United Kingdom

Ukr. Ukrainian

Urug. Uruguayan

US United States of America

Uzb. Uzbek

Uzbek. Uzbekistan

var. variant

Vdkhr. Vodokhranilishche
(Rus. reservoir)

Vdskh. Vodokhovyshe
(Ukr. reservoir)

Ven. Venezuela

W West

W. Sahara Western Sahara

Wel. Welsh

Yugo. Yugoslavia

Zamb. Zambian

A

- Aabenraa** Denmark 67 A8
Aachen Germany 76 A4
Aalborg Denmark 67 B7
Aalst Belgium 69 B5
Aba Nigeria 57 G5
Ābādān Iran 102 C4
Abadan Turkmenistan *prev.*
 Bezmeın, Büzmeýin
 104 B3
Abashiri Japan 112 D2
Abéché Chad 58 D3
Aberdeen Scotland, UK 70 D3
Aberdeen South Dakota, USA
 25 E2
Aberdeen Washington, USA
 26 A2
Aberystwyth Wales, UK 71 C6
Abhā Saudi Arabia 103 B6
Abidjan Côte d'Ivoire 56 D5
Abilene Texas, USA 29 F3
Abomey Benin 57 F4
Abu Dhabi *capital of* United
 Arab Emirates *var.* Abū Ḥabı
 103 D5
Abuja *capital of* Nigeria
 57 G4
Abū Ḥabı *see* Abu Dhabi
Acapulco Mexico 33 E5
Acarai Mountains *mountain*
range Brazil/Guyana 41 F3
Acarigua Venezuela 40 D1
Accra *capital of* Ghana 57 E5
Acklins Island *island* Bahamas
 36 D2
Aconcagua, Cerro peak
 Argentina 46 B4
A Coruña Spain *Cast. La*
Coruña 74 C1
ACT *see* Australian Capital
 Territory
Adalia *see* Antalya
Adalia, Gulf of *see* Antalya
 Körfezi
***Adan** Yemen *Eng.* Aden
 103 B7
Adana Turkey *var.* Seyhan
 98 D4
Adapazarı Turkey *var.* Sakarya
 98 B2
Ad Dahnā' *desert* Saudi Arabia
 103 C5
Ad Dakhla Western Sahara
 52 A4
Ad Dawḥah *see* Doha
Addis Ababa *capital of* Ethiopia
Amh. Ādis Ābeba 55 C5
Adelaide Australia 131 B6
Adélie, Terre d' territory
 Antarctica 136 C4
Aden *see* *Adan
Aden, Gulf of sea feature
 Indian Ocean 122 A3
Adige river Italy 78 C2
Ādis Ābeba *see* Addis Ababa
Adiyaman Turkey 99 E4
Adriatic Sea Mediterranean
 Sea 78 D4
Aegean Sea Mediterranean
 Sea *Gk.* Aigaío Pélagos, *Turk.*
Ege Denizi 87 D5
Aeolian Islands *see* Isole Eolie
Afghanistan *country C* Asia
 104-105
Africa 50-51
Africa, Horn of physical region
 Ethiopia/Somalia 122 A3
Afyon Turkey *prev.*
 Afyonkarahisar 98 B3
Afyonkarahisar *see* Afyon
Agadez Niger 57 G3
Agadir Morocco 52 B2
Agassiz Fracture Zone *tectonic*
feature Pacific Ocean
 135 E4
Agen France 73 B6
Āgra India 116 D3
Agrigento Italy 79 C7
Agrinio Greece 87 B5
Aguarico river Ecuador/Peru
 40 B4
Agua Calientes Mexico 32 D4
Ahaggar mountains Algeria
var. Hoggar 53 E4
Ahmadābād India 116 C4
Ahvāz Iran 102 C4
Ahvenanmaa *see* Åland
Aigaio Pélagos *see* Aegean Sea
Aintab *see* Gaziantep
Air, Massif de l' region Niger
 57 G2
Aix-en-Provence France
 73 D6
Ajaccio Corse, France 73 E7
Ajdābiyā Libya 53 G2
Ajmer India 116 D3
Akaba *see* Al 'Aqabah
Akchār *desert* Mauritania
 56 C2
Akimiski Island *island* Canada
 20 C3
Akita Japan 112 D3
Akjoujt Mauritania 56 C2
Akmola *see* Astana
Akmołinsk *see* Astana
Akpatok Island *island* Canada
 21 E1
Akra Kanestron *see* Paliouri,
 Akrotirio
Akron Ohio, USA 22 D3
Aksai Chin *disputed region*
 China/India 108 B4
Aktau Kazakhstan *prev.*
 Shevchenko 96 A4
Akureyri Iceland 65 E4
Akyab *see* Sittwe
Alabama state USA 30 D3
Alacant *see* Alicante
Alajuela Costa Rica 34 D4
Alamogordo New Mexico, USA
 28 D3
Åland island group Finland *Fin.*
 Ahvenanmaa 67 D6
Al 'Aqabah Jordan *var.* Akaba
 101 B7
Alaska state USA 18
Alaska, Gulf of sea feature
 Pacific Ocean 16 C3
Alaska Range *mountain range*
 Alaska, USA 18 C3
Albacete Spain 75 E3
Alba Iulia Romania 90 B4
Albania *country* SE Europe 83
Albany Australia 129 B7
Albany Georgia, USA 31 E3
Albany New York, USA
 23 F3
Albany Oregon, USA 26 A3
Albany river Canada 20 B3

- Al Başrah** Iraq var. Basra 102 C4
- Al Bayḍā'** Libya 53 G2
- Albert, Lake** lake Uganda/Dem. Rep. Congo 59 E5
- Alberta province** Canada 19 E4
- Albi** France 73 C6
- Albuquerque** New Mexico, USA 28 D2
- Alcácer do Sal** Portugal 74 C4
- Aldabra Group** island group Seychelles 61 G2
- Aleg** Mauritania 56 C3
- Aleksandriya** see Oleksandriya
- Aleksandropol'** see Gyumri
- Aleksinac** Serbia 82 E4
- Alençon** France 72 B3
- Alessandria** Italy 78 B2
- Ålesund** Norway 67 A5
- Aleutian Basin** undersea feature Bering Sea 134 D1
- Aleutian Islands** islands Alaska, USA 18 A3
- Aleutian Trench** undersea feature Pacific Ocean 134 D1
- Alexander Island** island Antarctica 136 A3
- Alexandra** New Zealand 133 B7
- Alexandretta** see İskenderun
- Alexandria** see Al Iskandariyah
- Alexandria** Louisiana, USA 30 B3
- Alexandroupoli** Greece 86 D3
- Al Fāshir** see El Fasher
- Álföld** see Great Hungarian Plain
- Algarve** region Portugal 74 C4
- Algeciras** Spain 74 D5
- Algeria** country N Africa 52-53
- Alghero** Italy 79 A5
- Algiers** capital of Algeria 52 D1
- Al Ḥasakah** Syria 100 D2
- Al Ḥudaydah** Yemen 103 B7
- Al Hufuf** Saudi Arabia 103 C5
- Alicante** Spain Cat. Alacant 75 F4
- Alice Springs** Australia 130 A4
- Al Iskandariyah** Egypt Eng. Alexandria 54 B1
- Al Ismā'īliya** Egypt Eng. Ismalia 54 B1
- Al Jawf** Saudi Arabia 102 B4
- Al Jazīrah** region Iraq/Syria 100 E2
- Al Jizah** Egypt var. El Giza 54 B1
- Al Karak** Jordan 101 B6
- Al Khalīl** see Hebron
- Al Khārijah** Egypt var. El Khārga 54 B2
- Al Khums** Libya 53 F2
- Al Khurṭūm** see Khartoum
- Alkmaar** Netherlands 68 C2
- Al Kufrah** Libya 53 H4
- Al Lādhīqīyah** Syria Eng. Latakia 100 B3
- Allahābād** India 117 E4
- Allenstein** see Olsztyn
- Allentown** Pennsylvania, USA 23 F4
- Alma-Ata** capital of Kazakhstan Rus./Kaz. Almaty 96 C5
- Al Madīnah** Saudi Arabia Eng. Medina 102 A5
- Al Mafrāq** Jordan 101 B5
- Almalyk** Uzbekistan Uzb. Olmaliq 105 E2
- Al Manāmah** see Manama
- Al Marj** Libya 53 G2
- Almaty** see Alma-Ata
- Al Mawṣil** Iraq Eng. Mosul 102 B3
- Almelo** Netherlands 68 E3
- Almeria** Spain 75 E5
- Al Minyā** Egypt 54 B2
- Al Mukallā** Yemen 103 C7
- Alofi** capital of Niue 127 F5
- Alor, Kepulauan** island group Indonesia 121 E5
- Alps** mountain range C Europe 62 D4
- Al Qāhirah** see Cairo
- Al Qāmishli** Syria var. Kamishli 100 E1
- Al Qunayṭirah** Syria 100 B4
- Altai Mountains** mountain range C Asia 108 C2
- Altamura** Italy 79 E5
- Altar, Desierto de** Desert Mexico/USA var. Sonoran Desert 32 A1
- Altay** China 108 C2
- Altay** Mongolia 108 D2
- Altun Shan** mountain range China 108 C3
- Alturas** California, USA 26 B4
- Al Uqsur** Egypt Eng. Luxor 54 B2
- Alytus** Lithuania Pol. Olita 89 B5
- Amadeus, Lake** seasonal lake Australia 129 E5
- Amakusa-nada** island group Japan 113 A6
- Amami-Ōshima** island Japan 113 A8
- Amarillo** Texas, USA 29 E2
- Amazon** river South America 38 C3
- Amazon Basin** region C South America 42 D2
- Ambanja** Madagascar 61 G2
- Ambarchik** Russian Federation 97 G2
- Ambato** Ecuador 40 A4
- Ambaobary** Madagascar 61 F4
- Ambon** Indonesia 121 F4
- Ambositra** Madagascar 61 G3
- Ambriz** Angola 60 B1
- Amdo** China 108 C4
- Ameland** island Netherlands 68 D1
- American Falls Reservoir** Reservoir Idaho, USA 26 E4
- American Samoa** external territory USA, Pacific Ocean 127 F4
- Amersfoort** Netherlands 68 D3
- Amga** river Russian Federation 95 F2
- Amiens** France 72 C3
- Amindivi Islands** island group India 114 C2
- Amirante Islands** island group Seychelles 61 H1
- Amman** capital of Jordan 101 B5
- Ammassalik** Greenland var. Angmagssalik 64 D4

Ammochostos — Arad

- Ammochostos** see Gazimağusa
- Āmol** Iran 102 C3
- Amorgós island** Greece 87 D6
- Amritsar** India 116 D2
- Amsterdam** *capital of* Netherlands 68 C3
- Amsterdam Island** *island* French Southern and Antarctic Territories 123 C6
- Am Timan** Chad 58 C3
- Amu Darya river** C Asia 104 D3
- Amundsen Gulf** *sea feature* Canada 19 E2
- Amundsen Plain** *undersea feature* Pacific Ocean 136 B4
- Amundsen Sea** Antarctica 97 G4
- Amur river** E Asia 97 G4 107 E1
- Anabar river** Russian Federation 95 E2
- Anadolu Dağları** see Doğu Karadeniz Dağları
- Anadyr'** Russian Federation 97 H1
- Anápolis** Brazil 43 F4
- Anatolia** *region* SE Europe 85 G3
- Anchorage** Alaska, USA 18 C3
- Ancona** Italy 78 C3
- Andalucía** *region* Spain 74 D4
- Andaman Islands** *island group* India 115 H2 119 A5
- Andaman Sea** Indian Ocean 122 D3
- Andes** *mountain range* South America 39 B6
- Andijon** Uzbekistan Rus. Andizhan 105 F2
- Andhra Pradesh** *state* India 115 E1
- Andizhan** see Andijon
- Andorra** *country* SW Europe 73 B6
- Andorra la Vella** *capital of* Andorra 73 B6
- Ándros** *island* Greece 87 D5
- Andros Island** *island* Bahamas 36 C1
- Angara river** C Asia 95 D3
- Ángel de la Guarda, Isla** *island* Mexico 32 B2
- Angel Falls** see Salto Ángel
- Angeles** Philippines 121 E1
- Ángel, Salto** *waterfall* Venezuela *Eng.* Angel Falls 41 F2
- Ängermanälven** *river* Sweden 66 C4
- Angers** France 72 B4
- Anglesey** *island* Wales, UK 71 C5
- Angmagssalik** see Ammassalik
- Angola** *country* C Africa 60
- Angola Basin** *undersea feature* Atlantic Ocean 49 D6
- Angora** see Ankara
- Angoulême** France 73 B5
- Angren** Uzbekistan 105 E2
- Anguilla** *external territory* UK, West Indies 37
- Anhui** *province* China *var.* Anhwei, Wan 111 C5
- Anhui** see Anhui
- Anjouan** *island* Comoros 61 F2
- Ankara** *capital of* Turkey *prev.* Angora 98 C3
- Annaba** Algeria 53 E1
- An Nafūd** *desert region* Saudi Arabia 102 B4
- An Najaf** Iraq *var.* Najaf 102 B4
- Annapolis** Maryland, USA 23 F4
- Ann Arbor** Michigan, USA 22 C3
- Annecy** France 73 D5
- Anshan** China 110 D4
- Ansongo** Mali 57 E3
- Antakya** Turkey *var.* Hatay 98 D4
- Antalaha** Madagascar 61 G2
- Antalya** Turkey *prev.* Adalia 98 B4
- Antalya, Gulf of** see Antalya Körfezi
- Antalya Körfezi** *sea feature* Mediterranean Sea *Eng.* Gulf of Antalya, *var.* Gulf of Adalia 98 B4
- Antananarivo** *capital of* Madagascar *prev.* Tananarive 61 G3
- Antarctica** 136
- Antarctic Peninsula** *peninsula* Antarctica 136 A2
- Antequera** Spain 74 D5
- Anticosti, Île d'** *island* Canada 21 F3
- Antigua** *island* Antigua & Barbuda 37 G3
- Antigua & Barbuda** *country* West Indies 37
- Anti-Lebanon** *mountains* Lebanon/Syria 100 B4
- Antipodes Islands** *island group* New Zealand 124 D5
- Antofagasta** Chile 46 B2
- Antsiranana** Madagascar 61 G2
- Antsohihy** Madagascar 61 G2
- Antwerp** see Antwerpen
- Antwerpen** Belgium *Eng.* Antwerp 69 C5
- Anyang** China 110 C4
- Aoga-shima** *island* Japan 113 D6
- Aomori** Japan 112 D3
- Aoraki** *peak* New Zealand *var.* Cook, Mount 133 B6
- Aosta** Italy 78 A2
- Aoukâr Plateau** Mauritania 56 D3
- Apeldoorn** Netherlands 68 D3
- Apennines** see Appennino
- Apia** *capital of* Samoa 127 F4
- Appalachian Mountains** *mountain range* E USA 17 D5
- Appennino** *mountain range* Italy *Eng.* Apennines 78 C4
- Apure** *river* Venezuela 40 D2
- Aqaba** see Al 'Aqabah
- Aqaba, Gulf of** *sea feature* Red Sea Ar. Khalij al 'Aqabah 101 A8
- 'Aqabah, Khalij al** see Aqaba, Gulf of
- Āqchah** Afghanistan *var.* Āqcheh 104 D3
- Āqcheh** see Āqchah
- Arabian Basin** *undersea feature* Indian Ocean 122 B3
- Arabian Peninsula** *peninsula* Asia 85 H5 94 B5 103 C5
- Arabian Sea** Indian Ocean 122 B3
- Aracaju** Brazil 43 H3
- Arad** Romania 90 B4

- Arafura Sea** Asia/Australasia 126 A4
- Araguaia river** Brazil 43 F3
- Arāk** Iran 102 C3
- Araks** see **Aras**
- Arak's** see **Aras**
- Aral Sea inland sea**
Kazakhstan/Uzbekistan 94 C3
- Araouane** Mali 57 E2
- Ararat, Mount peak** Turkey var.
Great Ararat, *Turk.*
Büyükağrı Dağı 94 F3
- Aras river** SW Asia *Arm.* Arak's,
Per. Rūd-e Aras, *Rus.* Araks,
Turk. Aras Nehri 99 G3
- Aras Nehri** see **Aras**
- Arauca** Colombia 40 C2
- Arauca river** Colombia/
Venezuela 40 C2
- Arbil** Iraq *Kurd.* Hawlēr 102 B3
- Arctic Ocean** 18-19 137
- Arda river** Bulgaria/Greece 86 C3
- Ardabil** Iran 102 C3
- Ardennes region** W Europe 69 D7
- Arendal** Norway 67 A6
- Arensburg** see **Kuressaare**
- Arequipa** Peru 42 B4
- Arezzo** Italy 78 C3
- Argentina country** S South America 46-47
- Argentine Basin undersea feature** Atlantic Ocean 49 B7
- Argun river** China/Russian Federation 95 E3
- Århus** Denmark 67 A7
- Arica** Chile 46 B1
- Arizona state** USA 28 B2
- Arkansas state** USA 30 B1
- Arkansas river** C USA 17 C5
- Arkhangel'sk** Russian Federation 92 C3 96 C2
- Arles** France 73 D6
- Arlington** Texas, USA 29 G3
- Arlington** Virginia, USA 23 E4
- Arlon** Belgium 69 D8
- Armenia country** SW Asia 99 G2
- Armenia** Colombia 40 B3
- Armida** Australia 131 D5
- Arnhem** Netherlands 68 D4
- Arnhem Land region** Australia 128 E2
- Arno river** Italy 78 B3
- Arran island** Scotland, UK 70 C4
- Ar Raqqaḥ** Syria 100 C2
- Arras** France 72 C3
- Ar Riyāḍ** see **Riyadh**
- Ar Rub 'al Khālī** desert Asia
Eng. Empty Quarter, Great Sandy Desert 103 C6
- Ar Rustāq** Oman var. **Rostak** 103 D5
- Artesia** New Mexico, USA 28 D3
- Artigas** Uruguay 44 B4
- Aru, Kepulauan island group** Indonesia 121 G5
- Arua** Uganda 55 B6
- Aruba external territory** Netherlands, West Indies 37 E5
- Arusha** Tanzania 55 C7
- Asad, Buḥayrat al Lake** Syria
Eng. Lake Assad 100 C2
- Asadābād** Afghanistan 105 E4
- Asahikawa** Japan 112 D2
- Asamankese** Ghana 57 E5
- Ascension island** Atlantic Ocean 49 C5
- Ascoli Piceno** Italy 78 C4
- 'Aseb** Eritrea var. **Assab** 54 D4
- Ashburton** New Zealand 133 C6
- Asheville** North Carolina, USA 31 E1
- Aşgabat capital of** Turkmenistan prev.
Ashkhabad, Poltoratsk 104 C3
- Ashkhabad** see **Aşgabat**
- Ashmore and Cartier Islands**
Australian external territory
Indian Ocean 124 A3
- Ash Shāriqah** United Arab Emirates *Eng.* Sharjah 103 D5
- Asia** 94-95 106-107
- Asmara capital of** Eritrea *Amh.* Asmera 54 C4
- Asmera** see **Asmara**
- Assab** see **'Aseb**
- As Salt** Jordan var. **Salt** 101 B5
- Assamakka** Niger 57 F2
- Assen** Netherlands 68 E2
- Assad, Lake** see **Asad, Buḥayrat al**
- As Sulayyil** Saudi Arabia 103 B6
- As Suwaydā** Syria 101 B5
- As Suways** Egypt *Eng.* Suez 54 B1
- Astana country capital** Kazakhstan prev. **Akmola**, **Akmolinsk**, **Tselinograd**, **Kaz.** **Aqmola**. 96 C4
- Astoria** Oregon, USA 26 A2
- Astrakhan** Russian Federation 93 B7
- Astypálaia island** Greece 87 D6
- Asunción capital of** Paraguay 44 B3
- Aswān** Egypt 54 B2
- Asyūt** Egypt 54 B2
- Atacama Desert desert** Chile 46 B2
- Atamyrat prev.** Kerki. Turkmenistan 104 D3
- Aṭār** Mauritania 56 C2
- Atbara** Sudan 54 C3
- Athabasca, Lake lake** Canada 19 F4
- Athens capital of** Greece **Gk.** **Athina**, prev. **Athinaí** 87 C5
- Athens** Georgia, USA 31 E2
- Athina** see **Athens**
- Athinaí** see **Athens**
- Athlone** Ireland 71 B5
- Ati** Chad 58 C3
- Atlanta** Georgia, USA 30 D2
- Atlantic City** New Jersey, USA 23 F4
- Atlantic Ocean** 48-49
- Atlantic-Indian Basin undersea feature** Indian Ocean 136 B1
- Atlantic-Indian Ridge undersea feature** Atlantic Ocean 49 D7
- Atlas Mountains mountain range** Morocco 52 C2
- Aṭ Ṭalfilāh** Jordan 101 B6

Aṭ Ṭā'if — Balabac Strait

Aṭ Ṭā'if Saudi Arabia 102 B6
Attapu Laos 119 E5
Attawapiskat Canada 20 C3
Attawapiskat river Canada 20 B3
Attu Island *island* Alaska, USA 18 A2
Auch France 73 B6
Auckland New Zealand 132 D3
Auckland Islands *island group* New Zealand 124 D5
Augsburg Germany 77 C6
Augusta Australia 129 B7
Augusta Georgia, USA 31 E2
Augusta Maine, USA 23 G2
Aurillac France 73 C5
Aurora Colorado, USA 24 D4
Aurora Illinois, USA 22 B3
Aussig see *Ústí nad Labem*
Austin Texas, USA 29 G4
Australasia 124-125
Australes, Îles *island group* French Polynesia 125 F4
Austral Fracture Zone *tectonic feature* Pacific Ocean 125 H4
Australia *country* Pacific Ocean 124
Australian Alps Australia 131 D7
Australian Capital Territory *territory* Australia *abbrev.* A.C.T. 131 D6
Austria *country* C Europe 77
Auxerre France 72 C4
Avarua *capital of* Cook Islands 127 G5
Aveiro Portugal 74 C2
Avignon France 73 D6
Ávila Spain 74 D2
Avilés Spain 74 D1
Awbārī Libya 53 F3
Axel Heiberg Island *island* Canada 19 F1
Axios see *Vardar*
Ayacucho Peru 42 B4
Aydarko'l Ko'li *lake* Uzbekistan *var.* *Aydarkül* 104 D2
Aydarkül see *Aydarko'l Ko'li*
Aydın Turkey 98 A3

Ayer's Rock see *Uluru*
Ayr Scotland, UK 70 C4
Ayutthaya Thailand 119 C5
Ayvalık Turkey 98 A3
Azaouād *desert* Mali 52 E2
A'zāz Syria 100 B2
Azerbaijan *country* SW Asia 99 G2
Azores *islands* Portugal, Atlantic Ocean 48 C3
Azov, Sea of Black Sea *Ukr.* Azovs'ke More, *Rus.* Azovskoye More 93 A6 91 G4
Azovs'ke More see *Azov, Sea of*
Azovskoye More see *Azov, Sea of*
Azul Argentina 46 D4
Azur, Côte d' *coastal region* France 73 E6
Az Zarqā' Jordan 101 B5
Az Zāwiyah Libya 53 F2

B

Baalbek Lebanon *var.* Ba'labakk 100 B4
Babeldaob *Island* Palau 124 B2
Babruysk Belarus *Rus.* Bobruysk 89 D6
Babuyan Channel *channel* Philippines 121 E1
Bacan, Pulau *island* Indonesia 121 F4
Bačka Topola Serbia 82 D3
Bacău Romania 90 C4
Badajoz Spain 74 C4
Baden Switzerland 77 E6
Bādiyat ash Shām see *Syrian Desert*
Baffin Bay *sea feature* Atlantic Ocean 48 B1
Baffin Island *island* Canada 19 G2
Bafing *river* Africa 56 C3
Bafoussam Cameroon 58 B4
Bagdad see *Baghdad*
Bagé Brazil 44 C4
Baghdad *capital of* Iraq *var.* Bagdad, *Ar.* Baghdād 102 B3
Baghdād see *Baghdad*
Baghlān Afghanistan 105 E3
Bago Myanmar *prev.* Pegu 118 B4
Baguè *river* Côte d'Ivoire/Mali 56 D4
Baguio Philippines 121 E1
Bahamas *country* West Indies, Atlantic Ocean 36
Baharden see *Baharly*
Baharly Turkmenistan *prev.* Baharden, Bāherden, Bakharden, Bakherden 104 B3
Bahāwalpur Pakistan 116 C3
Bāherden see *Baharly*
Bahía Blanca Argentina 47 C5
Bahía, Islas de la *islands* Honduras 34 D2
Bahir Dar Ethiopia 54 C4
Bahrain *country* SW Asia 103 C5
Baia Mare Romania 90 B3
Baikal, Lake see *Baykal, Ozero*
Bairiki *capital of* Kiribati 127 E2
Baishan China 110 E3
Baja Hungary 81 C7
Baja California *peninsula* Mexico *Eng.* Lower California 32 B2
Bajo Nuevo *island* Colombia 35 F2
Baker Oregon, USA 26 C3
Baker & Howland Islands *external territory* USA, Pacific Ocean 125 E2
Bakersfield California, USA 27 C7
Bakharden see *Baharly*
Bakherden see *Baharly*
Bākhtarān see *Kermānshāh*
Bakı see *Baku*
Baku *capital of* Azerbaijan *Az.* Bakı, *var.* Bakı 99 H2
Baky see *Baku*
Balabac Strait *sea feature* South China Sea/Sulu Sea 120 D2

- Ba'labakk** see Baalbek
- Balakovo** Russian Federation 93 C6
- Bälä Morghāb** Afghanistan 104 D4
- Balaton** *lake* Hungary var. Lake Balaton, Ger. Plattensee 81 C7
- Balaton, Lake** see Balaton
- Balbina, Represa Reservoir** Brazil 42 D2
- Baleares, Islas** *island group* Spain Eng. Balearic Islands 75 H3
- Balearic Islands** see Baleares, Islas
- Bali** *island* Indonesia 120 D5
- Balikesir** Turkey 98 A3
- Balikpapan** Indonesia 120 D4
- Balkanabat** Turkmenistan prev. Nebitdag 104 B2
- Balkan Mountains** *mountain range* Bulgaria Bul. Stara Planina 86 C2
- Balkhash** Kazakhstan 96 C5
- Balkhash, Lake** see Balkhash, Ozero
- Balkhash, Ozero** *lake* Kazakhstan Eng. Lake Balkhash 94 C3
- Ballarat** Australia 131 C7
- Balsas** *river* Mexico 33 E5
- Bălți** Moldova 90 D3
- Baltic Port** see Paldiski
- Baltic Sea** Atlantic Ocean 67 C7
- Baltimore** Maryland, USA 23 F4
- Baltischport** see Paldiski
- Baltiski** see Paldiski
- Bamako** *capital of* Mali 56 D3
- Bambari** Central African Republic 58 D4
- Bamenda** Cameroon 58 B4
- Banaba** *island* Kiribati prev. Ocean Island 127 E2
- Bandaaceh** Indonesia 120 A3
- Banda, Laut** see Banda Sea
- Banda Sea** *sea feature* Pacific Ocean Ind. Laut Banda 121 F4
- Bandar-e 'Abbās** Iran 102 D4
- Bandar-e Büshehr** Iran 102 C4
- Bandar Lampung** Indonesia prev. Tanjungkarang 120 C4
- Bandar Seri Begawan** *capital of* Brunei 120 D3
- Bandon** Oregon, USA 26 A3
- Bandundu** Dem. Rep. Congo 59 C6
- Bandung** Indonesia 120 C5
- Bangalore** India 114 D2
- Banggai, Kepulauan** *island group* Indonesia 121 E4
- Banghāzi** Libya Eng. Benghazi 53 G2
- Bangka, Palau** *island* Indonesia 120 C4
- Bangkok** *capital of* Thailand Th. Krung Thep 119 C5
- Bangladesh** *country* S Asia 117
- Bangor** Northern Ireland, UK 71 B5
- Bangor** Maine, USA 23 G2
- Bangui** *capital of* Central African Republic 59 C5
- Bani** *river* Mali 56 D3
- Bani Suwayf** Egypt var. Beni Suef 54 B1
- Banja Luka** Bosnia & Herzegovina 82 B3
- Banjarmasin** Indonesia 120 D4
- Banjul** *capital of* Gambia 56 B3
- Banks Island** *island* Canada 19 E2
- Banks Islands** *island group* Vanuatu, Pacific Ocean 126 D4
- Banks Peninsula** *peninsula* New Zealand 133 C6
- Banks Strait** *sea feature* Tasman Sea 131 C7
- Banská Bystrica** Slovakia Ger. Neusohl, Hung. Besztercebánya 81 C6
- Bantry Bay** *sea feature* Ireland 71 A6
- Banyo** Cameroon 58 B4
- Banzare Seamounts** *undersea feature* Indian Ocean 123 C7
- Baotou** China 109 F3
- Baranavichy** Belarus Rus. Baranovichy, Pol. Baranowicz 89 C6
- Baranovichi** see Baranavichy
- Baranowicz** see Baranavichy
- Barbados** *country* West Indies 37 H4
- Barbuda** *island* Antigua & Barbuda 37 G3
- Barcaldine** Australia 130 C4
- Barcelona** Spain 75 G2
- Barcelona** Venezuela 41 E1
- Barcolod** *City* Philippines 121 E2
- Bareilly** India 117 E3
- Barentsburg** Svalbard 65 F2
- Barentsøya** *island* Svalbard 65 G2
- Barents Sea** Arctic Ocean 137 H5
- Bari** Italy 79 E5
- Barinas** Venezuela 40 D2
- Barisan, Pegunungan** *mountains* Indonesia 120 B4
- Barly Tableland** *plateau* Australia 130 B3
- Barlavento, Ilhas de** *island group* Cape Verde var. Windward Islands 56 A2
- Bar-le-Duc** France 72 D3
- Barlee, Lake** *lake* Australia 129 B5
- Barlee Range** *mountain range* Australia 128 B4
- Barnaui** Russian Federation 96 D4
- Barnstaple** England, UK 71 C7
- Barquisimeto** Venezuela 40 D1
- Barra** *island* Scotland, UK 70 B3
- Barranquilla** Colombia 40 B1
- Barrier Range** *mountain range* Australia 131 C5
- Barrow** *river* Ireland 71 B6
- Barstow** California, USA 27 C7
- Bartang** *river* Tajikistan 105 F3
- Bartica** Guyana 41 G2
- Baruun-Urt** Mongolia 109 F2
- Barwon River** *river* Australia 131 D5
- Barysaw** Belarus Rus. Borisov 89 D5
- Basarabearca** Moldova 90 D4
- Basel** Switzerland 77 B6
- Basra** see Al Baṣrah